

PERMANENT SCARS

I Knocked on the Door and Hell Reign'd In



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Preface

“Writing is magic, as much the water of life as any other creative art. The water is free. So, drink. Drink and be filled up.”

-Stephen King

"I do not carry such information in my mind since it is readily available in books. The value of a college education is not the learning of many facts but the training of the mind to think."

-Albert Einstein

“The more sensitive you are, the more certain you are...”

-Marlon Brando

“Bipolar 1 should be called a brain disorder.”

-Marlene Cordero, MD

No AI was used in the writing of this novel, other than to assist with the copyediting.

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Part 1: The Beginning

Oto was 14-months old.

He calmly stood up and walked across the large room without falling.

Ana, his mom, couldn't understand it, unless somehow, he was practicing on his own in his crib, and surely that wasn't possible.

When he was four-years-old, Oto had a dream that hairy monsters would grab him.

They would always take him underneath his bed, down to what seemed like hell, to torture him.

One night in real life, Oto was going to sleep, and in a dream, he picked up a baseball bat.

When the hairy creatures tried to grab him in his dream, he beat the hell out of them, as they surrounded him in his bedroom.

The monsters never came back for him again.

Oto was five-years-old, and he was already saving pennies and nickels in a plastic Pinocchio from the top shelf in his bedroom.

When he reached up to grab the "bank", he was standing on the bottom shelf, reaching up to the toy that contained all the coins he had managed to save up.

The top shelf couldn't support his weight.

The bottom shelf fell off its brackets, and he fell onto his bed below, but not before yelling out in pain as the top shelf crashed down onto his bed.

Before landing on his bed, the shelf hit him right above his left eye.

To this day at the age of 40 he can still see the scar.

Oto was five-years-old when he caught his first small trout in a stream with nothing but a short fishing line that was tied to a long stick, and a hook with a bloody worm impaled on it.

He pulled the small fighting fish out of the stream, and it landed on the river bank.

When his stepdad took the fish home, he showed Oto how to bash its brains out on a rock, gutting the small limp trout by ripping out its organs.

They then fried up the delicious trout meat and devoured it together.

Chapter 1: The Crash

Oto was 11 years old on that beautiful Spring Day in May in Georgia when his stepdad crashed his Pitt's Special into the ground due to exhaustion (not suicide). He was practicing to be featured in the Georgia State Fair, but he flew cargo jets for Hawaiian Airlines. Oto felt guilty because he had a love/hate relationship with his stepdad.

Oto stepped off the bus, driven by an old lady with purple hair, and into the warm sunshine. He opened the front door to the house when the yellow phone on the wall began to ring. He picked it up, and his good friend Nolon was already quickly talking before Oto even got the receiver to his ear.

"Oto, your dad crashed his Pitt's Special in the field across from my house."

There was a slight pause on the phone.

"I ran over and in the cockpit your dad was slumped down in the seat."

Oto wasn't sure that he was actually hearing the words coming from Nolon.

"There was a piece of metal sticking out from his head and his brains were dripping down into his lap."

Oto dropped the rotary dial receiver and ran to the nearby garage, and opened it.

The Pitt's Special wasn't there, and Oto hadn't seen his stepdad for weeks. He suddenly felt like vomiting, as he raced back and hung up the phone on Nolon.

Oto walked into the living room and looked out the large windows facing the front of the house.

He saw with horror several cars pulling up into the driveway and couldn't look away as they parked and people he didn't know got out of their cars.

He opened the front door right before a man and a woman he had never seen before were about to knock.

They asked him if his mom was there, and one man whispered to the woman not to tell him that his dad was dead.

It wasn't long before strangers filled the living room, and Oto knew for sure now that what Nolon had described to him was true.

He sat in the living room feeling guilty because he couldn't cry.

He remembered how his stepdad began building the motor for the bi-plane in their garage back in Michigan, when the icicles were so long in the winter that he would use a snowball to break them off and eat them like an ice cream cone.

He also remembered how months earlier, in the living room, his stepdad had been taping the wings of the bi-plane that he later painted out in the garage.

Other memories started flooding in on Oto.

He walked out the front door and saw his mom, Ana, in the car, pulling into the driveway. She had just come back from a shift of waitressing at a fancy burger restaurant.

In slow motion, he saw his mom park the car and look the stranger that Oto had never seen before right into her eyes. Oto thought he heard the woman whisper something to his mom.

Ana yelled out in what seemed like pain, and it was the most god-awful sound Oto had ever heard in his life.

She burst into tears before screaming once or twice more.

Oto walked back into the garage and saw his model airplane with broken wings lying on the ground in the corner.

His stepdad had walked him through every step to create the masterpiece, and it was a model, much like the Pitt's Special, in a way, with stretched cloth for the wings and a small gas tank that held high-end fuel.

The plane had two wires and a handle attached to it, and on a winter day in Georgia, his stepdad had started up the little engine by putting pressure on the propeller.

His stepdad stood in the field where he usually started his own Pitt's Special from, turning the speeding model plane around in circles, flipping the loud toy upside down by maneuvering the handle in his hand.

The plane moved up and down with a slow rhythm that mesmerized Oto. His stepdad asked him to step in close and join him in the circle, smiling as he handed off the loud plane to him.

Oto panicked, quickly crashing the small plane into the grass, breaking the wings in half.

The day of the funeral arrived, and Oto was so happy riding in the limousine.

Due to the state of his stepdad's body, he was told by Ana that it would be a closed coffin.

Oto was laughing at the police escort that, for some reason, was blazing a trail for them in the limousine, even though it disturbed his mom.

He had never been in a limousine before, and he couldn't believe how the motorcycles with men in uniform providing the escort would pull up to red lights, rev their engines, and stop cars before speeding their shiny motorcycles through the intersection.

It wasn't long before they arrived at the big funeral hall that was filled with people.

Oto sat off to the side next to his uncle, whom he had once watched The Wizard of Oz with.

The two things he could remember about his uncle were how, at Denny's, he flirted with the waitresses and could use a fork to catapult a spoon into a jar of jelly.

He also recalled how his uncle was running once in the Arizona desert and ran into a sequoia cactus, screaming out in pain as the needles pierced his skin.

Oto listened to the music drifting around him, back near that closed coffin. Finally, he let go, and the tears rushed over him in waves.

Later that night, Oto tried to go to sleep. He remembered all of the different memories of his stepdad.

As he shifted around in his bunkbed, he recalled the times when he felt like he hated him.

Once he had found some matches. He tried to burn a dead bird on the ground to give it a mini funeral, but the nearby field caught on fire.

He jumped up and rode his bike away from the flames.

Luckily, a nearby neighbor had been mowing his field with a big riding lawnmower.

The old neighbor drove over in the lawnmower, and mowed a fire line that prevented the flames from spreading to the nearby houses.

The news traveled fast in the small community where he lived.

As Oto pumped the pedals on his bike, the muscles in his legs started burning, and they felt heavy as he rode home.

Somehow, his stepdad had already heard about the field.

As Oto opened the front door, he saw with horror his stepdad standing there waiting for him.

He had a smile on his face and a dark black belt in his hands.

Oto was ordered to bend over as his stepdad whipped him with it over-and-over again.

By some fortunate amount of luck, Oto had a wallet in his back pocket, so the blows didn't hurt so bad.

His stepdad figured that out and ordered Oto to unzip his pants and drop them with his underwear to the ground.

The lashes then left deep red marks, and the pain was intense. Just like when he had crashed the toy plane that Oto had built with his stepdad, the tears now flowed down Oto's cheeks.

Back in his bunkbed Oto cried, remembering the intense pain from that day.

Just like when the toy wings had broken in half, he was so upset with himself, but he managed to smile before he went to sleep.

It was at least a year before the funeral that Oto lay out in the dry grass near the runway that was not far beyond the trees on the property of their house in Georgia.

He loved watching his stepdad in the Pitt's Special way up in the clouds, spinning and diving in his bi-plane before stalling out and pitching the plane straight down toward the runway, before buzzing the small field, shaking the ground that he was lying on.

On one of those passes, his stepdad flipped the loud bi-plane upside down, flying close to the ground before soaring back up to the clouds.

That was the day that Oto broke his arm playing football with the neighbors, not far from where he had burned the field to give the poor dead bird his own funeral.

For some reason he thought he could cremate the beautiful, unmoving wings.

Oto was one of the youngest players on the line, where he was playing as a wide receiver.

He only knew what he had been told.

He was supposed to run out and catch a football and make it into the pretend end zone.

He never forgot what happened next.

He managed to catch the ball that was a perfect spiral from his friend.

He then sprinted toward what he thought was the end zone, and his legs were pumping so fast he couldn't feel them.

One of the older kids ran faster than him and slid into Oto's legs, sending him down so hard onto the field that he had the wind knocked out of him.

Not wanting to cry and be called a sissy, Oto jumped back onto his feet, but his right arm was tingling.

Oto shook his tingling arm, thinking the fall had just bruised it. But it wasn't long before the bone in his right wrist snapped and was scraping against the inside of his skin.

There wasn't any blood, but Oto went immediately into shock and was transported by his friend's mom quickly to the hospital.

Since his stepdad was up in his plane and his mom was shopping in a nearby town, he couldn't be treated for the intense pain.

He did remember lying on a gurney in the hallway of the hospital, drifting in and out of consciousness for a couple of hours until his mom finally showed up.

He was given a shot in his exposed butt and didn't remember much after that.

Given the compound break in his wrist, Oto had to be rushed off to the emergency room.

But first he watched as the needle sank into the same right arm to pull out the blood that they needed to use for the surgery.

He recalled being up in a cold room with bright lights as a doctor looked at him and told him to count backwards starting at 10. Oto didn't make it past 7.

He later woke up in the same cold room alone and looked around, but nobody was there.

He noticed the hard white cast that started on his fingers and ran all the way up just underneath his right shoulder.

He was later put into a separate room, and his mom looked down at him with some tears in her eyes, watching a nurse tie his cast down to the bed, where Oto would later fight to go to sleep.

It was eventually morning and the cuff was removed from his cast, but he cried out loud when noticing how his favorite shirt, cut in half, was hanging from his neck.

On the way back home, his mom stopped to get donuts.

Oto looked up and just happened to see the Blue Angels ripping through the air with a speed and sound that amazed him.

His friends met him back at the house.

He was shocked to find out that he was now a hero.

They all signed his cast with a Sharpie as they munched on the donuts.

The cast stayed on his right arm for six months, and at school, he had to learn how to write with his left hand, which was not easy to do.

He did manage to figure it out, though, and eventually he went back to the same hospital where he had the surgery so many months before.

The doctor came in, cutting off the cast, and asked him to put his arm up on a “table” where the X Ray would happen.

Oto was telling his arm to move, but the muscles couldn’t respond after so many months of non-use.

The results of the X Ray showed that Oto’s bones had healed.

The doctor gave him a small black ball that he was told to squeeze over-and-over to build the muscles back.

It hurt like hell whenever he used it, which wasn’t often.

It was a few weeks after Oto’s right arm and wrist were completely healed.

He couldn't believe that one afternoon he opened the garage door, only to see a new minibike that his stepdad gave him as a gift.

There was a red bow stuck onto the handle bars of the minibike that simply said, "Don't crash."

Like the model airplane, Oto was afraid to ride the minibike at first, but his stepdad explained how to use it.

Unlike with the toy plane that Oto had slammed into the grass on that Spring Day, he wasn't scared this time.

It wasn't long before Oto was racing up and down the road on his new minibike outside their home in the street that was almost always empty.

He found the narrow trails in the nearby woods and raced through them, yelling out at the top of his lungs.

When they lived in Michigan, one year before moving to Georgia, his stepdad came home one day with a BB gun.

Oto was lectured about how he had to be so careful and never shoot any animal or anyone.

He set up the targets in the basement, practicing for weeks until he could hit the middle of the target most every time.

He learned how to load the BB's into the small gun, but he felt a little guilty when he broke his promise once they were living in Georgia.

There were lots of squirrels in the woods, and he shot them from a long distance away.

The BB's never penetrated the skin of the jumping squirrels, but he couldn't help but notice how it hurt them.

They would quickly jump from branch-to-branch scrambling to try and dodge the small BB's that would whiz by them.

One time Oto was shooting some squirrels high up in the trees out in the woods behind his house.

His best friend was beside him, and he had a pellet gun that he would pump up and then kill the squirrels, watching as they dropped to the ground before he picked them up and bashed their heads on nearby rocks.

His good friend showed Oto how to skin the dead squirrels.

He would then rip out their guts, dropping them into a plastic bag.

They tied up the bubbly warm bag and swung it around.

Somehow, they managed to get the bag to “sit” upon on a nearby power line that ran across the road from his house.

They used the rotting bag full of hot guts as target practice as flies buzzed around it.

Oto and his friend hid behind a nearby tree and couldn’t believe it when a car drove under the bag, and it somehow dropped onto the windshield.

The car immediately lurched to a stop as the warm blood was wiped away by moving windshield wipers.

They ran as fast as they could back into the woods and never saw the car or the driver again.

Two weeks after the funeral, Oto decided to go back to school, even though he didn’t have to because there were only a few weeks left before summer break.

The old yellow school bus turned around in the cul-de-sac near Oto’s home, and the brakes squealed as it stopped outside.

Oto recognized that awful sound as he sat on the couch in the living room.

He grabbed his books and hurried outside, boarding the bus to take the one-hour trek to school.

It was the last day of school, and he had been up late the night before, working and reworking a poem that he wrote about his stepdad’s death.

The poem wasn’t too long, and he wasn’t confident that it was even a poem.

He had written it down on an 8x5 piece of paper, and was sure to stay inside the lines with his black pen.

Once he was sitting safely in his seat, he took out the poem on paper, reading it many times over-and-over before arriving at his elementary school.

After pulling up to the curb, Oto stepped off the bus and into the morning sun.

As Oto went through the doors to his class, he ran into Nolon who had called him that day on the phone. Nolon had dropped his math book onto the floor, so Oto picked it up for him.

Their first class was English, and Oto was nervous, and made sure again that he had his poem ready.

As soon as it was his turn, he stood up and was shaking as he did his best to keep the paper still.

He launched into his first line and the once noisy class went silent.

It only took him a few minutes to get through it before he sat back down.

His heart was pounding, and he stuttered a little on the second line because he was so nervous.

The last line of his poem ended with the line, “and his brains were dripping down into his lap.”

Once he was safely sitting back in his seat, he was surprised to see all of his classmates staring at him without making a sound.

As Oto stepped off the bus and into his yard after reading his poem in class, and also playing his snare drum with his good friend Nolon, he was enjoying sitting out on the front porch. This would be the very last day that he would attend his school in Georgia.

The next morning, they would all be in a car, heading across the country and to California, which he wasn't sure if he was looking forward to or not.

It just so happened to be the last day that he would write a poem until he was 17 years-old.

The next morning arrived soon enough, and Oto sat in the back seat in their maroon station wagon.

He didn't even mind not sitting in the passenger seat that was occupied by his mom's good friend Enne.

Enne had flown out to join them and help drive across the country from Georgia to California.

It was hot and muggy in the car, and the air conditioning barely reached Oto in the back seat.

He had been given a Rubik's cube by his stepdad the Christmas before the crash, along with a small "manual" that had some hints on how to solve it.

The trip would take many days, and he was so focused on solving the "puzzle" that he even managed to ignore his sister sitting next to him most of the time.

They would, of course, make many stops along the way, staying in motels and eating in the cheapest restaurants they could find.

Oto was so absorbed in his Rubik's cube that he managed to shut the world out around him.

He even managed to let his sister shove him to the side now and then to keep him from crossing the invisible line that she had drawn in the hot back seat of the car.

Somehow, he solved the Rubik's cube before they arrived at his grandparent's house in California.

He really couldn't recall what happened to it.

But it was the last time he picked one up.

He couldn't even guess how many of those plastic squares he had turned over-and-over until all of the colors lined up.

Oto had plenty of time to just think as they made their way across the U.S.

He had not told anyone that he saw the wrecked plane twisted on sitting on a large trailer in a nearby driveway on the afternoon of the plane crash when his stepdad was killed in his Pitts Special.

Chapter 2: Down Swing

Oto was 17-years-old and it was his senior year in high school when his first downswing, from what would later be called Bipolar 1, hit him like a ton of bricks.

Within a couple of months, he had lost 40 pounds and could barely walk to the bathroom to take a piss and brush his teeth.

His brain seemed to be fighting itself, and whatever was happening hit his dilapidated body with full force.

Oto instinctually taught himself how to meditate and do deep breathing exercises.

Although the anxiety ripped through every part of his body, he could somehow read Isaac Asimov books — the Foundation series.

He had what was called a bipolar down swing, but he wouldn't know about that for many months to come.

Oto went from a 3.90 GPA and lettering in two sports, to dropping out of high school from a nervous breakdown, which was the last thing that he wanted to do.

At his high school around the corner, believe it or not, all of his teachers worked together, trying to finish what is the equivalent to a senior project at many universities.

Oto could barely make it to the bathroom down the hall to drink well water out of the sink, and crawl onto the toilet to piss.

He was weaker than he had ever been in his life and he had no idea why.

It was like having the flu that would never go away.

Oto just kept doing the breathing exercises, focusing on his toes and all throughout his body, but the anxiety never seemed to let up for very long.

As he lay there looking up at the ceiling he thought of his stepdad who had crashed his plane.

Back then he recalled how it was in May when he was 11, and how it was May again, but 6 years later.

He never focused too much on dates, other than birthday's of course, but he could feel how it was Spring again.

This time of year, for some reason made him a little nervous, but never anything like how he was feeling now.

Oto's biological dad had divorced his mom when he was 4-years-old and had abandoned Oto for the most part.

His Dad was an alcoholic and Oto only saw him a few weeks every few years.

But last summer when Oto had visited him for some reason things were different.

His dad purchased a three-wheeler, gas-motored vehicle.

Oto loved racing it out back in the Arizona "wash," which was a large dry desert that would fill up when there were massive rain storms.

Now in Nevada, there was so much sagebrush everywhere he looked, which reminded Oto of Arizona.

In Arizona, however, that is the type of heat that when you spray water on your skin it instantly bubbles up like little blisters all over your arms and legs.

He also thought about how both sides of his family knew how to keep secrets.

Because of this, Oto couldn't know that his uncle on his dad's side of the family had Bipolar 1, which is what would later prevent Oto and his doctor's from knowing how to treat the illness.

Two days had passed since Oto had been thinking about his biological dad.

He had a stabbing pain in his stomach that he had never felt before.

He managed to get out into his 1978 Volkswagen Rabbit to drive himself down to the local doctor's office.

He was still in his down-swing and his brain was crippled, but he managed to get there.

The doctor instructed him to lay flat on the table that was covered with that tissue-like paper.

On the walls of the office that he was ushered into hung paintings of old cowboys sitting around a campfire eating cooked beans.

Just the thought of cooked beans almost made him throw up.

The doctor instructed Oto to lay down on the table and gently pushed in on his appendix.

Oto nearly jumped off the table, howling in pain.

He felt a burning pain in his side where his appendix was located, and tears and snot started running down his face.

Ana had raised her son Oto as best she could. She had two other daughters and another son after all.

She was working down at the county courthouse in a small agricultural community somewhere in Nevada.

The phone rang at her small office inside the courthouse where she worked.

She answered it only to hear the town doctor, a woman's voice, on the other end.

"Ana, get over here right away. Your son Oto needs an emergency appendectomy and I think it may burst so you need to get him to an emergency room as soon as possible."

Ana grabbed her purse and fumbled for the keys, almost sprinting toward the old blue blazer that ran on diesel fuel.

She raced over to the doctor's office, nearly running an old woman hobbling across the intersection down.

The woman screamed at her and just barely made it across the street.

Ana just kept saying to herself, "Dear God, don't let my son die."

Ana made it to the doctor's office and once inside she saw the doctor helping her son get his shirt back on.

He was blowing his nose and wiping his eyes on a few tissues.

She saw his bony torso in the bright lights from the nearby lamps.

She usually didn't have to worry too much about Oto, but this time it was different.

Oto managed to get into the car. "Hold on, Oto!" Ana said as gently as she could.

She left the doctor in the dust, so to speak, and said to herself, "I gotta get him to the hospital."

She wasn't sure if she was going 85 or 90 mph, but she did know she got him to the far away hospital in the city in one hour rather than the ninety minutes it usually took.

Somehow, to her surprise, she didn't get pulled over by any cops.

The blue Blazer was belching out diesel fumes that Oto could have sworn he could smell as he lay in the back seat.

The pain in his appendix was unbearable, and at every small bump, the seat would shake and he would moan out loud in pain.

They arrived at the hospital and Ana ran in to the emergency room yelling for help from the first nurse that she saw; a man wearing white scrubs.

She didn't know it but the doctor from the town she lived in had called ahead.

A team of doctors grabbed Oto out of the back of the car and put him in a wheel chair, racing to get Oto to be prepped for surgery.

"Hold on, Oto," she whispered. "God isn't about to send you to the next life if I can help it."

Oto was quickly pushed in a wheel chair at great speed through the hallways of the cold white hospital with all of the typical sights and sounds.

The “team” of doctors were prepped and ready to roll.

The only problem was that when the doctor pressed in on Oto’s appendix, he experienced no pain.

The doctor expected Oto to yell out loud, but when he pushed even harder on his stomach there was no reaction from Oto at all.

The doctor was baffled, and so he did a pin prick on Oto’s finger.

After getting the results from the drop of blood yanked from Oto’s finger, he just looked at Ana and said, “Your son’s glucose level is way too high.”

He took Ana aside and whispered to her.

“Your son may have diabetes, but we need to run some tests to make sure. You and your son should go and get some air and come back later.”

Ana thanked God for granting her prayers and was so relieved she stopped at the McDonald’s drive-thru.

She purchased her son a large vanilla shake that he quickly sucked down.

Since they had an hour or so to kill, she drove over to a nearby library.

She asked the librarian where to find an illustrated book about diabetes.

Oto and his mom found a small couch, sitting down together as they looked through the book.

He gave his mom a baffled look as he saw a photo of a stomach and a needle.

You see, he was afraid of needles and almost fainted thinking about pushing one into his own stomach several times a day.

Ana finished looking at the pages about the needles, which honestly made her feel queasy.

She put the book back up on the shelf, looked at the time, and they got into the car, driving back to the hospital.

After parking in the giant lot near the emergency room, they made their way back into the doctor's office.

The specialist looked at his mom and said, "Well, I don't know how to tell you this. His glucose level is a little high, but nothing too outside the normal levels."

Ana and Oto were both looking at the doctor in confusion.

Oto was so relieved to hear he didn't have diabetes, but he just wanted something to be wrong with him.

At least then whatever that was killing him could be treated.

The thought of going back to the unknown hit him right in the gut and he began to cry again.

He was relieved of course as they left the cold hospital behind.

Ana parked the car in the real estate parking lot, leaving Oto out in the Blazer in the hot sun.

She walked into her office only to be told that the sale of the house that she had listed had fallen out of escrow due to the seller committing suicide on his front steps.

She was actually in the office for over fifteen minutes and then she remembered that her poor son was out in the hot car.

She walked quickly back to the Blazer, driving Oto back to the small town where they lived.

She helped get him into the house and onto the old couch in the family room.

"Oto, you know where the bathroom is. You must need to use it."

Oto was fumbling around in the bathroom. As he sat on the toilet, he looked in the mirror and saw his sagging body.

He didn't know if he had a tumor or how on earth, he could lose 40 pounds in such a short amount of time.

Not long ago Oto was playing on the high school football team.

He was running several miles back then, but now he barely had enough energy to brush his teeth.

He was pretty sure he was going to die from something, and the doctors had no idea what was wrong with him.

Anna wasn't sure what to do next.

She looked at her son in his bed and tried hard not to break down in tears.

She was a Christian and was praying to God for guidance, but she was constantly worried about her son.

She decided the best thing to do would be to drive Oto to talk with their pastor.

After all, throughout her tough life she would talk to her pastor when she was facing something that was challenging her.

The drive to the church would take an hour or so.

She helped her son back into the car again, and they soon arrived in the church parking lot.

Ana got out of the car, helping her gaunt son out into the bright sunlight.

Oto walked into the dark church, trying to see what was around him.

He was having trouble seeing around the quiet church with nothing but empty pews to greet him.

His mom gently told him to follow her, so they proceeded to a door at the front of the church and she knocked on it.

Her pastor slowly opened the door and asked them both to enter, but the pastor wanted to talk alone with Oto.

Ana waited out in the empty church, sitting down in an empty pew to give them some privacy.

As Oto took a seat across from him, the pastor that confirmed him a few years before, began asking him a bunch of questions.

His anxiety was so acute that later when Oto was back in the car, he didn't remember much about the meeting.

He couldn't shake the one memory, though.

"Oto, I have known you for several years. Look me in the eyes, son," the pastor had said.

Oto did as he was asked, since the man sitting across from him was in touch with God.

"Oto, have you ever had sex before? I don't mean just kissing, but actually having sex?"

Oto just looked down at the floor in front of him.

He wished he was back out in the hot car.

Oto couldn't speak, so he just nodded instead.

On the long ride back home, Oto watched the road that was a blur.

He had no idea why he was going to die, but he began to cry.

He now knew he was going straight to hell.

Oto knew for sure, of course, that being burned alive in hell forever was not something that he wanted.

He also knew from confirmation with his pastor, that he was going straight to hell for having sex without being married.

It was a few days after Oto had made his embarrassing confession to his pastor when Ana told him they were going to see a psychiatrist.

This really scared him, because he really knew nothing at all about what a psychiatrist did, or what it would be like to talk to him.

After another long drive in the Blazer, they pulled up and parked in a small space near a medical building.

After waiting for what seemed like an hour, but was really five minutes, Oto was ushered into a small office with a chair and a couch.

Oto sat down in the chair and his mom left the room.

He just stared at the man who was sitting behind a desk in front of him.

Just like with the pastor a few days before, Oto had been told by his mom that he needed to be truthful and answer every single question as best he could.

The main difference was that in this case there were what looked like hundreds of books on some shelves behind the doctor.

Oto was asked to count backwards by increments of seven from one hundred to zero.

That was so easy for Oto that he quickly finished the task.

The doctor also asked Oto a lot of questions to test his memory, and he actually enjoyed the discussion with this doctor.

Oto listened to a story about some boy in a red wagon and all sorts of details that he had to then think about, answering the questions that he was asked.

After probing Oto and hearing his story, the psychiatrist prescribed anti-anxiety pills.

He called in the prescription and told Ana that it would be the best thing to help her son.

Ana asked him about the pills, and after telling her about them, Ana and Oto stood up to leave the doctor's office, but he took Ana aside.

"We won't know for sure until Oto here has been taking the pills for a week or two, but they should lessen his anxiety and help him gain a little bit of weight, given how much he has already lost," he said.

In front of both Ana and Oto the doctor explained that the best diagnosis he could come up with was that Oto had been perfect.

Oto listened to this and tried not to laugh.

"Ana, I don't know exactly what has happened to your son. But clearly, he has failed recently at something."

She looked at the doctor and then at her son.

At this point she was willing to believe almost anything, but that didn't seem to describe what was happening to her son.

"Surely there must be something other than this to explain what is happening to my son?"

The doctor explained how he would need a lot more appointments to try and get to the bottom of it, and he had his receptionist schedule another appointment in two weeks.

Ana and Oto left the doctor's office and drove over to a nearby pharmacy, filling the prescription of what was called Zyprexa.

She didn't read what the brand or dosage was, but decided that it was worth a try.

At the pharmacy Ana went to the line where the pharmacist could go over the new medication with her.

"Your son should take one pill in the morning with food and beverages and then also one in the evening. He shouldn't take them on an empty stomach though."

From that day forward, Oto took the shiny pills that Ana would place into his out-stretched hand, morning and night.

She called the psychiatrist several times a week, and she did see a very small change in Oto, but nothing that would console her for very long.

Oto would still spend most of his time in his bed.

He would look up at the ceiling, but now he was able to focus much better on his deep breathing exercises.

Still, for a lot of the time, he had no appetite.

Ana, like her son, was losing track of what day it was and she herself was also having trouble eating.

Unlike him, of course, she had only lost a pound or two.

She was pretty sure only a week had passed when she finally got ahold of the psychiatrist on the phone.

“Ana,” he said. “How is your son doing?”

Ana wanted to throw the phone across the room, but she took a deep breath before saying, “He doesn’t seem to be a whole lot better, although yesterday he ate a piece of toast and drank about half a glass of milk.

There was nothing but silence on the other end of the line, and Ana fought to keep control of herself.

“Ana, I can clear about fifteen minutes in my schedule for you and Oto, but it has to be at 2:45 pm tomorrow.”

At this point Ana didn’t even hesitate before agreeing to that fifteen-minute slot.

Ana arrived with her son back at the psychiatrist’s office, feeling like she had just been there.

She sat down in the chair outside the doctor’s office, and waited again as the psychiatrist ushered her son into his office and gently closed the door.

After fifteen minutes had passed the psychiatrist came out of the office with Oto next to him. He asked Oto to sit in the chair, and had Ana come into his office.

In the last two minutes before he had to see his next patient he quickly explained to Ana, once the door was closed, what in his opinion was the best option.

He told her how there was a hospital nearby that could help her son, but she needed to go over there right now without even going home.

He explained to her that a bed had just become available, and she had to take Oto over to that hospital right away before someone else took the slot.

It was one of those times that she just reacted.

Ana got back into the car with her son and drove straight over to the hospital after getting the address from the receptionist.

Chapter 3: Locked Up

As Ana drove Oto to the “facility” she tried to be brave, and felt this was the only way her son could get the help that he needed.

Checking into the hospital took a couple of hours, and as she filled out paperwork attached to a clipboard, she looked over at her son now and then.

Oto sat on a brown couch, staring at some other “patients” that were also being checked in.

It only felt to Oto like a couple of minutes had passed by, but actually it was much closer to two hours.

After all of the paperwork had been processed, Ana and Oto were taken into a small office where another psychiatrist was looking out the window.

“Oh, hello there,” the man said.

He proceeded to explain to Ana how Oto would be shown to his room that he would share with one roommate.

He told her about how he recommended that Oto stay in the facility for seven days so they could better evaluate him and how the medication was working for him.

“Don’t worry, we will take good care of him. We will give him all sorts of tests, and he can participate in group therapy. We will then have a much better picture of how Oto is doing and recommend further treatment for him after the week is up.”

Oto listened to this exchange and he felt like he was going to collapse. He began crying and begging his mom to not leave him in this hospital.

“Mom, surely you aren’t going to leave me in here?”

“Son, I don’t think we have any other choice. You can get the help you need in here, at least that is what we hope will happen.”

“Mom, please, I can just go home with you and I promise I will keep taking the pills so I can get better,” he said.

“Oto, I am sorry, but that isn’t helping all that much and we need you to get the help you need to get better, son.”

Oto was still crying, but he didn’t have too much time to beg his mom any further, because a large male nurse dressed in white arrived, joining them in the doctor’s office.

“Oto,” the nurse said, “follow me and I will show you where you will be staying.”

Before leaving, he hugged his mom, and she watched him leave with the nurse.

Ana was worried, but she was at the point where she just needed Oto to get better, and the new medication had helped him a good deal.

Oto was told to sit down at a table and was given a booklet with what turned out to be 360 questions and a small Scantron with bubbles to fill in with a pencil.

He was told that he had to be monitored as he took the new medication.

The one thing he did notice was that he wasn’t feeling as much anxiety as he did before.

In fact, his appetite was returning and he was beginning to eat a little bit more every day, and he definitely had a lot more energy.

He in fact felt more relaxed and calmer than he had in months.

The questionnaire, however, caused him great anxiety.

Just when he was beginning to feel better, he struggled a lot with the questions he was told to answer.

There were questions he read over and over, about torturing animals, and whether or not he wanted to harm himself.

Each time they would ask the question a certain way, and then Oto was constantly reading ahead, because he couldn’t honestly remember how he had answered similar ones.

He was becoming more and more worried about how he had answered a question, so he would start back at the beginning and erase what seemed more like errors.

He would very slowly fill in a bubble on the paper with his pencil, and after an hour when he counted them, he thought maybe there were twenty to thirty that he had finished.

At that point one of the “nurses” came up from behind him and grabbed the questionnaire away.

It was like lifting an incredible weight off of Oto’s shoulders.

“This isn’t going to be a valid test, so let’s try again in a day or two,” the nurse said.

Although it was maybe two in the afternoon on the same day as the Scantron test, that the nurse came back with some food.

The nurse showed Oto to the table where he could eat his lunch.

He sat at a table that was empty at the time, but he saw other patients walking around.

A plastic tray was put in front of him.

He was then able to eat some strawberry Jello and cold French fries.

That evening before he was shown to his room to sleep for the night, Oto was able to watch some TV.

He watched a special news alert that showed a bus that had crashed into a rushing river.

The reporter on the TV was explaining that seventeen passengers had drowned in the cold churning water, but somehow the driver and the rest of them got out in time.

He wasn’t positive, but he was pretty sure that it was the same river where he used to catch trout and fry them up in a skillet.

He smiled as he remembered how the bones of the small trout liquified from the sizzling heat.

After cutting off the head and tail of the fish, he could eat them all, like warm fishy fries.

Oto was only hospitalized for a one-week hold, but it seemed like a year to him.

Although Ana was unable to see Oto, she did visit the hospital, giving one of the nurses a bag of candy that was delivered to him, along with a book or two.

Oto's "bunk mate" was an 80-year-old man who stole Oto's candy in the middle of the night.

Oto woke up and saw him walking back to his bed with the candy.

He hopped out of bed and yelled at him, yanking the bag of candy away from the old man.

The man then shuffled with his gown dragging loosely on the floor behind him.

He walked right up to the sink that they shared and began peeing in it with a strange smile on his face.

Later, Oto felt sorry for the old guy, because the hearing aid that he wore made terrible screeching sounds at night and the old man would yell out in pain.

This prevented Oto from sleeping, but a nurse never showed up to help him.

Oto found it hard to go to sleep with the nurses laughing out in the hall.

He wasn't sure, but he thought they were laughing about the pain his bunkmate was in, and it didn't matter because they never came in to help him.

In group therapy, there was a 17-year-old girl with blonde hair and a fit body with tight jeans, wearing a white t-shirt.

Oto looked at the scars all over her right arm, along with the bandages that she said were from fresh wounds on her left forearm.

The young girl looked down at her feet, before continuing on with her story.

She explained to the small group that she had bulimia.

She talked about how she would sneak downstairs in the two-story house and quietly open the refrigerator in the middle of the night, making sure she didn't wake her mom up.

She said she could feel the hunger in the pit of her stomach and how it was something she had to fill up.

She would grab all of the food that she could carry and quickly walk up the steps back to her bedroom.

She would carefully arrange all of the food on her bed before eating it as quickly as she could.

She explained, however, that she was still careful about it all, and didn't leave a single bit of food on her sheets.

"It was about three days ago, I think. I am not sure exactly, but as I ate my food on that particular night on my bed something just felt different inside," she said.

She went on, but this time she looked right into Oto's eyes until he looked away.

He could no longer look at her, so he instead looked down at his feet that shifted around on the cold floor as he sat in the plastic chair.

In vivid detail, she described how she opened a drawer where she always kept a sharp razor blade, which she always used to shave her legs.

She had put it there weeks before.

"I can't really say why I put that blade in my drawer."

What she said next got Oto to look into her eyes again, and they were both crying at that point.

"I carefully picked up that blade in my right hand and slowly pressed it into my left forearm."

She didn't have to explain the pain that shot through her arm as the tip of the blade pierced the tight skin of her arm.

"I got dizzy and the room began to spin around."

She said she fought to stay focused on the blood streaming down her arm and onto the carpet of her room.

She didn't look at the actual place where the blade was moving back and forth as if it wasn't her arm at all.

She pressed harder and harder until everything went black.

At this point she paused and the tears that were streaming down her face were dropping onto her feet that were moving back and forth on the cold floor.

She sighed and explained how her mother, unfortunately, managed to find her before she died.

Of course, she had only been told this later as she somehow recovered in an emergency room at a different hospital not far from her home.

Oto had never thought of killing himself, even though he wasn't sure if he had said yes or no on that questionnaire the first morning he had arrived in this hospital.

He was intrigued by this girl, and the red ooze that came out from some of her bandages, but he never saw her again.

He couldn't recall if it was at lunch or dinner, or if it even really mattered, when a woman in her forties sat down across from him the next day at the lunch table.

She was whispering some words to him that he had trouble hearing.

She must have figured this out, so she got up and sat right next to him, and began whispering again.

"Have you been to the rubber room yet," she asked.

Oto had never heard of a rubber room, but the woman who had a small scab above her lip with breath that smelled like chocolate pudding went on.

"Don't worry, you will if you are here long enough," she said.

She smiled, explaining how that very morning she had been drugged and put in a straitjacket and locked up in the white room with padding on the walls.

She had thrown herself with all of her strength against those pads she said with a big smile.

Eventually, though, two nurses had opened the door to the room and pushed a needle into her left arm where the straight jacket didn't cover her skin.

It didn't take long for the drugs that swirled around inside her to work their magic.

She then sat down until the nurses came back in and removed the straitjacket.

The time in the hospital was actually starting to slide by pretty fast.

In fact, before he knew it, he was told he would be leaving.

Oto was told he was being released, and that his mom would be coming to pick him up.

“You need to back up your belongings and bring them to the front desk,” the nurse said.

It was the same nurse that had walked him into the hospital when he first arrived.

Oto walked back into the room that he had tried to sleep in every night.

He wasn’t sure, but if he had to give a number, he would say possibly that he got around two to three hours of sleep a night.

Oto packed up his belongings and placed them into a clear plastic bag that the nurse had given him.

He dropped the candy into the bag that he hadn’t even touched, except to yank it from the hands of the old man that was not in the room at that moment.

He also slipped in the books that he had not even looked at during the week’s stay.

The nurse that had been watching Oto closely took the plastic bag away from him and left the room.

Oto turned around to see the old man that he had shared the room with shuffling in before heading over to his bed.

The wrinkled man slowly sat down, before looking Oto straight into his eyes.

The man kept adjusting his gown to cover up his knees as best he could.

He ran his hands slowly through what little amount of hair he had on the top of his head.

The old man was moving his feet around that dangled off the floor as if he was cold.

He just kept looking into Oto’s eyes and gave him a big smile.

The crooked brown teeth are what Oto would always remember after the nurse walked back in and ushered Oto out of the room.

Oto didn't look back at his roommate.

Even years later Oto would never forget that smile.

He would remember though, how numb he had felt at the time.

He hadn't felt any emotion at all.

But he did remember the fear that seemed to knot itself deep inside of him.

Oto stood on the side of the glass door that he had been trapped in for several days.

He watched, without smiling, as his mom suddenly appeared on the other side.

He had been looking down thinking about what he had experienced.

The nurse unlocked the door and gave Oto a gentle push.

He helped Oto walk out into the room where Ana was filling out paperwork again.

Oto watched her hand as she wrote down her signature and then looked up at her son.

Ana couldn't be sure, but she thought that her son looked much calmer, and his eyes seemed a bit clearer.

She was relieved as Oto slowly followed her back out into the bright sunlight and helped him get into the Blazer.

Ana slowly drove her car out of the empty parking lot and onto the busy street.

She was focused on the cars that were moving by as she headed back toward their home that was at least an hour or two away.

She didn't look over at her son, and he was grateful for that.

The tears were flowing again down his cheeks, but he quickly wiped them away and focused on the blur of the road that went by.

Chapter 4: 10-Key

Once Oto was released, he returned home again, worried about how much of his anxiety was going to return, and when it surely would, what he was going to do in order to survive it.

He was seated at the kitchen table, cranking away on his 10-key adding machine.

The sound of it, spitting out the numbers on the small sheet of paper that churned from the top of the adding machine, somehow soothed his mind a bit.

The goal that he kept to himself was how he was determined to return to the classes at his high school.

Oto wasn't even sure at this point when he stopped driving himself to school in his 1978 VW Rabbit that was still parked out in the driveway.

It sat, unused, for the many days as he stared up at the ceiling in his bedroom.

He somehow knew that he needed to keep swallowing down the same shiny pills that he had been forced to take in the hospital.

He was pretty sure it had only been a few days since he had arrived back home, but already what he had gone through in that hospital seemed so far away.

He was so bored at the beginning of his senior year at the local high school because he had already earned enough credits to graduate.

Before his breakdown, he had been juggling several remote correspondence courses, and one of them covered advanced accounting.

The lessons were mailed to his house every week, and after completing them, he would mail them back to the BYU University professor who was in charge of grading and verifying completion of the course.

Oto was still feeling anxiety every minute of every day, but he was now only about 30 pounds underweight.

He was actually able to slowly talk, spending some time each day with his mom, when she came home from work.

He did his best to listen to her telling him about her day.

Back again at his adding machine, he was able to move his fingers quickly over the smooth keys.

After about an hour, he actually finished a couple of pages of homework he was way behind on.

He hadn't received back the last packet that he had finished several weeks before from his professor, and he was afraid that he would be dropped from the course.

He paused to look at the columns on the paper that were lined up in such an orderly fashion.

He heard a knock on the front door and walked over and opened it.

The sun was bright and he had to squint to see who was standing there.

It was the math teacher who would also look over Oto's lessons before mailing them back to the professor.

“Hello, Oto,” the teacher said.

“I was wondering if you could help me with a couple of problems in the last lesson you finished weeks ago.”

Oto knew that the teacher was meeting with students at a nearby town who were doing what they could do, with the help of the man standing on his steps, to get through their lessons.

His teacher quickly explained how there was one student in that group that actually was doing his best, and was completing the exercises in each lesson.

“There are a couple of advanced problems in that last lesson you finished, and I am wondering if you can help me with them?”

Oto followed his teacher out the front door, and was soon sitting in the passenger seat of the old white truck.

The man sat in the driver’s seat and pulled out the lesson that he had on the floor of his car.

He opened up one of the papers and set it on Oto’s lap.

There was a problem that was circled with a question mark next to it.

As the teacher explained how he had tried to solve the problem, he pulled a cigarette out of his shirt pocket, lighting it up with a match that he struck on the metal steering wheel.

Oto focused on the problem at hand.

He always did his best in life to give it his all, but today like most days the anxiety was making it hard for him to focus.

He studied the problem and searched his memory.

Oto looked over at the smoke swirling from the lit cigarette.

He hated the smell of smoke because it always gave him a headache, and he was pretty sure that was going to happen.

Oto smiled, though, for the first time all day.

He looked over at his math teacher before saying, “Believe it or not I did complete this advanced problem a few weeks back.”

Ignoring the smoke and the pang in his gut, he explained exactly how he had solved the problem.

After about fifteen minutes of Oto gagging on cigarette smoke, he had explained enough of his solution to his math teacher until he could solve it on his own.

The math teacher laughed and put out his cigarette in the “ashtray” in the middle console of his dashboard.

“Oto, I don’t know how you do what you do. Son, I get it now. Okay, you better get back into the house because I need to get going so, I can help the kid in my class.”

With that, Oto left the car with relief, and stumbled back into the house.

For the rest of the summer Oto worked for Ana’s boyfriend named Renner, who was actually more of a father than his biological dad ever was.

But he still had a week or so to get ready for the new job.

Each day, with the help of the pills, he got a little bit better.

The day before Renner drove up in his Ford F 150, Oto was actually able to sit down and eat a small meal.

He weighed himself on the scale every morning and he was now only about 20 pounds underweight.

Oto had already packed up his adding machine and some old clothes that he thought would be best to wear at the Ready-Mix plant.

Ana was very worried about whether or not Oto would be able to do the job he was hired for, but she trusted Renner and gave her son a long hug before he left.

She noticed for the first time that the Ford F-150 that left the driveway was the same beige color of Oto's VW Rabbit that he left parked on the side of the house.

Oto did his best as he worked for Renner at the local Ready-Mix plant, but he still wasn't back to his "old" self. He was feeling anxiety most of the time.

"Oto," he said, "I will give you three days to improve and do the job I hired you for, but if I don't see any progress I will have to drive you home this weekend and hire someone else to help me out."

There was no way in hell Oto was about to go back home and admit defeat.

He stopped taking his pills at lunch that day, because he believed they were making it hard for him to concentrate.

That day he didn't feel much different, but at breakfast the next day he felt better than he had in a long time.

He sat in the old trailer that smelled like sweat and cement dust, behind his old desk, that he had gotten used to.

He was actually able to eat half of his warm breakfast burrito before tossing the rest of it in the trash.

There was plenty of downtime at the plant when the Ready-Mix trucks were out pouring "mud" at job sites.

There were two things that Oto loved to do in his spare time.

The first was to hit a punching bag that hung in one corner of the trailer where he spent most of his time that summer.

It felt so good to slam his fists into the hanging bag.

The other thing was to practice hitting flies with a rubber band.

Oto used the largest rubber bands that he could find on his desk and actually got pretty good at hitting flies when they landed on his desk.

This skill that he acquired actually came in handy.

One afternoon Renner walked into the trailer after finishing a cement slab with a trowel out in the hot sun.

Whenever there was extra “mud” that came back in a mixer they would pour it out in the “yard” and create a smooth slab to cut down on the dust.

“Oto, what are you doing with those rubber bands?”

Oto of course told him.

“Well, if you can hit and kill the fly that is over near me, about ten feet away, then I will treat you out to a nice dinner.”

Oto didn’t hesitate. He took aim at the fly, nailing it with his first shot using the rubber band.

The poor thing dropped dead from the hit onto the dusty floor.

Oto had never eaten lobster before.

The restaurant they sat out that night was amazingly good.

Oto ordered the biggest steak and lobster that he could find on the menu.

Renner even had some melted butter brought over in a small tin cup.

Oto slowly cut the delicious seafood meat, savoring every incredible taste that burst in his mouth.

The steak was also cooked perfectly, and he took his time eating the meal that he would remember for the rest of his life.

The only other major event that Oto remembered from that summer, besides the fact that the anxiety finally went away, was an accident that he had driving one morning at 5 a.m.

He was driving Renner’s Ford F-150 driving back from a weekend in the small town where he had his complete breakdown.

Oto had been exhausted after drinking a bit the night before.

He was driving on a curvy mountain road, and was doing his best to stay awake.

Renner had drifted off to sleep, since he also had been drinking a bit the night before as well.

Oto felt like he was going to fall asleep at the wheel.

He cracked open a bottle full of water and dumped it all over the back of his neck.

It was like getting hit by some lightning, which jerked him fully awake.

About fifteen minutes later Oto drove around a blind curve in the rough road.

There, standing right in front of him, was a giant buck.

The deer was a five point.

Oto would later remember how Renner had told him about his hunting adventures that he had high up in the mountains.

Renner had plenty of experience killing and skinning deer with his high-powered rifle.

After killing a buck, he would carry the freshly-carved meat out on a donkey that he kept down at camp.

The buck had just finished a long drink from a nearby running creek, and he looked Oto straight in the eyes.

In that moment Oto would later recall that he had seen the water dripping from the deer's open mouth.

Oto tried swerving around the unmoving animal standing in the middle of the road.

There just wasn't enough time to go around the beautiful animal.

The truck that Oto was driving slammed into the deer with the left tire of the truck.

Right before that moment Oto had looked down at the speedometer and noticed that he was racing through that turn at 50 mph.

The deer hit the pavement with a loud thud.

Renner was pulled out of his sleep in seconds, nearly hitting the side window that he had been resting against.

Oto was shaking, but Renner calmly told him to pull off on the side of the road.

Oto of course immediately did that and shut off the idling truck.

Unfortunately, the left tire had broken the back of the suffering deer that was trying to get up off the pavement, but just couldn't manage it.

Renner didn't hesitate.

He reached into the rack in the back seat of his truck, grabbing his favorite rifle.

He loaded it with a buckshot bullet, sending the bullet into the chamber, and cocked the weapon.

Renner quickly walked over to the deer and without hesitating he shot it straight in the head.

In a second the suffering animal lay still on the pavement and Renner pulled the warm carcass onto the side of the road so nobody would drive over it.

They were thirty minutes late arriving at the Ready Mix at six in the morning instead of at five-thirty.

Renner had made Oto drive the rest of the way there, because like he had calmly said, "When you get bucked off a horse, you don't hesitate, you get right back on."

Once Oto parked the truck in the "yard," Renner quickly jumped out and started up the loader.

They had a 50-yarder scheduled and they were late getting to the job with the first mixer.

Renner immediately loaded into the hopper the right quantity of rocks and sand and began batching eight yards of "mud" into the spinning drum of the mixer.

The mixer was always so loud under the hopper, because the engine of the big truck had to be revved up while it was in neutral.

The drum could then could quickly spin around as the “mud” was being poured inside.

Later that morning, Renner and Oto were eating cold turkey sandwiches.

He looked over at Oto with pride and simply said, “Oto, I still can’t believe that the deer you hit didn’t damage my truck at all.”

“The only way I could even tell that anything happened was the hair and blood that came off the buck and was stuck to the left front bumper.”

“I pulled that off right before handing you the sandwich you are devouring.”

Chapter 5: Junior College

Oto could smell the pepperoni pizza cooking away in the brick oven.

Ana had driven Oto in the car for four hours to check out a college in California.

He was living in a small town in Nevada, but couldn’t wait to move to California to live in a college town and live life on his own.

As Oto waited for their number to be called so he could eat the pizza, he watched the big screen TV live for the Space Shuttle take-off.

With horror, he saw it explode in seconds after lift-off.

The space shuttle came apart in the sky like something out of a Star Wars movie.

Somehow Oto was still hungry, but he ate the pizza, yet it didn’t taste the way he thought it would.

He wiped away a small tear running down his face that dropped into the sizzling cheese on his plate.

They drove over to the college and Oto waited with Ana until they were finally seen by the dean.

Oto had been accepted at a top Arizona school for Accounting, so he thought he had a good chance of getting into that major at the university in California.

The dean saw them in, and laughed when Oto said he wanted to major in Accounting.

The dean informed him how they hadn't let anyone into Accounting in at least eight years.

Oto then asked about the English department and was laughed at again.

Oto was told that he should start at a nearby junior college and get his AA degree before transferring to the four-year college.

Ana drove him to the junior college, and after going through a lengthy application process he found out right then and there that he had been accepted.

He got excited about majoring in English and readily signed up for some classes.

The night after he finished his first English 1A class, Oto decided to drive out to one of the popular beaches.

He turned the volume up as he listened to Genesis, driving his Volkswagen Rabbit out to the ocean that was 30 miles from the apartment he was now living in.

He was alone, it was about three in the morning, and he had the pedal to the floor.

He had his window down, and the cold wet fog enveloped his car with a smell that can only come from the ocean at that time in the morning.

He raced around the turns at 70 mph and he could hear the wheels of his beige German car squeal a bit through the turns.

He finally arrived and parked his car two blocks from the ocean.

He got out, running down into the cold waves that crashed onto his tight jeans and t-shirt.

Although he usually avoided the waves during the day, that night he danced in them and yelled out at the top of his lungs.

He dropped down on the dry sand and spat out what stuck to his wet cheeks and his dry lips.

Oto hadn't slept in four days, so he looked at the thick fog around him and drifted off into sleep for a couple of hours.

It was the sound of a leaf blower that woke him up.

He sat up and was so cold he felt like an icicle was stabbing into his cold armpits, and his jeans were still soaking wet.

Oto quickly walked back to his car and found some old shorts that had Taco Bell beans smeared on them.

He managed to slowly pull off his soaking wet pants and underwear, since nobody was around, and pulled up the dry smelly blue shorts.

Oto immediately felt some relief, and he was laughing at how good it felt to be alive.

At least that was how he would describe it to his psychiatrist years later.

Oto was starving, so he got back into his Rabbit and drove fast, but not too fast, back to the city he now lived in.

As he drove down a side street, he spotted a Denny's that he hadn't seen before and pulled over.

Oto went to the counter and ordered two "grand slam" platters of food, quickly emptying his plate until he was finally full.

When the bill was given to him, he went to his back pocket to pull out his wallet.

He suddenly remembered with dread that he had left it next to his bed the night before.

He didn't dine and dash, but instead went to a pay phone and called his mom.

Ana had just finished showering in her one-bedroom apartment that she had rented after following Oto to the new city she found herself in.

She had a good amount of money saved from selling some ranches out in the Nevada sagebrush months ago, but had to find a job so she could keep her reserves.

She figured she had enough money for about seven months, but would need to quickly find a job in this new city that Oto had returned to.

Oto refused to listen to her when it came to anything about budgets.

Ana's house was pale green on the outside and pink on the inside, but was only a few blocks away from the beach.

She had to admit that she enjoyed taking long morning walks in the sunny hot sand.

She was watching a beautiful sunrise, drinking coffee, and smoking cigarettes, when the phone rang.

She picked it up and was surprised to hear her son on the line.

She couldn't believe what he was rambling on about. It was something about eggs and bacon, and how he had no money to pay the waitress.

Oto told her that he had offered to do the dishes, but the waitress had said no, and was threatening to call the cops on him.

Anna always parked her blue Chevy Blazer three blocks from her house because it was too big to fit into the tiny driveway of her rented home.

She had put out her cigarette the minute she had slammed the phone down.

She quickly left the smoldering remnants of her Marlboro Slims in the ceramic ashtray that she had purchased in the shell-shack a block away.

She hopped into her car, driving the few miles to the Denny's that Oto had described to her.

She pulled her Blazer up to the Denny's parking lot, trying not to step into the small pool of what looked like yellow vomit she had unfortunately parked nearby.

She yanked open the grimy door to the greasy spoon restaurant.

Oto was sitting on a stool, talking to what looked like several waitresses at once.

She walked over to him and gave him all of her cash.

It turned out to be a twenty-dollar bill that she had planned to use to buy a pack of cigarettes.

The money was just enough to cover the bill with a small tip.

Oto smiled as his mom turned around and left, and he didn't see or talk to her again for a couple of days.

Oto managed to stay up for two more days and nights without sleeping.

The old apartment room where he currently lived had posters taped to the walls of women drinking Michelob and Coors beers that he had picked up at an empty bar the night before.

It was one in the morning, the perfect time to talk to those students who were also going to the JC.

Oto loved talking about politics, or any subject at all actually.

He discovered that he could verbally joust with anyone who could pull an all-nighter with him.

It never took too long for a person to get worn down and then they would go to sleep.

He didn't mind at all because he would then just move on and hang out with those early birds who woke up to go jogging.

Oto had more strength than he could ever remember having in his life.

He loved jogging with young girls in tight leggings that seemed to be everywhere in the lively college town.

After the jogs they would go out and get some orange juice and toast.

Luckily, he never left his wallet in his room again.

He had plenty of money now that he had cashed in the thousands of dollars, he was awarded from the scholarship he had received from high school.

But he didn't worry about how much money he was spending. It just didn't seem that important to him.

Oto would lose track of how many hours he was awake and how many hours he slept. He went to every party that he could, especially those that served alcohol, staying out until at least three in the morning.

He and all of his new "friends" would then drive over to the packed Taco Bell, hanging out and discussing all of the parties from that night.

That Taco Bell happened to be the busiest on the West Coast.

On this particular night he was flirting heavily with one gal who was giving him lots of eye contact. She was working behind the counter doing several things at once with ease.

He worked up the nerve to ask her out, but she shut him down right away.

He got a little bit upset, but that didn't last too long because he was having the time of his life.

The next night he was racing his Rabbit again right up to the speed limit as quickly as possible.

He yelled out his window, but never actually went over the speed limit by more than five miles per hour.

He couldn't believe it when he looked back in his mirror and saw the blue and red lights behind him.

He of course immediately pulled over.

The cop slowly walked up to him, asking for his license and registration.

When Oto reached over and opened his glovebox, a full warm and unopened can of Budweiser rolled out and landed on the floor on the passenger side floor of his car.

He looked at the cop after rolling down his passenger side window that barely even rolled up in his car.

He gave the cop his license and registration and was trying to stay calm, at least that was what he thought he was doing.

The cop opened the can of beer and poured it out on the curb, gave Oto a warning, and for some reason he wasn't handed a ticket.

The cop then deposited the dripping can in a nearby trash that was overflowing onto the ground.

Oto had made friends with a 21-year-old student that he met in his psychology class at the junior college.

It was a hot and sunny day and he was in the mood to play some basketball.

The only problem was that the court outside his apartment was always full with guys playing, and he didn't feel comfortable trying to join them.

He had made friends with a girl that lived in the apartment right next to him.

He was only 18, but she bought him a six-pack of beer that Oto then carried back to his apartment complex.

It was a hot day and he was sweating, wishing he had driven rather than walked with the six-pack in his sweaty hands.

On his way up to his apartment he decided to go and hang out, watching the guys playing basketball.

Oto was never able to play with them because they were way too good.

In high school he had played basketball, but he was really just a bench-warmer.

That all changed, however, when he handed out the six beers when the players took a break.

After slamming down the cold brew, they let him join them on the court.

Oto felt like superman.

Although he was only 5 feet 10 inches tall, he somehow managed to “snuff” one of the athletes when the six-foot-three dude went in for a slam dunk.

Later that night Oto’s sister, Hanah, pulled up in her Honda, and told Oto to hop in.

He didn’t think anything of it at the time.

He was always up for an adventure so he hopped in.

Oto had no idea where they were going, but once they were driving 75 down the highway, he opened his window and yelled into the night sky that he would soon be the President of the United States.

When they stopped at a gas station, Oto quickly walked into the bathroom and took a long piss.

After drying his hands on his shirt, he walked out into the store and grabbed some candy.

He walked out to the car not thinking about whether or not he had paid for it.

Hanah walked quickly over to the small man working behind the counter, apologized, and quickly paid for the candy.

She then ran back out to the car where Oto was sitting.

“Oto, what the hell were you thinking in there. It is as if you just don’t think at all, and just do stupid shit.”

Hanah started up her car and quickly got back on the freeway.

She glanced briefly over at her brother.

“Can you please roll up that window and stay in the car?”

Chapter 6: Betrayal

Hannah pulled the Honda up into the driveway of her grandma and grandpa’s house.

She was exhausted from the four-hour trip across several freeways to get there.

Her back was hurting and she asked her grandma for some Tylenol as soon as she got into their house.

Her grandparents were waiting for her, since she had called them before picking up Oto.

The three of them just looked at him.

He was so excited, because he had no idea that this car adventure would end up with him at his grandparent's house.

When Oto was 13, he worked for his grandpa out on a peach orchard in the summer when it was 105 degrees and the humidity factor was 80 percent.

His grandpa paid him \$3.35 an hour, which was the going rate at the time.

Oto would hoe a three-foot perimeter around 3,000 peach orchard trees in the first month at work, because the weeds couldn't be reached with a mower.

The blisters eventually became callouses, and after three and half weeks he finished the entire orchard.

Oto thought back to that simpler time, recalling one afternoon when his grandpa had dropped him off at another orchard that was being irrigated.

He had eaten two bean burritos, with extra cheese, and no sauce, and scarfed it down.

That usually was okay, but on this particular afternoon it felt like hot lead in his stomach.

He couldn't wait to get home, so he squatted down in the running water in the orchard and relieved himself.

He had nothing to wipe with, so he just pulled up his jeans, and finished up with the irrigating.

It was a few weeks later when Oto was pulling down a five-hundred-pound bin of peaches off a trailer.

It had a bunch of metal rollers on the trailer so the bins could slide off, and onto the ground, to then be picked up with a fork-lift.

There were a few rollers that weren't working, so instead of just sliding off the trailer, he had to go and pull the bins down the "ramp" to help them drop off the trailer.

The boy who was driving the tractor accidentally "popped the clutch," and the bin full of peaches fell off the trailer.

Unfortunately for Oto, he was trapped in between two bins, and as one of the bins dropped off the trailer it landed on his foot.

By some stroke of luck Oto somehow managed to pull his left foot out just as the heavy bin dropped down onto it.

Oto's grandpa was busy running the forklift so couldn't hear him scream out in agony.

Oto limped over to the nearby lawn, collapsing on the grass lawn.

His grandpa saw this out of the corner of his eye.

He quickly shut down the loud forklift, running over to see what had happened to his grandson.

His grandpa went inside the nearby house looking in the freezer for ice.

He found some and quickly wrapped them into a towel that he grabbed from the kitchen.

He then ran out and had Oto elevate his left leg on a nearby rock, gently placing the ice on his ankle.

Oto recalled the pain shooting through his foot, but he was soon in shock and not feeling anything.

His grandpa rushed him to the hospital where they quickly took an X-ray of his foot after waiting for an hour in the emergency room.

The X-ray showed how there was only a small chipped piece of bone in the corner of his foot. The bone was fractured, but luckily it had stayed in place.

He was told he wouldn't even need a cast, just a boot to wear for a few weeks, but he couldn't walk at all on it during the time it took to heal.

His grandma took good care of him, bringing him food while he recovered in bed.

Eventually, after about five days slid by, Oto was able to limp around and use crutches.

He was feeling so much better so he decided to take a trip to the mall with his grandma.

Once they got there and parked Oto felt fine, but he wasn't used to getting around with crutches.

Halfway to the first store, his arms were burning, and he was having trouble catching his breath.

He caught up with her, sitting down on a bench, as his grandma went into Gottschalks to buy some "old lady" underwear.

He had so much fun after work that summer long ago, hanging out with his grandpa, drinking A&W Root Beer and eating Cheeto Puffs.

The smooth soda was of course out of a cold can.

Oto and his grandpa would then sit in the living room, talking about the work from that day.

His grandpa told him how he had driven millions of miles as a Greyhound bus driver.

One story in particular stuck with him.

His grandpa had driven a route from Tucson, Arizona to El Paso, Texas three times a week.

He had a good friend that would always drive the opposite route, from El paso to Tucson.

They would usually meet about halfway there out on the open highway and would always flash their high beams three times and then pass each other on the two-laned road.

On one particular night they flashed their lights three times, but this time they put their plan into effect.

They both switched lanes, because no other cars were out on this moonlit night.

So, they were each then driving on the left side of the highway as if they were passing a car that wasn't there.

They sped by each other, honking and laughing to themselves.

Everyone on his grandpa's bus was asleep, except for one woman in the back of the bus.

She yelled out so loud that she woke up most of the sleeping passengers.

At night Oto would stay up late with his grandma.

She would drink Kahlua and cream at night as they watched old westerns on TV.

Oto was worried about his grandpa.

Sometimes his grandpa would stay up with them, but he never could finish watching a show because he would be too tired.

Every night before limping back to his bedroom, he would have to slowly push himself out of his comfy recliner.

He had faithfully driven Greyhound buses for over three million miles in his 30 years of service.

Unfortunately, Oto's grandpa drove the older buses that had a clutch, instead of an automatic transmission, which took a toll on his left leg.

His grandpa would smile at him and just say he had to get the old leg "going."

The memory of that summer came flooding back to Oto as he climbed out of his sister's blue Honda Accord.

He opened the door through the garage, with Hannah right behind him, like she was flanking him or something.

He was instantly worried, because he saw his grandma and grandpa pacing in the kitchen, like they had been waiting for him.

His grandma opened up a pill bottle, pulling out a shiny red pill, which seemed strange to Oto.

As soon as Oto walked into the kitchen, his grandma showed the pill in her hand to Oto, telling him to take it.

“Sorry, but no thanks, grandma.”

She then handed the pill to his grandpa and he did the same thing.

Oto replied back in the same way.

Oto’s grandpa then raised his voice and yelled at him, which he had never done before, so Oto took the pill, dry-swallowing it.

What Oto didn’t know at the time was that the pill was 20 MGs of Zyprexa, which was like shooting an elephant with a tranquilizer dart.

The medication was extremely powerful, and before Oto knew it, he was fast asleep on the same couch where he had fought off pneumonia five years before.

Oto was told later that he slept for twenty-two straight hours.

When Oto woke up, he felt more rested than he had in weeks.

He was delighted to see that Ana, his mom, was also there to greet him.

Ana just whispered to Oto, “We are going on a new adventure. Don’t worry we will have lots of fun.”

Ana felt bad about lying to her son, but she felt that she had no other choice.

It wasn’t long before Oto’s sister joined them in the Blazer, along with his grandma and grandpa, who were “posted” on both sides of Oto in the back seat.

He didn’t mind at all being scrunched in the middle, and it wasn’t long before he was talking a mile a minute about one of the nights he recalled from the prior week.

Unlike the trip to his grandparent's house, nothing eventful happened along the way as they drove to wherever they were headed.

It was roughly four hours later that they pulled up and parked outside a hospital in Nevada.

They all got out of the car to stretch their legs after such a long drive.

Oto followed his mom into the hospital and was instantly greeted by a nurse in the air-conditioned room.

At the check-in desk Oto watched as a nurse gave Ana a clipboard with a bunch of paperwork attached to it.

Ana filled it out as quickly as she could, looking over at Oto from time-to-time.

Grandma, grandpa, and Hanah had walked over to a nearby restaurant since they were hungry and wanted Ana and Oto to be alone together in the hospital waiting room.

Ana finally finished filling out the paperwork, giving it back to the receptionist along with her insurance card.

It wasn't long before what looked like a 250-pound male nurse entered the small room.

The nurse in white approached Oto and told him to follow him.

Ana was right behind them both and just told Oto, "Don't worry son, everything will be fine."

This reassured Oto, so he followed the nurse with his mom right behind him.

They approached a big door that had a tiny glass square in the middle of it.

The glass had metal wires running through it.

The nurse unlocked it and asked Oto to follow him.

Chapter 7: Slammed Shut

Oto was surprised when he was ushered through the door of the hospital that was almost all in white.

He jumped a bit when the door slammed shut behind him.

Ana was on the other side of the locked door and he looked back at her through the wired, glass window.

He saw the tears in her eyes and he could hear her screaming, “Otto, I am sorry!!”

He watched her standing there for a couple of minutes, but then she was gone, leaving him all alone in the hospital.

Oto felt nothing at all at this point. He just thought it was strange that he was now all alone with this nurse.

The large, smelly man grabbed Oto by the arm and turned him around until they were face-to-face.

“Sit down in this desk against the wall. And shut up and don’t say a word. I have a headache and don’t want to hear even a yawn coming out of your mouth!”

It just so happened that it was exactly 12 noon when the time started for Oto to be confined against his will.

He later learned that he was locked up in an adolescent hospital with 15 to 17-year-old boys and girls for a two-week involuntary hold.

The small green and yellow pill that he was told to swallow with some ice water, was shiny and smooth.

It was 300 Mgs of Lithium Carbonate, but not the generic kind.

He asked the nurse what would happen if he didn’t take it and he was laughed at.

“Well, then, that will be fun, because I will force you to take it.”

Oto was looking the nurse in the eyes, and he could tell he wasn’t bluffing, so he took the pill and drank down the entire cup of ice water to chase it down.

The nurse walked back over to Oto, and made him open his mouth and lift his tongue to make sure he had actually swallowed the pill.

This was something that Oto eventually got used to doing.

The nurse sat back down behind his desk.

Oto couldn't help himself. He was soon asking the large nurse in white what his name was.

The nurse just ignored him.

Oto watched the clock on the white wall slowly tick away until it was 2 pm, but to him it felt like just a couple of seconds had passed.

At exactly 2 pm the nurse walked over, but this time with two shiny pills in his meaty hand.

"Take these now," he said, handing Oto another paper cup with ice water in it.

Oto didn't hesitate this time - he did what he was told.

This time it was two 300 Mg pills of Lithium Carbonate.

He quickly swallowed them down with the water.

This time, though, he instantly felt queasy.

He was sure that he was going to vomit on the floor in front of him.

He had taken 900 Mgs of the shiny element, the lightest metal on earth, in the span of his first two hours in the hospital.

It wasn't like anything he had taken before.

It left a metallic taste in the back of his throat, and his body tried to get rid of the element that he was swallowing against his will.

Later on, he would understand that it wasn't just that day when he had to take these poisonous-like pills.

Much later he would have to come to grips with the fact that he had to do it for the rest of his life.

Oto managed to keep the pills down, and then promptly asked the nurse for some paper and a crayon.

The nurse brought it over to him about fifteen minutes later.

Oto politely took the front and back of one blank page of white paper, quickly scribbling, filling both sides with the smallest print he could muster.

He had no idea what he wrote down, but he felt a little bit better after finishing.

The nurse came and grabbed the paper and crayon away from him, and Oto never saw either of them again.

It wasn't long before Oto felt like his bladder was going to burst.

"Please, can I go to the bathroom?"

The nurse laughed and told him to piss his pants.

Oto refused to give him the satisfaction of leaving a puddle of his own piss in the chair and onto the floor that he had almost vomited on thirty minutes before.

The nurse waited another thirty minutes before finally ushering Oto over to a bathroom in the hallway.

Oto had a hard time peeing, even though the pain in his bladder took his breathe away.

The nurse just laughed behind him, watching Oto finally get a stream going.

"Good, God, you piss like a race horse."

Chapter 8: Weak Spots

After sitting out in the hallway in that chair all day, Oto was finally escorted to his room.

He was surprised that there was only one bed in a large room, and it was just for him.

There was even a private bathroom, so he no longer had to worry about pissing himself.

Before leaving the room the nurse promptly told Oto, “You are still manic.”

Oto just looked at him, but nodded without saying a word, even though he had no idea what the nurse was talking about.

“If you are lucky, you will be released in a couple of weeks. But, since you have good insurance, don’t be surprised if we keep you much longer.”

The nurse turned to leave the room, but not before Oto quickly asked him, “But, what do you mean by if I have good insurance?”

The nurse didn’t even pause, or miss a beat, as he walked back out into the bright hallway.

Oto carefully looked around “his” room.

He quickly catalogued everything in his head, especially the furniture and the bathroom by instinct.

He surveyed and tested out every corner of the room to see if there were any “weak” spots.

It wasn’t very dark in his room, and Oto was supposed to be going to sleep.

Just naturally, he would count how many minutes passed in between the time that the nurse walked in to the room, left, and then later returned.

Oto looked at the big window that was on the far side of the room.

He could see any alleyway out there beyond the window.

He walked over to see if he could open the window, but then the light reflected off something, and he noticed how there was a heavy metal screen covering the window.

Oto turned his attention to a chair that was next to a desk.

The desk was bolted down to the floor, but for some reason the chair wasn't.

He picked up the heavy wooden chair, throwing it with all of his might, straight at the metal mesh that covered the window.

Unfortunately for Oto, the chair bounced back and hit him right in the nose, which immediately started bleeding.

He went into the bathroom and grabbed some toilet paper, shoving it up his nose to stop the bleeding.

He then went to his bed and tried to lay down and go to sleep, but he just couldn't even close his eyes.

The light from outside his room was flooding in to his room, and he could only sleep when it was absolutely dark.

He went back into his bathroom, and noticed the shower curtain with the plastic hooks on the end, hanging up in the shower stall.

He quickly undid the hooks, and pulled them from the shower curtain, tossing the hooks on the bathroom floor.

In his mind he was going to hang the shower curtain up somehow to block the light coming in from out in the hallway.

That of course didn't work, so he tossed the shower curtain back into the bathroom, and tried to go to sleep again.

Oto shifted his weight, and moved around at every angle, but he just couldn't get comfortable on the bed, especially because it was so bright in his room.

When he finally did shut his eyes, he prayed for help, because he wasn't sure what else he could do.

He actually thought that he might be drifting off to sleep, when he "saw" a giant red Satan-like demon laughing at him.

He wasn't sure if he was dreaming or not.

It scared him, of course, because he had never pictured anything even remotely like that in his life.

It must have been less than a minute after that when a nurse in white entered the room to check on him again.

The nurse immediately saw the chair upside down, Oto's bloody nose, and the shower curtain on the floor of the bathroom.

Oto wondered briefly why the nurse hadn't come into the room earlier, but figured he had just been checking on other patients or something.

"Get up right now before I slam you into the ground!" said the nurse.

Oto was immediately frightened for his life.

He was pulled out of the room by the nurse, and forced to sit back down in the chair out in the hallway.

Oto was staring again at the clock on the wall.

The nurse had left him alone again in the chair.

Oto managed to yell out, "I swear I wasn't trying to kill myself."

His voice just echoed throughout the empty hallway.

Chapter 9: The Guitar

It was the next day that Oto was told to his surprise that he had to attend "school" in the hospital.

The last school he had attended was the junior college that he had been "ripped" away from after spiraling out with his manic episode, but he wouldn't really know any of that until weeks later.

He thought back to the philosophy class there.

He had no idea who Nietzsche was at the time, but he was bored out of his mind hearing about the guy.

There was a lot of debate in the class about whether or not we as humans exist, and he thought that was a waste of time.

His nose was scabbed up a bit, and he remembered the chair from the night before.

He laughed to himself, thinking that he certainly does exist, because that chair had hit him with a lot of force, and when it hit his nose, he felt a lot of pain.

In one of the current “classes” he was given a guitar. He had never held one before.

The smooth light-brown starter guitar was string-less.

He was given the wires, and told that eventually he would learn how to play a few bars on the guitar.

But first he had to string it by himself with some instruction.

Oto was surprised that he was able to string the guitar.

Next, he was taught how to tune it.

He was even taught how to play a few chords before the class was over, and he naturally just started humming along to a little tune that he made up.

The only thing he didn’t like was how the wires had bloodied his fingers, and they hurt like hell.

Oto had always been good at learning how to quickly make friends.

He thought that it might have something to do with how he and his family moved around so often.

This would happen because his stepdad flew cargo planes for Hawaiian Airlines.

It seemed like every two years or so, after he made a best friend, Oto had to leave and start the process all over again.

In Georgia, Oto made a best friend named Sillis.

Oto remembered laying in the tall grass of his front yard, looking up at the clouds in the sky.

His stepdad had told him that if you looked at the clouds long enough, and thought about a hot fire, the clouds would disappear.

What Oto didn't learn until much later in science class was that it was just normal behavior for clouds to disappear, grow, or even shrink.

He was told how it had to do with factors such as air moisture.

His stepdad had been joking with Oto, but he had no idea of it at the time.

Of course, this made him think about the Pitt's Special up in the clouds before it spun out of control, and how his stepdad had crashed hard into the ground.

Oto's attention was quickly brought back to the GI Joe cartoon that was playing in the group therapy room.

It was Saturday, or at least that is what Oto thought. The days just sort of blended all together.

He had been in several group sessions with a boy named Ebbe, who like Oto, was seventeen.

Oto was watching the cartoon with Ebbe, the new friend he had made, sitting in a chair next to him.

They were both laughing and enjoying watching the cartoon and whispering to each other about what they used to do on the weekends before they are confined in this hospital.

They both pumped their fists in the air and yelled out, "Go Jo!"

That of course didn't last long.

One of the nurses soon came over and told them that if they didn't shut the hell up they would be sent back to their rooms.

It had been a couple of weeks before Oto was locked up with Ebbe and that Oto's new friend told him a story that didn't seem possible.

Ebbe had been able, at that time, to play some basketball with other patients out on the small outside court on that sunny day.

He was loving the basketball game that he was playing with his "buddies."

He had one eye on the basketball, and the other on the fence nearby, that was about twelve feet tall if he had to guess.

Unlike in a prison, there was no barbwire on the top of the fence.

Ebbe didn't see the basketball until it was too late.

It hit him right in the face, and the sting of it on his cheeks quickly brought his attention back to the game.

Like a fighter pilot in combat he didn't think, he just reacted.

Before anyone knew what was going on Ebbe had scaled the fence, grabbing the metal fence on the other side before falling to the ground.

He had seen something like that in a movie once, but now in real life it nearly knocked the wind out of him.

Ebbe landed, with the full force of the jump, onto his left ankle.

He thought he heard something snap, but he didn't slow down, he just pushed himself forward, limping over to the nearby freeway.

Cars slammed on their brakes, as he walked out in front of them, almost creating a pile-up.

One of the first stopped cars nearly hit Ebbe, and he just stood there looking in the passenger side window.

Ebbe barely even bothered to look at the man driving the stopped vehicle.

The car was an old maroon Volvo, but he wouldn't recall this minor detail at the time.

He didn't hesitate before limping over to the car.

The passenger side window was down and Ebbe stuck his head in and asked, "Excuse me, but can I get a ride, sir?"

As Ebbe looked over at the driver he noticed that his short-sleeved blue t-shirt was soaked in sweat.

“What in the hell were you thinking?” the man said.

Ebbe noticed the man seemed to be shaking a bit.

He was instantly worried that the man was going to hop out of the car and slam him onto the hot asphalt.

Ebbe could now feel the pain in his ankle as he stood on the hot asphalt.

He looked back at the long line of cars that were all stopped.

He even noticed the black skid marks on the road behind the Volvo.

He looked back at the man in the stopped car, not fully realizing that the man was just staring at him, not saying a word.

Ebbe seemed to be frozen onto the road, and he started to feel a bit sick to his stomach.

He suddenly thought he was going to vomit.

What happened next would later haunt Ebbe, but before he could react, there was a hand on his arm and he was being yanked toward the driver of the car.

The pain in his arm brought him back to the man in the driver’s seat, and somehow, he was being pulled into the car through the open window of the passenger side door.

Although Ebbe’s legs were still hanging out the open window in the hot sunlight, the man sped off at top speed.

Ebbe could now see the face looking at him.

He looked over in horror to see the nurse in jeans that had roughed him up in the hospital the day before.

The forty-year-old unshaven man just laughed at him.

The odds of this happening couldn't be calculated by Ebbe at the time.

But before he was pulled fully into the now moving car, Ebbe's body went limp and the pain consumed him.

Ebbe was pretty sure later, thinking about it, that he had passed out, and the entire memory of that time in the car was all just a blur.

The nurse took advantage of the situation and it wasn't long before he was parking his Volvo in his assigned spot back at the mental hospital.

It had taken the nurse five long years to acquire that reserved parking spot.

The man saw a good friend in white heading into the secure hospital to start his afternoon shift.

He yelled out to his buddy who looked over at the car and quickly ran over to help out.

They both held Ebbe's legs as they worked on getting Ebbe's limp body onto the ground outside of the car.

They both yelled out to a couple of other nurses who were standing outside of their parked cars.

They quickly ran over to see what was going on.

They all helped carry Ebbe back through the front door as a nurse inside held the hot door open for them.

When Ebbe woke up, he found himself in a small room that he had never been in before.

He tried to sit up, but was quickly surrounded by the same four nurses that had carried him in.

While he was passed out, the doctor examined his left ankle, but found out it wasn't broken, and he diagnosed Ebbe with a mild ankle sprang.

When Ebbe was fully awake he looked up and saw a doctor as he sat up on the cold couch.

He immediately felt the pain shoot through his entire leg and looked down at the bruised ankle with his shoe and sock on the ground nearby.

The doctor was shining a bright light in his eyes, and he wasn't sure if he had finally died or not.

As the room slowly came back into focus, he was horrified to see that he wasn't in the room alone with the doctor.

He looked up to see the nurse who had captured him, and returned him back to the hell that Ebbe had managed to escape from, along with two or three other nurses that he of course recognized.

Ebbe had been strapped down in 4-points at least three or four times in the weeks that he had been trapped in the hospital.

At some point he had been told that he had a type of insurance that kept him in the hospital that he despised.

For some reason, he just never thought he would be set free, which is why he jumped that fence in the first place.

He heard something from the doctor about his ankle not being broken.

Ebbe just relaxed, letting his body go limp.

He was carried by the four nurses into what he knew was the 4-point room that he had been locked into just two days before.

He knew if he resisted it would only give them an excuse to punch him in the stomach or the face.

He had learned that the hard way.

This time, however, they slammed him onto the 4-point “bed” with such force that his whole body went numb.

They spread his legs out, attaching them with the restraints that were attached to the lower part of the bed.

They tightened them around his ankles, and the pain in Ebbe’s left foot shot right up into his brain and he nearly passed out again.

Before he knew it, his arms were also secured to the top of the bed in restraints that were already digging into his wrists.

It usually took minutes for his toes to throb, but this time it happened instantly.

The nurses were really pissed off this time.

The nurse who had brought him back in the car punched Ebbe twice in the stomach with such force that Ebbe felt like maybe he was going to spit out blood.

The angry nurse looked Ebbe in the eyes before exclaiming, “Look here you little asshole, nobody has ever successfully escaped from this place in my ten years on the job, and we aren’t about to start now.”

Ebbe was left alone with his thoughts in the cold white room.

He wasn’t sure if he was there for hours, but eventually he couldn’t feel his arms or his legs and he looked at the ceiling that started to spin around-and-around.

Right before passing out for good this time he smiled, thinking back to the “Hitchhiker’s Guide to the Galaxy” that he had read.

He remembered reading that book the previous summer when he thought the worst day of his life was not being able to play video games.

He had finished the book that summer, though, and he thought he could recall that somehow the answer to the universe was the number 42.

Chapter 10: 4-Points

The next day in group therapy Ebbe was squirming in his chair.

The nurses had eventually taken him out of 4-points and put him back in his bed, leaving him alone in his room.

He was hurting more than he ever had in life.

This time, unlike the other times, he was really bruised and could taste blood in the back of his throat.

He felt like hot iron rods were burning in both of his legs and arms.

Ebbe's left ankle, especially, was in such pain the night before, that he finally just blacked out before waking up in the middle of the night.

He cried and cried, begging for someone to just finish off the job.

He no longer wanted to live in this hell, and he knew he couldn't take any more beatings. He had felt so free just twenty-four hours earlier out on the freeway.

Why couldn't the Volvo just have slammed into him instead of stopping just in time?

43 or 32 or 23, the numbers just didn't matter anymore.

For some reason numbers usually comforted him, but he was beyond that this time.

The room was still pretty light, or at least Ebbe wasn't sure if it was lighter or darker, but he didn't really care this time.

He needed to sleep, but the pain was just too much.

A memory came flooding back to him of his brother's friend beating him up when he was in seventh grade.

Almost every day on his way to school Ebbe would get punched in the face, in the stomach, and even in his kidneys.

He thought then he had learned what real pain was, and how even as a young boy you needed to learn how to fight.

His dad had been a marine who was dishonorably discharged when Ebbe was 13, and he had been away for the better part of six years.

During that time his mom had left him on his own for a lot of the time.

His mom was the one, actually, who got him hooked on cigarettes and then later weed.

Ebbe was getting high every day before and after school, and ended up in the principal's office on a regular basis.

The principal called Ebbe's mother once a week, because to be honest, the principal just didn't have time to deal with him anymore.

The day he thought he had experienced the most pain paled in comparison to he was feeling in the mental hospital.

He was thinking back to when he had been "jumped" by some 16-year-olds on his way to school.

The thing was, they wanted money, and all he had was one dollar.

They surrounded him, the three of them, and they were in a deserted alleyway at least half a block away from school.

There was nobody who was around to hear his screams.

Even if anybody had heard Ebbe's screams, they wouldn't have done anything.

The alleyway was on the poor side of town.

The three punks always preyed on younger kids to teach them who was in charge.

They weren't part of any gang, but they did love to play Russian Roulette every day after school.

They later told the cops who arrested them that they were the ones that had been attacked by Ebbe.

Of course that was the furthest thing from the truth.

But to be honest, Ebbe wasn't one of those wimps who would roll down on the ground and give up.

Ebbe thought back, long before the beating from the three punks, to the time back at his house and the 19-year-old man who would come around to screw his mom at least three times a week.

During this time, Ebbe would go climb the tree in the backyard, and listen to music.

He would pretend he didn't hear them both yelling out in rapture in the back bedroom of the house.

The three guys that left Ebbe bleeding in the alleyway didn't go to the same school that he went to, thank God.

How on earth could he have gone back to school if that was the case?

Ebbe actually got used to the 19-year-old hanging out with him after school now and then.

The guy was really like a dad to Ebbe.

He was really tough, and he taught Ebbe how to fight dirty.

He showed him how to lean back and kick any guy that messed with him as hard as he could in the nuts.

Ebbe thought back again to that hot summer day when he had squared off against his three assailants that had “jumped” him that day as he walked to school by himself.

On that day Ebbe fought dirty, and he managed to kick one so hard in the nuts that his foot hurt like hell.

The supposed leader of the three dropped to the ground, howling out in pain.

Ebbe didn’t hesitate, he jumped on top of him, punching him as hard as he could in the face until it was a bloody mess.

But then of course the other two guys pulled Ebbe off their buddy. One held Ebbe down as they pounded Ebbe in his face.

By some miracle a cop had walked by the alleyway that day.

He had called for backup, but by the time they cop cars had showed up the three guys had run away.

The cop found Ebbe laying on the ground in a pool of blood.

The other cops eventually showed up and took his statement.

Ebbe never did hear if the three thugs were caught or not, but he never ran into them again.

But the pain in the alley that day was nothing compared to how Ebbe was feeling now.

He was trapped in a cage called a mental hospital and had just been given the beating of his life for just trying to escape.

He didn’t cry very often, and it didn’t matter, because at this moment he was beyond crying.

He had been left in his bed, in his room, alone.

As he rested in bed after the worst beating of his life, Ebbe finally relaxed.

The tears flowed down his face and he couldn’t stop them.

Ebbe fell asleep, but in the morning, he was in even more pain if that was possible.

That horrible day when they had dragged Ebbe back into the hospital had occurred at least a week before his good friend Oto had showed up, but it still was fresh in his memory.

After that beating, Ebbe had done his very best to be good, and at least try to follow the rules.

He decided right then and there that he was no longer going to pretend to be the tough kid in this fucking hell-hole that he was trapped in.

Oto and Ebbe had just hit it off, so to speak, from the first day they met.

They both were only a couple of rooms away from each other, and were always hanging out in group therapy.

The nurses were always doing their best to split them up, but they just naturally bonded on a level that Ebbe had never experienced before.

Ebbe's injuries had long healed, and the nurses actually gave him an extra chocolate pudding now and then.

The next day Oto and Ebbe were actually paying attention to the psychologist in a small room filled with about ten other adolescents who had some type of bond with each other.

It is true what they say, that when a group of people go through hell together, they form a life-long bond.

"Oto, do you have something to share with the group today," the psychologist asked him.

Oto decided to share a bit with the group.

He actually ended up telling his story about how he loved to race around in his VW Rabbit.

His stepdad had loved racing fast in cars or even on motorcycles.

For some reason Oto just knew that he had the reflexes of a race car driver.

Oto wasn't really sure how he knew that, but it didn't matter.

On one side of Oto on that day was Ebbe, who was winking at his buddy, slapping him in the arm when the psychologist wasn't looking their way.

Next to Oto was a 17-year-old girl with brown hair who always kept her head down and never smiled.

She had been called on that day in group, and it took her what seemed like a minute to finally look up, staring over at Oto and Ebbe, who were carefully watching the good-looking girl.

Most of the girls in that ward that were separated by empty rooms between the boys and the girls.

If Oto was being honest, he wouldn't waste his time talking to most of the girls there.

He just wasn't that interested in these particular girls, although he had a girlfriend that was still living back in that small town out in the middle of nowhere Nevada.

But they broke up months ago when they went to different colleges.

He usually kept to himself, except when it came to his buddy Ebbe.

It took a long time for the girl to look up, but eventually the therapist convinced her to tell the group why she was locked up like the rest of them.

That was of course the therapist's goal with all of the young kids.

She herself was only 28, and she thought she had a tough childhood.

But the stuff that these kids under 18 had gone through would keep her up at nights.

She would drink Vodka with strawberry soda most every night to get some of the horrific memories to at least go away for a bit.

The young girl in question said it all started when she was thirteen.

There had been a boy her own age in the same class that she was in.

She explained how she loved school, along with reading and writing in her journal whenever she got a chance to do so.

She would catch this young boy in class staring at her, and it actually made her feel uncomfortable.

But the teachers in her classes at school didn't seem to even take notice of this, or if they did, they never said anything.

It was only in Algebra that the boy was ever in a class with her.

Eventually, he got up the nerve to talk to her now and then after class on the way back out to the hallway, filled with students running around after the bell rang between classes.

At the end of the Fall semester she began talking more and more to him after class.

She actually started to feel something for him that she had never felt before with anyone.

She paused, looking up now and then at Oto and Ebbe.

She actually didn't mind watching the two boys enjoy spending time together.

She hadn't made any friends herself.

She looked up at the psychologist who was leading the group, looking the therapist in the eyes for several seconds.

She went back to telling the group her story.

It was at the start of the Spring semester the same year that she again spotted the boy from math class. In that semester she rarely saw him, because she was in the honor track and he wasn't. On that day it was sprinkling just a little bit, which she actually enjoyed. She was flustered a bit, but said hello to him. She asked him what he had been up to and how she actually missed him. Of course she only thought the part about missing him. They started walking together more and more after school and soon became quite close. This time, back in group therapy, she stopped talking and looked over at Oto.

Rather than just shutting down like she usually did, she continued on with her story. She explained how she actually learned how the boy lived only a few blocks East of her home. They then started walking together more often before going their separate ways. Eventually, the boy got up the courage and asked her to go steady with him. She hadn't heard such a thing before. She quietly just said, "yes."

Things were great at first, and they enjoyed holding hands and playing video games together at his house when his parents were still at work. That only lasted for a month or so because he decided to start hanging out more with his guy friends instead of with her. She spent this time reading any book she could get her hands on, and it wasn't long before her school was out for the summer.

One night in particular, although she didn't know it, the boy had been drinking warm beer that he had scored at one of his friend's house.

She explained to the group that he had somehow ended up on her doorstep.

The boy later told her how he was terrified himself, but his "boys" had dared him to do it, and he felt he had no other choice.

She came to the front door of her house and was surprised to see him looking at her like he had all of those months before in math class.

She stared at the floor back in her uncomfortable chair in group as she told the rest of her story, and Oto was now staring straight at her.

She explained in almost a whisper how she started drinking with the same boy and started snorting something that he had given her.

She had never snorted anything before, and the experience left her feeling woozy and disoriented one afternoon at her house when her parents weren't there.

At this point Oto was whispering to Ebbe, but he stopped, and couldn't help but listen to what the girl said next.

"I kept it in the drawer next to my bed at home."

The therapist asked her in a soothing voice, "What do you mean, you kept what in your drawer?"

"It was a blade that I had sharpened," she said.

She didn't say too much after that, but she finished talking by saying, "One night I went too far in my bedroom, cutting too deep into my left thigh."

The next day they were all ushered into the gym that Oto had never seen before.

A record player started up with a Country Western song echoing throughout the empty gym.

One of the therapists was at the front of the large room, and briefly showed them with another therapist how to do the Do-Si-Do.

“You know kids, swing your partner round and round...”

The therapist told them they were not allowed to get more than a foot away from each other, and that if they actually touched anyone, they would be forced to sit down against the wall.

Oto actually refused to dance at first, but he changed his mind as he tapped his foot in time with the song.

Oto actually laughed to himself a bit listening to the horrible song that vibrated from the spinning record player.

Oto didn't hesitate when the girl who talked about the sharp blade decided to “dance” with Oto.

She spun around next to him, and they both locked arms, even though of course they weren't supposed to.

A nurse immediately separated them.

Although she was allowed to keep dancing, Oto was told to go stand in the corner of the gym all on his own.

He felt bad, actually, but he had been getting used to this type of behavior in the cold hospital.

Just like the first day he had been brought into the place, Oto had to sit in a chair against the wall again after he was ushered out of the gym.

This time, however, he was not allowed any crayons or paper to write on.

Writing was actually the only time he felt sort of free.

He just stared at the nurses that would walk by.

They ignored him, chatting about whatever they could, to get through their days dealing with the kids around them.

In that chair, on that day, Oto started counting at 1,000 and worked back as long as he could by 7 until he felt better all alone against the wall.

Chapter 11: 18 Years Old

Oto wasn't sure how or why he knew that he had to be released the next day, but somewhere deep down in his mind he had a feeling it might happen.

Of course the law says that on his 18th birthday he can decide whether to stay or go, and it wasn't even a close decision.

At the time, however, Oto knew nothing about the law and wasn't even sure that it was his birthday.

Oto also didn't bother counting the time between the nurse rounds the night before.

He had managed to stay up almost all night, except for the two hours when he drifted off to sleep.

The morning finally arrived, and he could tell it was morning by the light coming in from the window overlooking that empty alleyway outside of his room.

He looked around at the desk where his clothes had been sitting in unused drawers.

He thought back to the first night in the room.

He slowly took the clothes out, folded them, and carefully placed them at the foot of his bed.

He then sat there, not even bothering to look up at the nurse who did a check on him, who then quickly left the room.

The rest of the morning went by quickly, and before Oto knew it, the time for him to leave had arrived.

Oto carried his clothes out with him that were in a plastic bag with his name written on it with black marker.

Before walking back out the door, the one that he had been gently pushed into two weeks before, he was able to say one last goodbye to his buddy Ebbe.

They were allowed to fist bump, and Oto, of course never saw his good friend again.

It wasn't long before he was escorted over to the same place where he had been processed in by his mom.

He spotted her sitting over in a chair waiting for him.

He played it cool, but gave her a big hug that he could tell surprised her.

Before he knew it, he was out in the sunshine that he really missed.

They had forced him to take Vitamin D pills along with his Lithium when he was locked up, because he was never allowed outside during the day.

Once inside the Blazer, Oto was contemplating whether or not to open the passenger-side door and jump out.

Given how they were still in the parking lot, he decided against it.

"Oto, I don't want to get into an argument, but we are heading straight over to the local junior college and enrolling you in some classes," his mom said.

Oto just sat there and agreed with her, even though he hadn't really heard what she was saying.

Oto was surprised when his mom drove into a parking lot and parked the car.

He immediately saw a sign that said it was a junior college.

As they walked up the long sidewalk to the admission department, Oto spotted a crow that landed nearby.

He loved crows and ravens, because they were the smartest birds, at least that is what Ebbe had told him.

He already missed his good friend.

Oto and his mom walked up to the administration building, standing in the cold hallway with young kids walking around, talking to each other in loud voices.

He walked up to the counter, following his mom.

Behind the counter was a woman who asked if she could help them.

The woman explained that the semester started the next week.

Without even talking to Oto, Ana quickly enrolled her son in an English and a Biology class after filling out the enrollment forms and paying the money that was needed to “seal the deal.”

It wasn't long before Oto and Ana were back out in the Blazer and the loud sounds from at the junior college had been left behind, replaced only with silence in the moving car.

Oto couldn't help himself, and what he said next would haunt him for many years.

“Mom, I am not going to this fucking junior college!”

Ana couldn't even remember her son ever cursing at her in private or in public.

She fought back the tears that were already starting to run down her cheeks, but quickly wiped them away so her son who was looking out the window wouldn't see them.

For the rest of the drive back to the small town, Oto just stared out the window, watching the world pass him by in a blur.

He was just so happy to be free again.

When her son wasn't looking, Ana would look over at her beautiful son, before focusing back on the road.

She could tell he had put on a few pounds, which she was glad to see.

At one point, without even looking in his direction she simply said, "Oto, I don't want to hear another word about the hospital ever again."

Chapter 12: Escape

Oto decided he would keep taking his Lithium, just like he did in the hospital, but really almost more out of habit.

There was no way he was going to be locked up again if he had anything to say about it.

He said over-and-over to himself that he wouldn't stay "confined" to this house that felt more like a prison than anything else.

One difference, though, that Oto was grateful for, was how he had to take his meds.

In the hospital they had forced him to take the shiny Lithium Carbonate pills, and then they would lift his tongue and probe his mouth to be totally sure he had swallowed them.

Ana put his medication out on the kitchen counter, and she watched him take them at the exact times, just like in the hospital.

Thankfully she didn't lift his tongue or probe his mouth.

There was also the strange thing about the scale that his mom had brought home with them.

He had never seen the scale before, so he assumed that she had purchased it before she picked him up from the hospital that day.

It didn't really matter to Oto, but his mom made sure he stepped on that scale in the bathroom and wrote down exactly how much he weighed every morning right after breakfast.

The surprising thing to Oto was that in the mental hospital they had never weighed him, not even once, in the two weeks he was locked up against his will.

Ana drove her son to the junior college every day, which was an hour away from their home in rural Nevada.

She was afraid that she would come home one day and he wouldn't be there.

She was determined to make sure that would never happen.

On the drive each day to the junior college her son mostly looked out the window and wouldn't talk to her that much.

She would drop him off to go to his English and Biology classes that she had signed him up for.

After dropping him off, she would then sneak in some time at her real estate office, before picking him back up again.

Oto played along, but in both the English and Biology classes he just stared out the window, plotting his next move.

It only took a week before Ana was so happy with her son that she decided to leave him alone at home.

She had a good lead on the possible sale of a large ranch, and she needed the money, so she was doing all she could to land the deal.

Oto waited until the second week of classes before telling his mom one morning how he was too sick to go to the junior college that day.

Ana was a little suspicious, but she left him alone at the house, and spent the day showing the ranch that was for sale to some possible buyers.

She decided that she would call him later that afternoon, just to make sure he didn't need some soup or something for her to bring home for him.

Oto waited until his mom was gone for an hour or two before he sprang into action.

He had his 1978 VW Rabbit packed up in twenty minutes.

He then jumped into the car, pulling out of the driveway, and started driving back to the town he had left a few weeks before.

He knew his sister Hannah had only wanted to help him, but he had trusted her, which was why he had agreed to go with her in her blue Honda Accord without even hesitating on that night he left.

His plan was to make it to her house and go from there.

Oto was sweating, because his car had no air conditioning, and one window wouldn't even roll down.

He didn't care at all, because he just knew he was going back to face his demons.

His mom would never understand his decision, but it was his to make.

He was 18 years-old-now and could vote, so he would plot his own path in life.

The four-hour drive back was pretty uneventful at first.

By the time Oto was halfway there, he didn't know it, but his mom was calling him about lunch.

Of course he wasn't there to pick up.

It was at about this same time that his car started "acting" up.

Oto was driving 85 mph behind a big rig on the freeway.

Right before closing in on it, he pulled out into the fast lane to pass it.

For some unknown reason his car slowed down to 40 mph, even though Oto hadn't let up at all on the gas pedal.

Oto was really sweating now, and he quickly swerved back into the slow lane, looking around for a place to pull off the road.

The big rig started closing in on him, but at the last minute his car lurched forward and he found himself speeding back up to 85 again without any pressure at all on the gas pedal.

He took the first exit he could find, pulling off at a gas station and filled up the tank.

Oto was pacing back and forth, trying to figure out what his next option might be.

After deciding he had to just keep driving, Oto paid for the gas, and headed back out onto the freeway.

The car then ran perfectly fine, and two hours later he was speeding down the familiar grade back into the city he had grown so fond of.

He had nowhere else to go, so he parked outside his sister's apartment and knocked on the door.

Hanah opened it, and just stared at her brother grinning on her front porch.

She was shocked, but of course let him in.

As he went to the bathroom, she quickly called her mom, explaining how her brother was in her apartment, and how he had just showed up.

“Mom, what the hell am I supposed to do?”

Four-and-a-half hours later Ana joined her son and daughter in the same apartment.

She of course couldn't stay with him at Hannah's place, so she had Oto follow her in his car to a nearby hotel.

Oto carefully explained to her that he was not going back to Nevada and that if she tried to make him, he would leave in his car and she would never see him again.

Ana was looking into her son's eyes and she could tell he wasn't bluffing.

Ana gave in, because she felt she had no other choice.

Ana and Oto stayed in a cheap hotel for one week.

She needed to find a place for herself to live, and also a place for him as well.

He had never even so much as rented his own place with his own money.

Of course she wasn't thinking that her son had done that very thing a month before in the same town she found herself in.

Ana soon found a small apartment for herself that she rented.

She then found another apartment for her son not far from the junior college.

She paid for his place, because what else could she really do?

The day that Oto was moving in to his new apartment he drove to the junior college he had been going to a month before he had jumped into that car with his sister.

The sun was burning Oto's neck as he walked into the dean's office at the junior college campus that he had been withdrawn from several weeks before.

He was told that the only way he could be re-admitted was to convince a teacher to let him join an English class that was already five weeks in session.

Oto could be persuasive when he had to be, and he found the English teacher, who did that very thing.

Of course, first he told her what had happened to him over the last several weeks, and she took pity on him and got him into her class.

Oto was off to the races.

He had a week to write three essays, and it wouldn't take him long to quickly get that done.

Chapter 13: Oto's Roommate

Oto couldn't sleep in the large bedroom that must have been three times the size of the one where he stayed at in the hospital he had been locked up in against his will a few weeks before.

His mom, Ana, had been generous enough to pay and get him an apartment with a roommate who was several years older than him. His name was Natan.

Still, he was glad to not be watched like a "hawk," and he looked forward to hanging out with his new roommate.

He still had his goal of finishing the essays that he needed to stay enrolled in at the junior college.

Every morning at 6 a.m. the 275-pound giant, his roommate, would start up his turntable and put on his favorite Boston record, cranking the volume up on high.

"It's more than a feeling," he would sing out loud.

Oto, at first, would put his pillow over his head.

But, after a week of this same thing over-and-over again, Oto actually looked forward to watching Natan jump around and sing his songs before taking a shower.

Oto was enjoying hanging out with his roommate and also writing his essays for his English class.

In order for him to keep getting a prescription of Lithium Oto had to talk to a psychiatrist and he found one that would take him on as a patient.

Her name was Graciela, and half the time she worked with the criminally insane, but she ushered Oto into her office and had him sit down in a chair.

“It is nice to meet you,” she said.

Oto smiled at her, and she seemed pretty nice.

“So, I believe you mentioned that you have been diagnosed with manic-depression and that you are taking 900 Mgs of Lithium Carbonate a day?”

“Yes, that is right,” Oto said.

“And you go to the local junior college and have a roommate in an apartment you recently moved into?”

“Yes, I am taking an English class at the JC, and I have been enjoying writing essays that I need to get caught up on.”

Oto was looking at a painting of a girl looking up at a full moon who was standing in some grass in a field.

They talked a bit more about the hospital and how he was feeling.

Oto did his best to talk about his time in the mental hospital, but he didn’t go into a lot of detail, because he didn’t want to think about that place.

It was not something he could really talk much about, except for the fact that he had been locked away and it had been pretty awful.

After a few more exchanges, Graciela wrote Oto a new prescription for Lithium Carbonate pills and scheduled their next meeting for two weeks later.

Oto drove his car back to his apartment and felt relieved that the meeting with his new psychiatrist was over.

He decided not to tell Natan about it once he got back into his place.

Oto only had \$1,500, so he couldn't afford a private psychiatrist, so since seeing Graciela didn't cost much given it was a county facility, he decided to keep seeing her.

Because of this, he had to put up with all of the talk therapy, so he could get his 900 Mgs of Lithium Carbonate.

He had learned not to vomit up the pills in the sink, by chasing the pills that he needed, with chocolate or soda.

Natan was a bouncer at one of the most popular bars in the college town.

Oto soon found out that it was always a happening place that every college kid had to find a way to get into.

Of course, Oto always had a way in with Natan, who would pull him to the front of the line.

Oto could still remember vomiting out front on the sidewalk after drinking too many beers with green olives floating inside the mug.

On that particular night, he had stayed out on the dance floor and relaxed with the strobe lights flickering on and off.

He had accidentally slammed into a 200-pound guy wearing black jeans and a white shirt with no hair sticking out of his shirt anywhere.

He thought that was so strange.

Natan and Oto would hang out a lot, because for the most part they didn't have a lot to do during the day, since neither one of them were working then.

Oto didn't plan on getting a job right away, but he had applied to a few local restaurants to wait tables, but he hadn't heard anything back yet.

On one afternoon Natan showed him how to take a two-pound slab of raw tri-tip and place it onto the counter, carving off any sign of fat at all.

Oto was mesmerized watching Natan massage the tri-tip on the counter as he cut off every scrap of fat.

Natan laughed as he went out and lit a fire with charcoal in the barbecue until he was satisfied with the temperature.

"Bro, you gotta have everything just right."

Oto just laughed as he watched the flames tickle the searing meat on the grill.

Natan told him how he was pretty sure his girlfriend, whom he had been dating for two years, was pregnant.

"We still aren't yet sure whether we will keep it or not," he said, as he balanced a can of Budweiser on his knee as he sat on their couch.

"Are you serious?" Oto asked. "What the hell are you going to do?"

"Well, like I said I am not totally sure yet if she is pregnant. I know she went out today and bought a kit to find out one way or another."

"Natan, you must be so stressed out about all of this?"

Natan explained how they had been careful and how he had been seeing her for the last couple of years. He explained that there was nothing he could do for now until they found out for sure.

A week before the grill-watching, Oto had been at a party with freshman friends from the local junior college that he met in his English class.

Unlike his nights with Natan, there was no delicious tri-tip, and no beer with green olives.

Instead, he was with his freshman buddies at a party where the cops were on their way to break it all up.

They had scored a large bottle of cheap-ass tequila by paying a homeless person to go in and buy it for them.

They had partied out in someone's backyard and were having a great time hanging out.

They would charge anyone from the party five bucks a shot that they would let them drink out of a red plastic cup out behind a tree wet from piss.

Oto was happier than he had been in at least a month.

Oto and his buddies were passing that bottle back-and-forth, and were two sheets to the wind in less than an hour.

As they staggered out front, they avoided the cops that were asking for ID's.

The party was fizzling out anyway, so Oto and his friends were walking across the street.

They would never drive when drunk.

Oto looked at the street they had just walked across and saw a four-door piece-of-shit car roll up on them.

All of the doors swung open at the same time, and some large dudes jumped out onto the pavement.

Oto stood there, as if his feet were frozen to the ground, and just watched as the guys ran over and started punching his friends in the face.

Oto had never actually been in a fist fight before, but his buddies had, and they pushed those dudes down on the ground and were kicking the shit out of them.

Oto saw in slow-motion a fist coming at his face, and somehow managed to block it.

He would later learn at a bar that all of these guys were high on PCP.

The guys got back into their car and drove off. Oto checked with all of his friends and everyone seemed to be okay.

It was the next night at the bar Natan got him into that he met some random guy sitting on a stool that was out near the dance floor.

It was dark, but Oto could see the spider web tattoo on the guy's face.

It went down all the way onto his neck, and it moved with a strange rhythm as Oto told him about how him and his friends had been jumped the night before after a party that the cops had broken up.

Oto had no idea why he was telling this stranger that story.

The stranger just looked at Oto saying how he had heard last night that some friends he knew were high on PCP and jumped some punks at a party.

The tall man explained how he had been in prison for putting a knife inside some stranger during a bar fight, but that he had been released a month ago.

Oto wasn't sure what the odds were of him meeting a stranger with this news, but he decided to believe him.

He went over and talked with Natan for a bit, but told him he was tired so Oto walked home to their nearby apartment and went to sleep.

Natan was always hungry and he loved hanging out with Oto.

One day Natan walked by a neighbor's apartment and saw a nice filet mignon on an outside grill unattended.

Natan just reacted. He grabbed the perfectly cooked medium-rare steak off the grill with his fingers and tossed it back-and-forth from one palm to the next, literally running into their apartment.

Oto was laughing his ass off watching this whole thing go down right outside the front door of their apartment.

Natan ran over to the kitchen counter.

He dropped the sizzling meat onto the cheap-ass countertop.

He took out a steak knife and fork and cut up the bloody meat, eating it as quickly as possible.

Oto declined a bite, and Natan devoured the whole thing, and then wiped off the warm counter with his shirt, before sitting down on their dark brown couch.

This was the same couch where the two of them watched “Days of our Lives” from every day at lunch time.

Oto’s favorite character was of course Patch, and yes of course, like any good pirate he wore a black patch over one eye.

It was at this point, when Natan had flipped on the TV, that they heard a scream from the neighbor next door, no doubt having gone out to take the steak off the grill.

They both laughed so hard until they cried.

The night after the two of them laughed about the steak episode, they had been watching a movie and just hanging out.

“You know what, we should go out and buy a bottle of good tequila. I have some mix and it we can then take a couple of shots and make some margaritas in the blender.

Oto was more than happy to go out on a “tequila run” with his roommate.

They walked out of their apartment and headed toward a liquor store a few blocks away.

Natan knew of a shortcut, so Oto followed him and they soon came to a place where they needed to jump over the railroad tracks to get to the store.

As soon as they went around a corner they saw, unfortunately, that there was a stopped train on the tracks.

“No worries, bro, we can just go up and over. Follow me.”

Natan jumped into one of the empty boxcars, pulling Oto up with him.

“Dude, we aren’t about to let this fucking train stop us, because I am in the mood for some good tequila,” Natan said.

Oto had no idea what good tequila was, but as they moved through the open boxcar to the other side, they felt the train lurch forward, and they both fell on their asses.

Natan immediately jumped off the train, and almost “rolled” his left ankle before hitting the sharp rocks on the ground that can always be found on the railroad tracks.

Oto thought he heard Natan scream at him that if he didn’t jump he would end up in the next town.

That was all that Oto needed to hear. He just reacted and jumped out without thinking.

He had no problem landing on his feet like a spider that jumps from a blade of grass.

“Jesus Christ, Natan. Did we really need to save five minutes to get to this store?”

“Come on, man, my ankle is hurting, but I will be okay.”

Natan went into the smelly liquor store without hesitating and stole the tequila right off the shelf.

They both ran as fast as they could back to their apartment, which was easier to do now that the train had passed off the tracks heading North in the night.

Unlike the cheap tequila that Oto was used to swallowing that burned his throat, the tequila in the bottle that they had scored was like drinking water.

It wasn’t long before his lips were numb.

Natan made up some great blended margaritas, and although it would be years before he could legally drink alcohol he decided right then and there that margaritas were his favorite drink.

The night after the tequila episode, Natan had left a pot full of rice on the stove the night before, and they were both recovering from a hangover.

Oto just sat there and watched his roommate turn over the pot onto the counter.

Natan massaged the white rice into what looked like a discus hurled at a track meet.

Once outside the front door of the apartment, Natan swirled it around in a circle.

The small white missile then flew through the air, splattering on the door of the nearby apartment where the steak incident had occurred.

The rice broke up into hundreds of pieces, and again, about ten minutes later they heard another yell from their neighbor.

Chapter 14: The Apache Truck

It was a sunny day, and Oto and his roommate took a drive out to the countryside in Natan's old Apache truck that his grandpa had gifted to him.

Oto didn't know what year the truck had been built, but it was so old that there weren't even seat belts in it.

Natan loved "gunning" the old truck over the speed bumps in the parking lot of their apartment complex.

On this particular day Oto wasn't paying attention, and his nose hit the glass of the windshield after Natan slammed on the brakes.

The tires hit the speed bump with full force.

Oto's eyes watered, and he tasted a little blood, but Natan just laughed his ass off.

Oto had the window down in the Apache truck as Natan drove it at 50 mph back on an old country road, until they got to a tree line out in the middle of nowhere.

He pumped the brakes a couple of times until the truck came to a stop.

“Check this out, Oto, I have a surprise for you.”

They both hopped out of the truck.

Oto looked all around, but there was nobody except for birds in the area.

He thought that he heard an old crow cawing nearby.

Natan hopped up into the back of the bed of the truck and pulled away an old tarp that Oto had missed somehow.

“What the hell is that, Natan?” Oto asked.

Natan lifted a semi-automatic rifle that was belt-fed out of the bed of the old truck.

He didn’t waste any time, and he wrapped the “belt” around his forearm just like in the Rambo movies.

Natan smiled, aiming at the dirt road ahead, letting the bullets fly.

Oto watched with fascination as the giant bullets slammed into the ground, throwing up dirt and dust.

Natan yelled out at the top of his lungs as the blood pumped in his veins and surged in his big neck.

There was no way that Oto would even have the strength to fire the gun, and he was relieved that Natan didn’t ask him to.

“Dude, wasn’t that awesome?” Natan asked.

“I have never seen anything like it, that’s for sure. Where the hell did you get that gun and where do you keep it?”

“Don’t worry, bro, it isn’t my gun. It belongs to an old friend that I have and he trusted me enough to take it out here and try it out.”

Natan was again relieved, because he knew they didn't have a gun at all in their place, much less something like that.

Natan carefully covered that gun back up with the tarp and they drove back home, but first stopped at the friend's house so Natan could give him the gun back.

Even though Oto and Natan shared the same bedroom, Natan had a queen-size bed, whereas Oto only had a twin.

At least three times a week Natan's girlfriend would stay over. It turned out that she wasn't pregnant, and Natan had told Oto the good news a few days ago.

That is when he learned about the sock being on the doorknob.

On those nights when he stumbled in from a late-night party, Oto would see the sock on the doorknob to the bedroom, and he then knew he had to go and sleep downstairs on the couch.

On those nights, after crashing on the lumpy brown couch, he would wake up the next morning with a hangover and a stiff back.

On afternoons when it was hot in the apartment, and they were tired of watching TV, Oto and Natan would go out to the rec room and play pool.

Natan would bring all of his dirty socks with him and stuff them into the pool table pockets.

That was how Oto learned how to play an afternoon of pool after paying only fifty cents.

Oto did his best playing pool against his roommate, but he never was very good at it.

"Oto, what the hell is wrong with you? You told me you were good at math, but if you know Geometry at all, you should be able to beat me playing pool."

It was a Saturday night, and Oto was carefully slicing the fat off a tri-tip the way he had been taught, when the phone rang.

He quickly wiped his greasy fingers off before picking up, and was surprised to hear Natan's girlfriend on the other end.

"Oto, something terrible has happened. Natan ran a red light and crashed his truck after almost running down an old man walking in the crosswalk."

Oto was listening to every word she said, and then she paused before saying, "He called me from jail because he has been arrested for drunk driving."

The next couple of days went by in a blur.

Oto went down and visited Natan, who was locked up because he had failed to tell him that he had been arrested three years before for drunk driving.

Natan explained how one night last year when he had too much to drink, he drove himself home.

He ended up crashing into a power pole, and fled the scene.

Natan explained how a policeman had knocked on his door before arresting him, taking him away in cuffs, and reading him his rights.

"Why the hell did you never tell me this, Natan?"

"I don't know to be honest. It was never something I really liked to talk about."

"I am just in shock from all of this. What is going to happen to you?"

Natan looked at his roommate, but he was told that he could only talk to Oto for a few more minutes because his time was about up.

"Oto, I only had one final class before I could graduate, but I am going to be in here for a few weeks, so I think I will miss my college graduation."

Oto had no idea what he was going to do for the summer, and he was busy with his final essays in his English class.

The last thing he heard from Natan before his roommate was ushered out of the visiting area was, “The lease isn’t up on our place until the end of next month, and we are paid up, so you get the place to yourself.”

The apartment was pretty lonely without Natan around, but Oto did his best to stay busy.

He stopped drinking alcohol and of course he was no longer able to get into the popular bar downtown.

He would stay out late almost every night, though, since he had been notified that he got a B- in his English class.

He had been hoping for an A, but he was still happy with the outcome.

Chapter 15: Greyhound

Prior to Natan getting put in county jail for his second DUI, he drove Oto to the four-year college that he was supposed to graduate from.

They both walked up the steps and into an old dilapidated trailer that had job bulletins pinned to a corkboard.

“Natan, what the hell are we doing here?” Oto asked.

“Look, dude, you asked me to help you get a job, and that is what I am doing,” Natan said.

Natan pulled a 3x5 card off the board that read “Shipping and Receiving,” handing it to Oto.

“Call this number when we get back to the apartment.”

Oto called the number on the 3x5 card, and a woman answered on the other end.

“Hello, there, I am looking for a job,” he said.

Before he knew it, he was on his way to the address he had been given for an interview.

Oto picked out his best shirt and a pair of clean blue jeans, quickly put them on, and then raced over to the address he’d been given.

He would later discover that there was an old Greyhound sign in the parking lot that he hadn’t noticed.

He walked into the depot, which he also didn’t know was a Greyhound depot.

The woman who Oto talked to on the phone was there to greet him.

She had her blonde hair up in a tight bun.

She looked Oto over up and down, telling him to follow her into her office, which was located in a corner of the empty building.

She had him sit across from her behind a desk.

After exchanging some pleasantries, she got down to business.

“Can you lift 50 pounds, Oto?”

Oto looked at her and just answered honestly. “Sure, who can’t lift 50 pounds?”

“Have you ever worked hard and taken initiative?”

Oto paused a bit, but then responded in the affirmative.

“Okay, Oto, you are hired,” she said.

He couldn’t believe what she was saying, but he was more surprised when she told him he had to start that very minute.

He said “sure, why not?”

She took him into the back of the large building, and wrote his name down on a time sheet, “punching” him in to start a shift.

He ended up working a few hours and was trained on how to fill out paperwork to accept packages.

He was then taken out back and shown an empty Greyhound bus that was idling in the parking lot, belching out diesel that reminded him of his grandpa.

Of course at that point he knew he was somehow working for Greyhound.

His grandpa had driven over 3 million miles in his 32 years that he drove buses for Greyhound.

He actually started driving them during World War II to transport soldiers to and from training camps to board planes and head to the front lines.

This was why his grandpa had not been shipped out himself.

After all, someone had to drive the buses.

His grandpa limped around just when getting out of his recliner, due to driving those miles in a bus that had a clutch, rather than an automatic transmission.

Oto had been working most every day at the Greyhound depot the two weeks before his roommate was put in jail for that second DUI.

He actually liked it because it kept him busy, and of course he was making some money.

It must have been about a week after Natan was put away and Oto had the place to himself that he went to a party with one of his co-workers from the depot.

The co-worker who had a “nose” for weed had just scored a box of it from underneath the bin of an idling bus.

She put it in her locker and would later smuggle it home to weigh out the “killer shit” and sell it.

At least that was her goal, but she later told Oto that she ended up smoking half of it.

He hung out at her party for a couple of hours.

For some reason she also told him to go and grab the Absolut Vodka out of the freezer.

She didn’t have any tequila, and Oto wasn’t a fan of drinking vodka, so he just gave her the bottle.

She took a swig right out of the bottle before wiping her mouth off with the back of her hand.

She then placed a small line of “coke” on the top of her hand and with a rolled-up dollar bill she snorted it all up.

She said it would even everything out and she could finally feel good.

Oto didn’t stay much longer and headed home to his empty apartment.

He really missed Natan, but he had only gone back once to visit him.

He felt bad about that, but it was not a great time to talk about how his roommate was arm wrestling for extra peanut butter and jelly sandwiches.

One day in the hot sun, Oto walked toward the bus out on the lot that had been sitting there for 24 hours.

He had lost the coin toss with his co-worker, so he had to go into the bus and, using a coat-hanger, unclog the yellow and orange vomit that filled the sink in the bathroom at the back of the bus.

The smell nearly made him vomit as the chunky mess that had been baking in the heat of the bus fell into the blue liquid that he had grown used to smelling in the toilet.

Oto then exited the horrible mess and switched places with his co-worker, who then went to the bus bathroom, mopping up the vomit and cleaning out the sink.

Oto had to work the graveyard shift, and in order to do his homework he would “busy” out the five incoming lines so that the lights on the old phone would light up so nobody could call in and disturb him.

That worked well until an irate customer walked in and saw the lights all lit up, and Oto reading from his giant William Shakespeare book.

“Look, who the hell do you think you are? I have been calling in for the last hour and can’t get through.”

“Why do you have all of those calls on hold?” he asked.

Oto just looked at him and noticed the sweat beading up on the man’s forehead.

“I need a bus down to LA, and I want you to sell me a ticket right this instant!”

Oto looked the man in the eyes before saying, “I have them busied out so I can do my homework.”

The man got calm and stormed out of the depot, but not before saying how he would be back the next day to report him to his supervisor.

It was around half an hour later that same night when Oto was once again interrupted from his studies.

This time, however, he kept hearing a loud smacking sound.

Oto looked over and saw a homeless man sitting cross-legged in one of the old white chairs across the depot.

The man was chanting and hitting himself on the top of his head with all of his might.

Oto was a little surprised, because the plastic chairs were intentionally designed to be uncomfortable so that customers waiting for their bus would not sit for too long.

The next day, Oto’s boss had him report to her office, where she had him sit down in the same chair that she had hired him in.

“Oto, is it true that you busied out the incoming lines so you could do your homework last night?”

“What are you talking about?” he said.

“How do you do that?”

“Oto, some man called me this morning and said he drove over last night and you wouldn’t even sell him a ticket.”

Oto looked at her desk before replying, “You know I don’t really even know how to sell tickets. You said you were going to train me on the tickets so I didn’t have to just work the baggage.”

Oto’s boss trained him the next afternoon, quickly showing him how to sell tickets for passengers wanting to ride the stench-filled buses, where homeless and those without much money, would manage to ride in.

She spent maybe fifteen minutes training him on how to use paper tickets and look up routes in a giant book the size and shape of his giant Shakespeare book.

Oto did his best to follow along, but he honestly wasn’t paying complete attention because he knew he would probably be trained for weeks before having to sell the tickets by himself.

The depot was empty one morning, so his boss left for an early lunch break, but instead of the usual half hour she was gone for an hour.

It was during this time that two vans pulled up out back, and about 35 prisoners were led into the depot and lined up in single file like they were in kindergarten.

What Oto didn’t know at the time was that they had to take a bus back to the city where they committed their crime.

And they had all clearly been lifting weights for months and glared at Oto, who was standing behind the big glass “wall” that separated him from the pissed-off convicts.

Oto felt like shitting himself, but somehow instinct just kicked in, and he dealt with the first convict and asked him where he was going.

“Oceanside, you dipshit.”

Oto knew he had to get the angry man with tattoos on his forehead to Los Angeles where he could then catch a connecting bus to Oceanside.

He wasn’t sure how he did it, but he found the information with codes that he needed to enter into the old IBM computer, and managed to print the ticket.

He took the 40-dollar bill from the inmate, gave him his ticket, and put the money in the register.

The sweat running down Oto’s back started to dry up.

He got through the entire line just as his boss returned from lunch.

She looked at Oto just standing there and told him to get back to work.

Oto was starving late one evening as he worked the counter by himself.

He walked over to the greasy spoon cafeteria that was connected to the depot to load up on some French fries.

One look at the buffet made him feel queasy, so he changed his mind, but not before running right into some crazy old woman yelling about having to take a piss.

She walked past him and grabbed some napkins off a table in the empty cafeteria, pulled up her dress, and promptly squatted down and took a long piss on the floor.

The woman had no underwear on, and Oto saw her entire lower body.

He would do his best later on to try and get the image out of his head.

The woman calmly walked up to the buffet counter, grabbed some napkins from the dispenser, squatted down again and wiped herself clean.

She then tossed the wet napkins into her warm puddle of piss.

Oto left the cafeteria, ignoring the pool of urine on the floor, and decided to get his favorite peanut butter Grandma cookies out of the nearby dispenser.

One of Oto's favorite bus driver decided to play a joke one day when the depot was swarming with passengers waiting to board the idling buses out back in the parking lot.

The bus driver opened the glass door, that had the number three in an old sign, located above the inside of the door to the depot.

The driver was wearing dark sunglasses, and holding a cane used by blind people.

He began tapping the "cane" on the depot floor, calling out to the passengers that the bus would be leaving shortly for San Francisco and that he was the driver.

Oto laughed his ass off until a woman in line nearly fainted, falling to the tiled floor.

Oto quickly ran over and helped her back up, not wanting to fill out the 10-page form so that she wouldn't sue Greyhound.

Oto had been trained by his boss to drive a bus over a metal grate that had a place for a hook in the middle of it in order to clean out the bathrooms in the back of the buses.

He actually got to drive the buses off the back lot, and was quite good at knowing exactly where to park to "clean" out the shitters.

He knew by now that he had to position the bus directly under the plate and then use a long metal hook on wheels to lift the plate and pull it back.

He then had to pull the handle located on an open side panel at the back of the bus that released the blue liquid full of shit and piss and God knows what else down into the "pit."

He would then yank on the handle inside the bus panel that he had opened, dumping the sloshy stench that would drop into a wire "filter" to catch the solid waste.

Everything else from used condoms to used tampons would stay in the filter and let all of the blue fluids drain down into the open sewer pit.

He was also trained to jump back at the same time to avoid feces from landing on his face and clothes.

One day when the depot was mostly empty, Oto had to train a new co-worker on how to dump the shitter on a bus.

On that day Oto was devouring his bean burrito, minus onions, with extra cheese.

He was sitting in one of the blue-cushioned chairs behind the counter, when his boss walked over to him.

“Oto, put down that burrito right this instant and train your co-worker here on how to dump a bus,” she said.

Oto did as he was instructed.

He put down his burrito, and had the lazy dipshit follow him out back to train him.

Oto, of course failed to tell him that once out at the exposed pit how you have to jump back after pulling the handle.

The poor guy yanked the handle and just stood there as shit and piss sprayed all over him.

Oto walked back behind the counter, picked up the half-eaten burrito without washing his hands, and quickly ate it before the next buses pulled in.

It was about a month later that Oto’s brother Kanak called him up one night.

“Bro, I just moved here to Anaheim and I really need a job. Do you have any leads or a way to help me out with that?”

Oto loved Kanak and would do anything for him.

They had grown up in the same house, of course, and they were pretty close in age and also told each other their secrets and goals in life.

The next day while working an early shift, Oto begged his boss to send the Greyhound Anaheim depot manager a letter of recommendation so Kanak could start working there.

Oto's brother worked a few weeks at the Anaheim Greyhound depot, but got sick and tired of dealing with the traffic and homeless people that would "take over" the bus depot at all times of the day and night.

Kanak called Oto up one morning and asked if he could maybe work with him up on the Central Coast instead of in Anaheim.

A couple of days later, Oto begged his boss to let Kanak work with him.

Oto was one of the best working employees that she had hired in years, so she gave in, and Kanak moved up and stayed with his brother.

Kanak had to work the graveyard shift, so like a vampire he could only come out at night to work, and then go back to sleep just as the sun was coming up.

Anyone who has worked graveyard shifts can attest to this, and unless you hang out with other people who work graveyard shifts, it can feel very isolating.

The timing was perfect, though, because this was the same time that Oto's roommate, Natan, was locked up in county jail from his second DUI, so there was plenty of room for Kanak to crash on his brother's couch.

It only took Oto two weeks to convince their boss that Kanak needed to start working day shifts with him.

Again, Oto's boss gave in and in two week's time Oto and Kanak had so many adventures at the Greyhound depot.

One night when Oto was working with his brother, the two of them had to lock up the empty depot and wax the floors with a special buffing machine that was hard to use.

It was a process that took three hours, and the two of them had to go up into the attic inside the mop room to get the cleaning supplies that they needed.

Up in the small janitor's closet there was an attic in the ceiling that only Oto and his boss knew about.

He reached up above the top shelf, opening up the attic door, before pulling down several plastic jugs.

He was careful, because he knew how the jugs contained a "stripping" liquid that was used to burn off mold from the inside of swimming pools that had been drained and were dry.

Once a week Oto had to pour the liquid acid inside of a small spray bottle.

He would then use it to clean out the urinals in the men's bathroom without having to scrub them with a brush.

The acid was so strong that sometimes it would melt the little plastic coverings where men can do their best to aim their hot stream into them for target practice.

His boss had cheated the system, squirreling away other products such as "stripper" and a special liquid wax.

She had to order all of these supplies from a special distributor, paying cash for them so they couldn't be tracked by the Greyhound accountants that worked in Dallas, Texas at the time.

Oto and Kanak finished polishing the depot floor until they could see their smiling faces on the glowing red tiles.

Their boss would later win an award for the cleanest bus depot on the West Coast.

The two brothers worked at the busy bus depot until the end of that summer, working shifts together and partying with Oto's friends.

It was a good time for them both to quit, though, because they got tired of dealing with co-workers who would just outright steal money out of the cash registers behind the counter.

No matter how much money was missing, the next day for some reason, Oto and Kanak would always get the blame.

It was the end of the summer and both Oto and Kanak quit on the same day.

They hadn't really planned exactly what they were going to do, but they had both saved up some money and weren't too worried about their immediate future.

It wasn't long before the lease was up on Oto and Natan's apartment.

Oto and his brother both then decided it was a good time to get new jobs, and figure out where they would live next.

They always cherished those times they had together in life, and would later laugh along with their grandpa, telling him about their adventures whenever they would see him.

Part 2: Locked Up

For the next 23 years or so, Oto went through life religiously taking 900 Mgs of Lithium Carbonate, just liked when he was locked up against his will in the second mental hospital in his life.

The first dosage of 300 Mgs was taken at 12 noon and the second 600 Mgs of Lithium Carbonate was taken at 2 p.m.

Nobody, unless they have taken Lithium Carbonate for that long, can know what it is like.

Oto couldn't describe it, until his senses came back to him after switching off Lithium to save his life, because his kidneys were almost in renal failure.

The way Oto would later describe it to friends and family is that it was like being trapped in a large bubble, unable to feel real emotions.

The trade-off, however, was that he lost a lot of memories in those 23 years.

He would later recall almost all of his medium- and long-term memories.

This happened, because loved ones and friends that supported him and stuck by him through thick-and-thin, would tell him about their memories of spending time with him.

A neurologist later explained that with all of those years on Lithium, any type of trauma or even accomplishments that he managed to pull off were blocked at a molecular level.

This caused what he would think of as “gray pockets” to form on the inside of his brain.

These “gaps” in his memory would later dissipate, and a CT scan would verify that they were not present in his brain at that time, when he was 40-years-old

Doctors who had devoted their lives to understanding the brain, as best they could, had no explanation of the fact that with a CT scan there was no longer any gray pockets in Oto’s brain.

Oto’s kidneys, from taking so much Lithium Carbonate for so many years, formed crystals in them.

These crystals prevented, in some fashion, to prevent the normal flow of “wastes” to be filtered from his blood stream.

Anyone that has lost control of his or her brain due to a disease they are born with can tell you, if they survive it, that is the scariest thing in the world.

Oto had his own business during a good portion of the 23 years that he successfully controlled his Bipolar 1 illness that he was born with.

Although he made more than 150k one year, he still felt like a failure, because his goal was to make 1 million a year.

During those 23 years he would attend one 30-minute session, with a private psychiatrist, that he would pay out of pocket for.

The psychiatrist, who treated Oto for those 23 years, couldn't believe how stable he was.

He made the decision to prescribe a year's worth of Lithium Carbonate after only seeing him for 30 minutes once a year.

Somehow Oto was able to pack in the history of all he had accomplished during the previous year into 20 minutes.

The rest of the time in each session was reserved for Oto to pay his psychiatrist, and to set up another appointment for the next year.

Afterwards, he was prescribed a lab check to get all of the numbers from a multitude of tests returned to him.

Oto would later pass these results on to his psychiatrist.

Unfortunately for Oto, even though the private psychiatrist treated a good portion of Bipolar 1 patients for his thriving practice, he was wrong about Oto's prognosis.

But Oto had formed a pretty close bond with his psychiatrist over so many years.

At least as close a bond you can form with a medical professional, who controlled whether or not Oto would continue taking the light metal in the shiny pill casings, so he could live a so-called "normal" life.

The fear of dying, since Oto would soon need a kidney transplant or face certain death, is what led him after several years of worrying, to taper off Lithium Carbonate slowly and then taper onto a drug called Lamictal.

Doctors today have no idea why Lithium works as a treatment for Bipolar 1, but it was first discovered in the 1950's and thus has many decades of studies.

There have been millions of actual Bipolar 1 patients that have been successfully medicated who can then do amazing things in life.

Lamictal was created in the 1970's and it was originally used to treat epilepsy, but it was never that effective.

By accident, really, it was used in a controlled study on a group of Bipolar 1 patients.

Lamictal is even more effective than Lithium Carbonate, but it too has side effects.

To start with, once you taper off Lithium Carbonate and on to Lamictal you have to start with a 100 Mg dosage.

If you are unlucky enough to develop a large rash on your neck and chest, you must immediately be rushed to an emergency room and have a blood transfusion.

Without this procedure you will most likely die.

Luckily for Oto, he didn't develop the rash that can occur from using Lamictal.

After going off Lithium and on to the Lamictal, Oto had a 6-month manic episode that he hadn't had since he was 17-years-old.

His dosage went from 100 Mgs of Lamictal to 125 Mgs, to 150, and all the way up to 200 Mgs.

Oto can happily report today that he is stable with no full-blown mania or depression and is back on 200 Mgs of Lamictal.

Just look at many of the most successful doctors, lawyers, actors, writers and so on in this country and throughout the world and if they are truthful and not protecting their “secret” identity they will tell you that they also were born with Bipolar 1.

Science is always advancing.

Doctors and others who study the brain, really don’t know a whole lot about Bipolar 1 disorder, given its complexities.

They can only tell you a relatively small number of things compared to say, the kidneys, even though of course how the brain is the most important organ in the body.

Someone who is lucky, or unlucky enough to be born with Bipolar 1, experiences the symptoms from what is described as a “down swing,” or an “upswing.” This is also called mania or depression, depending upon the strain, or type of the illness.

Oto would not know any of this until he studied it and figured some of it out for himself.

As a result, during those 23 years of potential up and down swings, for Oto the illness was mostly masked, allowing him to go through life in a fairly normal way.

Sure, he would have some extra energy in the Fall, and not so much energy in the Spring each year.

Most “normal” people without a mental illness feel somewhat similar due to the natural changing of the seasons.

Although Oto would feel this extra energy during the Fall, it wouldn’t distract him from doing his job or functioning on a daily basis.

During the Spring time, however, Oto would feel a high level of anxiety.

This would cause him to miss a few days of work for two to three days, or maybe a week.

He would take it easy and not work during this time.

Part 1 of Oto's journey covers from when he was roughly 17-years-old to when he was around 40 years-old.

Part 2 will cover the year when he turned 40, and that is a wild tail that you can read in these subsequent pages.

After reading this novel, you may learn a few things about Bipolar 1.

The story of Oto in this novel is hopefully one that you enjoy reading.

Just follow along, as best you can, especially if you are not part of the say one percent of the human population on earth that is born with an illness called Bipolar 1.

This tale, if you take the time out of your busy life to read it, is something hopefully that you will find of amusement or horror, and perhaps it covers what it is truly like to live with Bipolar 1.

This novel is Oto's journey.

It is fiction, and Royce Scratch has done painstaking amounts of time and research to bring this piece of fiction to life.

Although Royce Scratch has no idea what Bipolar 1 can feel like, or even know anything about the illness other than his research, he has done his very best to provide some illumination on what must be a very difficult disease to deal with.

It has taken him more than a decade to bring this tale to life, but there is only so much time in a day, and Royce had his own life to live and deal with.

But, again, Royce Scratch has no doubt fallen short many times during the writing of this novel.

As the large percentage of the world-wide human population without a mental illness can attest to, anyone that is born with Bipolar 1 must indeed have a life full of ups and downs and struggles.

The goal of this novel is to try and shed some light on Bipolar 1 in this country, and perhaps throughout the world, in hopes that it can be useful or maybe even entertaining.

Whether or not this is the case, it took Royce Scratch many years of deep research and doing whatever he could do to bring this fiction to light.

From all of the painstaking research and years that Royce Scratch spent on this short novel, really a novella, can attest to, science is always evolving and being tested against new theories that are constantly being discovered.

So, pick up this book, pay for it, and if you only read part of it or the entire novel, Royce Scratch will be happy with anything you take or don't take away from it.

You can purchase it in digital format or in print.

Chapter 16: Lithium

Over the 23 years that Oto used Lithium Carbonate to prevent any ups or down, his levels of Lithium in his body were extremely accurate.

The levels would always average between .05 and .06.

He forgot what the numbers meant, but he knew if he was going to be allowed to keep taking his meds, he had to hit those numbers, which involved getting blood draws quite often.

They would typically pull a five-vial blood-draw out of his arm to check all of his levels, especially the levels of creatinine that showed any damage to his kidneys.

The drawback, of course, was that due to taking Lithium, the side effects made him feel like he lived in a bubble, which dulled his senses.

The main side effects from the drug were diminished taste and smell, and even tremors in his hands.

During the 30 minutes once a year that Oto would meet with his private psychiatrist they would talk about talented actors, singers, and artists that have been diagnosed with Bipolar 1.

He, himself, kept his Bipolar 1 illness secret from everyone except his family and close friends.

Oto always worried that someone would discover his secret, and what that might mean for him.

His immediate family, though, was really good about keeping secrets.

Oto had been “stuck,” and blood pulled out of his right arm, many times over the course of his life.

But he still refused to watch the needle go into his vein.

He could feel the needle go in, and if the phlebotomist was skilled, he or she could get in the vein without much pain at all.

The secret, Oto knew, was that when the vein would roll, the best-of-the-best would anticipate that roll and stick the needle where it would go.

Oto knew exactly when to take his meds late at night, to the hour, to get the result he wanted.

He knew exactly what time to take the 600 mgs of Lithium Carbonate, and go into the lab exactly 12 hours later.

To do this, Oto just had to take the pills late at night, preventing him from getting a good night’s sleep, which dehydrated him.

He would also have to deal with the strong metallic taste of Lithium, which was typically something he dealt with, but not at this level.

As Oto tried to get to sleep, he thought back to one experience he had when he was 11 years old.

His mom and stepdad left him with his younger brother Kanak and his older sister Hanah.

The three of them were sitting down on the kitchen floor, playing with sharp knives, after just moving into their home in Georgia.

Ana and her husband were busy moving in to their new house, and weren’t paying much attention to them.

Oto still felt guilty about what happened next, even all these years later.

He had picked up the largest butcher knife and held the dull end against his thumb.

“Kanak, check this out,” Oto said.

After running the dull end of the knife against his thumb, he simply said, “That didn’t hurt.”

Kanak quickly grabbed the knife out of Oto’s hand, putting the sharp edge of the knife up to his own thumb.

“Kanak, don’t do it, Oto yelled out, but it was too late.”

Oto watched in horror as his brother pulled the knife against his thumb.

Instantly, blood began puddling out on the kitchen floor, and the flesh of his thumb was hanging off the bone.

“Holy shit,” Hanah exclaimed.

Without thinking, Kanak just reacted, putting his thumb in his mouth.

In seconds, Kanak’s mouth filled up with blood, spraying out in a pool on the cold kitchen floor.

At this point, Ana looked around and saw what was happening.

“Oh my god,” she said and quickly ran over to Kanak.

She lifted him up by the armpits, pulling him over to the kitchen sink.

She turned on the cold water, put her younger son’s thumb under the faucet, and watched as the blood and water swirled down the drain.

Kanak’s face was white.

He was, after all, in shock and couldn’t even feel his thumb.

Oto and Hanah watched the entire scene.

His mom and stepdad were arguing about who would rush their brother to the emergency room.

Ana won that argument, so she got her son into the car and raced over to the nearest emergency room five miles away.

Luckily for Kanak, he only needed about 20 stitches in his thumb, and he didn’t lose any mobility in it.

Three weeks later, when his siblings were out water-skiing on a lake that was a sheet of glass, Kanak had to sit inside a cabin, trying not to cry.

Ana's good friend had stayed behind with Kanak, and she had volunteered to use scissors to cut away the stitches in Kanak's thumb.

As the stitches gave way to the scissors, Kanak yelled out in pain.

She just looked at him and asked him to stop squirming.

"Suck it up, you need to face pain and not let it get the best of you."

Many years later, at the lab, Oto watched the blood swirl and slosh around inside the small tubes.

He would count one after the other until they added up to five.

He still couldn't watch the needle in his arm piercing his strong veins.

He was given the piece of cotton swab to press onto the "wound," and then had his arm wrapped in blue gauze.

His ritual that he always followed was to then go directly to a donut shop, order three of his favorite donuts, and then eat them as quickly as possible, washing them down with some cold milk.

Chapter 17: Kidneys

Oto was writing in his office from home, looking out the window, and enjoying the warmth from the sun shining on him.

He had received some unfortunate news from the lab results about his kidneys.

The creatine levels were very high and his doctor had scheduled an ultra sound for Oto to see if there was any kidney damage.

He had never had an ultra sound procedure, and he was worried about what it would reveal about his kidneys, even though he had adopted a modified diet several years before.

The morning for the ultra sound finally arrived, and Oto drove to the hospital trying to ignore the anxiety that he was feeling.

Once in the doctor's office, he took off his shirt, and positioned his body and breathing the way he was instructed.

The gel was cold and it was uncomfortable as the "wand" was pushed with force into where his kidneys were at.

Oto just focused on a happy memory he always went to when in stress that was on a beach in Maui.

Oto waited in the same room, and it wasn't long before his doctor came back in.

"Well, Oto, I have some tough news for you," the doctor said.

Oto knew that the word "tough" wasn't a good one coming from a doctor, so he braced for the worst.

"I'm afraid there seem to be crystals, or some type of mass in both kidneys, based on the images I looked over."

Oto looked down at the floor as the doctor continued. "It is my opinion that all of the years of taking Lithium has taken a toll on your kidneys," he said.

Oto now looked up at the doctor before the doctor continued, "Just to be sure, I am going to schedule to have you take a CT scan with another doctor."

Several weeks later, Oto walked into another hospital to have the CT scan done.

This was the third time that he had been given a CT scan in his life, so he pretty much knew what to expect.

He had to lay down and stay absolutely still as his body moved in and out of the noisy machine.

Of course, the radiologists would stay up in a booth and be protected from the "radiation" that came from the machine.

Oto had to wait quite a while out in the hallway before getting his results.

He was shocked to see a man on a gurney with blood seeping out from a fresh wound on his leg out in the waiting room.

Oto looked at the poor man, and asked him if he was okay.

“I think I will be fine, but they are working on my wife in another room. I don’t know how she is doing.”

It was uncanny about how many times in Oto’s life that complete strangers felt comfortable telling them their life stories in a few minutes.

“We were hit head-on while driving to my mom’s house for dinner, and my wife is eight months pregnant.”

The bleeding man went on.

“All I know is that the EMT’s mentioned on the scene that they were confident that my wife would be okay, but they weren’t sure about the baby. I just need to see her, but they won’t let me in the room.”

Oto never saw the man again.

He was led back into the doctor’s office.

He was so nervous he was shaking quite a bit.

Oto was told to sit down in a chair in the corner, which he of course did, and the doctor gave him the news.

“After reviewing the results of the CT scan, we can see crystals in your kidneys. Based on the stage they seem to be in, my best guess is that you are headed toward renal failure that requires dialysis.”

Oto thought back to when he was 17, and was told he needed an emergency appendectomy, but that turned out not to be the case.

He was also told he had diabetes at the time, but that turned out to be negative as well.

“So, doctor, you said something about dialysis?” Oto asked.

“Doesn’t that have something to do with being hooked up to a machine and having your blood recycled?”

“Well, actually,” the doctor continued, “that certainly is one option.”

“But there is another one called Peritoneal Dialysis.”

The doctor continued, and Oto did his best to “soak” it all in.

He did his best to absorb all of the medical jargon being thrown his way.

“A special fluid is washed in and out of the belly to soak up the waste. The good news is that you can have this done at home, perhaps even when you are asleep.”

The doctor then went on to cover how, after that stage, if his kidney’s continued to worsen, he would either need to get a kidney transplant or die.

Oto left the hospital and went back to his home office.

He sat back down to write something, anything, to get the news from the doctor out of his head.

It wasn’t long before he forgot all about his kidneys.

Oto had scheduled an appointment with his psychiatrist so he could share the unfortunate news about his kidneys.

His psychiatrist of many years was reviewing the medical notes that had been sent over from Oto’s doctors.

Oto looked down at his feet, trying not to squirm around on the black couch.

He laughed at the thought of his friends that had never even talked to a psychiatrist always saying that everyone has to lay down on a couch when talking to a shrink.

The truth is that you usually sit down on a couch, but you certainly don’t lay down.

Oto's psychiatrist cleared his throat, waiting for his patient to look back up at him.

"I really think it is time for you to move off of Lithium, given the damage it has done to your kidneys," he said.

"I am writing you a prescription for a new drug I want you to take. It's called Lamictal," the psychiatrist said.

They both just looked at each other.

His doctor went on.

"We've had this discussion for the last few years about the damage Lithium may be doing to your kidneys."

"Given the many years you have been taking Lithium, it is now time that you either face your fears and stop taking it, or as you just told me, you may be dead in a year or two."

Oto had never heard of Lamictal before.

But before he could ask any questions about it, his psychiatrist told him that he needed to pay him \$250 dollars, because his next patient was waiting for him.

Oto was handed a small piece of paper with what he said was the plan going forward.

Oto stood up, put the paper in his pocket and shook the hand of his psychiatrist.

"We will taper you off the Lithium for two weeks and then ramp you up on the Lamictal," the psychiatrist said.

"I know you pretty well, and I think maybe you will have a down swing in the Spring, but you shouldn't have any mania at all."

Oto thought about how Christmas was only a month away, not that it had anything to do with anything at all.

"I am not worried about you in the slightest."

The psychiatrist then went on to talk briefly about the drug Oto had never heard about.

Oto's psychiatrist then quickly explained how he had to start Oto off on a low dosage, like 100 mgs, of Lamictal.

Because if he developed a rash during the first four weeks of taking the new medication, he would have to go off of it right away.

The rash would most likely signify that Oto could be one of the small percentage of patients that are new to Lamictal and who are allergic to it.

"So," he said, "it would be like your system was being poisoned, but don't worry I don't anticipate you having any troubles with it."

At that point, Oto would then have to be hospitalized, and he would need a blood transfusion to avoid dying in the hospital.

Oto left the psychiatrist's office, and he could feel a sharp pain in his stomach that he couldn't ignore.

For the first time in 23 years he was facing the prospect of his mind spinning back out of control like it had when he was 17.

He couldn't explain the way his fear just took over his body.

He looked down at the "plan" on the crumpled-up piece of paper that he pulled out of his pocket.

When he got home, he started doing research to find out what Lamictal was, and what its side effects would be.

What he read made him feel worse, and he started breaking out in a sweat.

It was only a couple of days until Christmas, and he knew he was on his own again.

He looked down and read over the "plan" again for the fifth time, but he really had no idea what would happen next.

He went back into his home office, collapsed on the floor, and began crying uncontrollably.

He had nobody to talk to, but he had bought himself a few nice presents that he had been saving up for.

He wrapped them before placing them downstairs under a small tree with only a few ornaments hanging on it.

After four weeks had passed, and it was Christmas Eve, Oto started to feel like his thoughts were racing, and he couldn't reach his psychiatrist on the phone.

But somehow, even with his thoughts racing, he managed to write an email and send it off.

Oto got an email back from his doctor saying that the current dose of Lamictal he was on wasn't working.

He would need to start taking a higher dose right away.

Oto thought back to when he was 17 and had his first down swing.

It was a cold night in the rural community out in the middle of nowhere Nevada.

Oto was in his room doing his breathing exercises to try and calm his anxiety.

Ana had just picked up her son Kanak and her daughter Eve from the local school and it was almost dark, before they got back home.

As Ana ran back to go to the bathroom, the phone rang, so she quickly picked up.

She was surprised to hear her neighbor on the phone yelling about being trapped in their truck out in the snow.

Given the small town that she lived in, Ana already knew that her neighbor and husband had traveled to a friend's house earlier that day, to a town about two hours away.

Believe it or not there were no EMTs, or police, or anyone else that could help out her friends that were desperately asking for help on the phone.

Ana decided she needed to go to try and find them.

She quietly poked her head into Oto's room, and seeing him actually fast asleep, she made a quick decision.

"Kanak and Eve go and get back in the car, we need to go and try and help out our neighbors who say they are stuck in a snow drift out on the highway and have nobody else to turn to."

Ana wasn't that worried because it was calm outside and she could see the bright stars already in the night sky.

Ana drove as fast as she could in the direction of where her neighbors said they were stranded.

After about ten minutes, though, snow started falling, and a few minutes after that it was really coming down, making it hard for her to see out the front windshield.

No matter how she adjusted her windshield wipers, she was not even seeing the white lines on the side of the road.

Her youngest son and daughter were both in the back seat asking her what they were going to do, and how they were getting scared.

Ana took her eyes off the road in front of her for two seconds, while she looked in her rear-view mirror to try and reassure them both.

During those two seconds a big rig materialized out of nowhere right in front of her Blazer.

Ana tapped the breaks ever so gently to avoid skidding out of control.

Unfortunately, this put her car into an uncontrolled slide, and the Blazer slammed into the side of a snowbank.

Just like in the movies, the back of the Blazer was close to the edge of a snowy cliff.

The other half of her car was still on the side of the road with the tires spinning, but they weren't getting any traction.

Like Ana had done so many times before in her life, she didn't think, she just reacted.

She had never put the Blazer in four-wheel-drive, and had no idea how to do that.

But, by the grace of God, she somehow figured it out by flipping a hidden switch she had never really noticed before.

Kanak yelled out and pushed Eve over to the opposite side of the car, as he heard the tires spinning out of control.

In seconds, the front and back tires worked in tandem, suddenly grabbing the icy road, and they veered back onto the road.

The big rig had disappeared into the snowy night, and Ana drove on, but this time staying under 25 mph.

It was about five minutes later, when Ana stopped the car to try and turn around and go back home.

At this point she was not willing to go any further.

As she looked for a wide enough spot to turn back, she saw a truck blocking her path.

Somehow Ana had managed to find her friends who were sitting in their truck.

They had the engine and heater running, but couldn't move their stuck vehicle.

As soon as the neighbors saw the Blazer, they hopped out of their truck, and climbed into the back seat, as Kanak moved up front to join his mom.

They all tried to stay calm as Ana somehow managed to turn back and head toward home.

After about twenty minutes the snow let up and Ana was able to speed up.

She thankfully arrived at her neighbor's house, dropping them off before pulling up into the driveway of her own home.

Ana immediately remembered that Oto was home alone.

She quickly went in and poked her head into his room again, and was relieved to find him still fast asleep.

She watched his exposed chest rise and fall with a steady rhythm, and she quietly closed the door to his room, making sure she didn't wake him up.

Chapter 18: Christmas

Oto didn't need an alarm clock to know that it was 5:30 in the morning.

He decided to take the few strands of lights and ornaments off his Christmas tree, carefully packing them away in the box with the correct label on it.

"Well," he said out loud in his empty apartment, "Another year up and gone."

He laughed to himself as he took the small Christmas tree, now bare, and dropped it off on the curb outside his apartment.

It was January 5th and Oto's brain was ramping up into over-drive.

He was feeling a bit nostalgic, so he turned the TV on, searching for just the right movie to cheer him up.

He came across an old animated movie with Shaq in it.

He loved watching women's basketball, so he sat back in his old blue recliner, and watched the movie until he fell asleep.

Oto wasn't sure what time it was, or what day it was, and he was having trouble understanding the words that were bouncing around inside his mind.

He went into his kitchen, trying to pull out a carton of milk so he could get to a cold bottle of Mexican Coke, his favorite.

He couldn't drink the fake crap they put in Classic Coke, but his drink used sugar cane.

Oto somehow lost his balance and the cold bottle with some bubbly liquid running down the side slipped out of his hand, crashing and exploding into hundreds of glassy shards all around him.

"Fuck, that was my last bottle," he yelled out loud and slammed the refrigerator door closed.

He didn't see the sharp shiny glass sticking up from the tile behind his left heel, until it was too late.

The sharp glass ripped through his skin and muscle and he fell backwards.

Oto woke up on the kitchen-tiled floor three hours later, but it was dark, which was a good thing.

If he had the lights on, he would have seen the large pool of his own blood, mixed with his favorite soda, spilled out around him.

He was feeling dizzy, and he leaned over and started vomiting.

Before blacking out again, he managed to reach down into his pocket, pulling out his phone.

Luckily for him, he managed to dial 911 before everything went black.

When Oto opened his eyes, he tried to move his arms and legs, but as he did so, pain shot up his leg and he screamed out loud.

He looked around only to discover that he was tied down in a gurney in the middle of a hallway in a busy emergency room.

He had no idea why he was there, and then the memory of the glass and soda on his kitchen floor flooded back to him.

“Help me,” he said as loud as he could.

A nurse came over to him.

“Well, I was wondering how long it would take you to wake up,” the nurse said.

“Why am I strapped down to this gurney?”

The nurse ignored him and called over a couple of rent-a-cops who undid the restraints and helped Oto into a sitting position.

Oto’s left leg had many staples in it and the skin was glued together.

He was actually surprised he wasn’t in more pain, but that was only because the pain killers hadn’t yet left his system.

The “guards” helped Oto down off the gurney and half-picked him up, and half drug him, into a suicide-watch room.

Oto couldn’t stop the tears that were flowing down his cheeks and onto the cold “bed” that he was sitting on.

He examined his leg and left it alone, because just looking at the bandages made him get dizzy again.

Oto sat back and was soon fast asleep.

He thought he had been asleep for a few hours, but he could see from the digital clock behind him that had started the minute he was confined to his new room. It had only been about 45 minutes that had passed.

Outside of the room where he was on suicide watch, he couldn't hear outside the room, but those watching him could everything he was saying and doing.

He couldn't hear the old-fashioned clock on the wall that he noticed outside of his room. But in his head, he can think he could hear it ticking, second-by-second, and minute-by-minute.

Oto noticed how the two clocks weren't synced up.

This is because someone with Bipolar 1 can internally, using their brain that is moving 1.5 times faster than a normal, almost hear the time moving along in their mind.

There was a window up in Oto's cell, and he could just see a tree outside, swaying in the wind.

He began laughing out loud, noticing a crow sitting up on a branch.

Oto knew everything there was to know about crows and ravens.

Seeing the crow comforted him, and he stopped thinking about the pain in his leg.

He turned his attention back out into the busy emergency room.

He knew that the rent-a-cop outside of his room was writing down everything he did, but he refused to show any weakness.

He stayed on his bed, tapping his foot in beat with the song that was playing in his mind.

Outside of his cell Oto watched the rent-a-cop, who was posted on the other side of the thick glass that held him in the cage.

The "guard" kept scribbling something down on paper attached to a clipboard every ten minutes.

Oto was positive it had to do with whatever he had been doing ten minutes before.

An extra guard met up with the existing one every 45 minutes, and they stood together bull-shitting during that timeframe.

Oto wasn't tired, so he kept resting on his bed.

He wasn't sure, however, if it was the third or fourth guard shift, that he had carefully watched.

The one guard did eventually, though, press a switch on the outside of the glass "wall."

He could instantly hear everything going on out in the busy emergency room.

Oto was entertained by nurses running back and forth.

He even saw a man he thought to be in his twenties get wheeled by on a gurney with blood spurting out of his left hand.

Later on Oto was pretty sure he heard two of the guards laughing about scoring with chicks from the local Junior College.

The two guards were also taking bets on who would win the Super Bowl, but Oto didn't even know there was one playing.

Both guards slowly came up to the glass wall, opening the sliding glass door that Oto had never noticed.

The small opening was just wide enough for both guards to squeeze through.

They both looked at Oto sitting there and not moving.

"Look, pal, if you even move one inch off that bed, we are going to slam you down to the floor and you aren't going to like it."

The two guards explained how if he stayed on good behavior, maybe the next day, he could get moved to a new cell that had a TV in it.

Oto listened to the two guards in his cell, but didn't move a muscle.

He quietly asked who was playing in the Super Bowl, but he didn't bother listening to who the two teams were.

He really didn't care who might win or lose.

He only knew that he has been through this type of confinement before when he was 17-years-old, and he knew how the game was played.

Oto just sighed thinking to himself that he would rather be out walking in the sunlight.

At least that way he could actually hear the crow cawing up in the tree, rather than just watching the beak move up and down.

Chapter 19: Suicide Watch

Oto drifted off to sleep for an hour or so that night, or at least he thought it was night.

He also wasn't one hundred percent sure how long he had been sleeping, but upon waking up he shielded his eyes from the bright lights that were always shining down on him.

He wondered if this is what it was like to be a famous actor.

Oto was moved to the new room that had been promised to him if he stayed on good behavior.

He looked around the room just like he always did when in a new room when being confined against his will.

Unlike the previous room, it did indeed have a small color TV hanging up in the corner of the room.

But the sound was muted.

So he could watch the football players fighting it out on the Superbowl, running and tackling and hurting themselves and those players around him.

A nurse walked into this room, telling Oto how he was the head nurse.

The nurse had a small flip phone that he handed to Oto.

“Here you go, try and call your sister on this,” the nurse said.

Oto looked at it the old phone, but it wasn’t like any phone he had ever seen.

“Wait, before you leave, which sister are you talking about? I have two of them,” Oto said.

Oto looked up, but the nurse was already gone.

Oto flipped the “phone” over a couple of times and turned the power button on.

He had a lot of experience with mobile devices of all types, so he quickly flipped through the several layers of the small GUI.

The nurse came back with a sticky note that said Eve on it with a phone number.

He didn’t have his younger sister’s phone number memorized, but he quickly dialed what was on the sticky note.

A small ding could be heard coming from the phone.

As soon as it went off the head nurse came back into the cell.

“That wasn’t so hard now, was it?” the nurse asked.

“I don’t understand what you mean,” Oto replied.

The nurse said nothing, but he picked up the phone and sticky note and left Oto alone again.

Oto looked at the clock back out in the busy emergency room.

He couldn’t figure out what day it was, but he did notice that a couple of hours had gone before the head nurse walked back in.

Oto was told for the first time since arriving that his blood pressure was too high, but how his Lamictal levels were stable.

Oto remembered having his blood drawn a few hours before, but he had not been told what it was for.

The nurse went on to explain that he needed Oto’s blood pressure at a normal range in order to be transported to a bigger hospital that had food and other amenities for him.

At the mention of food, Oto realized that he was starving, and so thirsty he could barely talk.

Like clockwork, he was given two full 12-ounce paper cups with ice water in them.

He drank each one down as quickly as he could before asking for more.

He was told how he couldn't have more than a couple of cups in the room at once.

Unfortunately for Oto, he soon had to piss so bad, he felt like he might let loose and go on the floor of his cell.

Oto would never give the nurses or the guards the satisfaction of watching him piss on the floor.

He soon learned, however, that to relieve himself he had to put up his hand, since in this new room there was no longer any sound that he could hear.

Oto had to raise his hand like in a kindergarten classroom.

Once his hand went up, he then had to wait for two guards, a head nurse, and a second nurse to escort him to a bathroom that had no door.

The strange ritual had to occur every time he had to take a piss.

Each time the "team" would surround him, walking him to the toilet down the white hallway.

One of the nurses happened to be a 20-year-old female, and Oto wondered to himself if perhaps she could work in Hollywood.

As Oto approached the toilet, he pulled down his "sweats," making sure he aimed into the toilet.

The young nurse stood right behind Oto as he tried to piss into the semi-clean toilet.

As he tried to relax, he could smell her perfume.

After what felt like two minutes, but was probably only fifteen seconds, he finally got his piss to flow.

He could hear the young woman laughing behind him as she talked with the head male nurse. “Quickly wash your hands and dry them on this towel, and then toss it in the trash,” she said. Oto followed her instructions and was escorted back to his cell.

The hunger was so extreme that Oto raised his hand again after sitting in his room for another hour. Eventually a nurse came over.

“What do you want?” he asked.

“Can I please have something to eat? I am feeling light-headed,” Oto said.

“Oh, but wait I have a lot of food allergies.” Oto tried to explain what his food allergies, but the nurse had already left the cold room.

The nurse returned half an hour later carrying an orange plastic tray.

Oto was actually surprised, because the only thing that made sense to him was how they must trust him not to hurt himself or others with the hard tray.

His stomach churned as he looked at the stale bread with mayonnaise soaked into it.

He couldn’t help but notice the shiny slice of what he was told was sliced turkey.

He pulled the cheese and turkey from the bread, immediately devouring them.

He then opened the small cup of tapioca pudding that he had been given.

He ate every last bit of the delicious pudding.

The nurse entered the room once last time, picking up the empty tray, leaving Oto alone again.

Chapter 20: Breaking Down

Oto thought back to when he was 17 and was locked up in another hospital against his will.

Just by instinct and experience, he felt confident that the people running this place might try and “break him down.”

But as a survivor, he never gave up, no matter what the cost.

Oto wasn't sure if it was the fourth or fifth time, he had to piss with the young girl watching him.

The head nurse eventually though, gave the young female nurse something better to do, like completing her rounds and checking on her patients.

In any case, for the rest of the afternoon when Oto had to relieve himself, it was only the head nurse that would now watch him.

Really, he thought to himself, the main difference was that the overweight head nurse smelled like stale sweat, and it was clear that he didn't believe in using deodorant.

Oto was starving, and it was making it hard for him to stay calm and focus on his current situation.

He was told by the head nurse that they only had a little mini fridge stocked with very little food on this main floor of the busy ER.

The nurse had actually put in a request for more food, which had to go through official channels downstairs to the cafeteria, but that could literally take a day or two.

Oto was told by the head nurse that if he wanted food, he would need to get his blood pressure down because due to insurance reasons they couldn't transport him until that occurred.

Oto wasn't sure what the man meant by "transport," but he thought he heard something about an ambulance.

Oto didn't feel like he had any other choice, so he reluctantly agreed.

Oto had never been in an ambulance before, so he was somewhat curious about what the experience would feel like.

The same "drill" happened like when he had to piss.

He was surrounded before having to hop up on a "gurney."

Once on the small bed he was told to lay back and get comfortable, which he did.

The ambulance driver then tightened up the four straps so Oto couldn't escape.

The drive to the fourth hospital where he would also be confined against his will was like the craziest amusement ride Oto had ever been on.

He of course couldn't be totally sure, but he was pretty confident they were traveling at 100 mph, based on what he saw out the back window of the ambulance.

The gurney had been locked down into the back of the ambulance, so he wasn't worried about moving around.

But of course he could feel every little bump in the fast moving "bus."

Just like when he was 17, he scanned every square inch of the inside of the ambulance that he could see.

He tested the straps that held him down and he was surprised at how he could get a hand and arm free from the black straps, at least he was pretty sure he could.

But why would he want to do that?

It would only affect him later on.

Instead of even worrying about that, Oto just stayed put, watching out the back of the ambulance, racing down the highway without any lights on.

He watched how they raced past every car and truck that was on the highway.

Oto actually had to pee again really bad, but he did his best to ignore that feeling, focusing on the cars and trucks on the road.

Before Oto arrived at the fourth hospital where he was headed, he thought again back to the day before in the suicide watch cell that he had been trapped in.

He thought about the phone conversation he had with his sister Eve the day before.

At least he was pretty sure that is what happened.

Months later he was told by his younger sister that she had called the ER after hearing how he was in the hospital.

By just random luck, a nurse one floor down from the ER, answered the phone and was surprised to hear Eve on the phone.

Without thinking, the nurse transferred the call upstairs.

The head nurse that was constantly bugging Oto answered the phone.

That created the incident of the sticky note with Eve's name and number that was given to Oto when he had called and talked to her for two minutes.

"Eve, what are you doing? How on earth were you able to call me?"

"Brother, that isn't important right now. The real question is how are you and why are you locked up in the ER on suicide watch?"

"I have no real memory of how I got here, but don't worry I have the protocols down," Oto said.

It wasn't long before the call was ended and Eve knew exactly what her brother meant.

She quickly called Ana, her mom, and told her that Oto had the protocols down, and how she was certain that he would be fine.

Chapter 21: Ambulance Trip

Luckily for Oto, the ambulance parked in the back entrance of the fourth hospital before he had to worry about pissing himself.

It would not be good to soak the blanket that was tucked so neatly underneath the black straps that held him down.

The ride had lasted for only an hour, but he was still new to using Lamictal. One of the side effects was increased thirst, and the need for him to piss at least once an hour, if not more frequently.

Oto watched the ambulance driver open the "bus" and unlock the mechanism that held the gurney into place.

"Can you please hurry, I have to pee really bad," he said.

The driver didn't reply, but he got Oto out of the ambulance and the gurney just sat on the pavement.

As Oto was wheeled into the back entrance of the hospital, the gurney slammed into a glass door that was supposed to stay open for them.

Oto yelled out in surprise.

He was wheeled into a small intake room that closed with a bang behind him.

The straps were then removed from him and he was politely ordered to step down onto the cold floor that he limped onto.

He was still feeling the sharp pain given the deep cut on his bandaged leg from the broken glass incident a few nights before.

He couldn't get the image of the bloody glass, his blood, and the soda mixed together on his kitchen floor out of his head.

He had no idea what really happened after that and although he had asked about that many times, he never got a straight answer.

For some strange reason as he limped toward what he was told was a bathroom, he wondered if the mess was still on his kitchen floor or not.

He ignored everything and just focused on the toilet he was taken to.

It still took him awhile to piss with the driver watching him, but eventually he managed to do it.

Oto flushed the toilet and finally did his best to relax.

He was still wearing the shorts, t-shirt and socks and shoes that he had been wearing before leaving for this hospital.

The only other thing he still had on him was his wallet, which for some reason was given to him at the last hospital before being strapped down.

Oto turned around in the small bathroom to see a tall black man wearing light-blue scrubs looking down at him, blocking him from even thinking about leaving.

The man smiled at Oto before saying, "Please remove your clothes and place them in this bag that I am holding."

As Oto did what he was told, each item was mentioned before being dropped into the bag.

At that point Oto was still wearing his underwear.

“Take them off as well,” the man said. “Hurry up I need to get you processed and I don’t have all day.”

Oto was a little surprised about having to take off his underwear and drop them into the bag, but what choice did he have?

“I couldn’t believe how long you pissed a second ago, it was like watching a race horse,” he said out loud and laughed.

Oto stood naked and shivering in front of this stranger that was now laughing at him.

He couldn’t believe how he was standing in this bathroom and what might happen next.

“Come on, it isn’t a big deal, just bend over, I need to make sure you aren’t hiding anything inside you.”

Oto bent over, and after some uncomfortable probing, he was given a pair of what felt like paper underwear.

He then quickly put on what looked like prison garb, or at the very least like the scrubs the tall man was wearing, that had just been so intimate with him.

“Follow me,” he said.

And of course Oto did.

The nurse took him through a maze of locked doors that were unlocked as he was ushered through them.

He was eventually told to wait at a typical emergency station that you would expect to see in a hospital.

“Here you go,” said the male nurse who had just probed him.

A new nurse looked up and asked Oto why he was there.

“I have no idea; did I do something wrong? Did I commit some crime that I am not aware of.”

The nurse laughed a little before saying, “Hmm, if you had done that you wouldn’t be here, now would you?”

Oto was going to ask where here was, but the nurse went on.

“Follow me and I will show you the room where you will be sleeping for at least the next few nights.”

He noticed how his bed was next to a window covered in some material, so no real light or anything else could come through.

“Your roommate is in group therapy right now, but his name is Salas, and you will meet him later,” he was told.

Chapter 22: Disney Drawings

Oto followed the nurse out of his new room and into what looked like a small empty cafeteria.

He sat down at an empty table and was brought over a small plastic tray.

Oto was so hungry that he just ate everything on it as quickly as possible.

That included the mashed potatoes and carrots that weren’t cooked that well, but he didn’t even notice.

He also ate the small sliver of what he thought was turkey, and the cherry Jello as well.

He just kept eating until the hunger finally left him for the first time in days.

As he finally looked up from his empty tray he was surprised to see lots of colored Disney Princess characters on pieces of paper.

It was obvious that someone had spent a lot of time using some crayons on them.

Oto was instructed where to put the empty tray and then followed the nurse back to his new room.

A man that looked similar in age to Oto was now sitting on the bed away from the window. He looked up as soon as he saw Oto, but then looked back down at the floor.

The nurse didn’t miss a beat. “Salas, meet Oto, your new roommate.”

Feeling awkward, Oto sat down on his own bed and just looked over at Salas for a minute or two.

Oto finally broke the silence by saying hello, and Salas looked up at Oto.

“Hello, nice to meet you. The old man that was previously staying here with me left this morning when I was in group therapy.”

“I have to say I am a little relieved,” Salas said, “Because he just mumbled to himself most of the time.”

For the next ten minutes Salas showed him where the bathroom was.

It was pretty obvious, but there were no door and the bathroom consisted of a small sink, a toilet with an actual lid on it, and a shower stall.

There was of course no privacy, which I guess was the point, Oto thought to himself.

At this point the same nurse came into the room and said it was time to get some sleep, since they would be up early in the morning for med checks and breakfast with the rest of the patients.

Oto was exhausted, so he gladly got into his bed and looked over at Salas.

“We can whisper, but only for a few minutes in between every fifteen-minute bed check from the nurse,” Salas said.

Salas pointed to what looked like a watch around his wrist but had no face on it, and in the light still in the room Oto was pretty sure he saw a Nike logo on it.

“Don’t worry, you will get one of these before you go to breakfast in the morning. They are blue-tooth enabled so the nurses can always track us in real time.”

Oto and Salas stayed awake, but pretended to be asleep, except for the ten or so minutes in between the nurse walking in and selecting buttons on a tablet device before leaving again.

They both hit it off instantly and Salas shared how he had been diagnosed with Bipolar 2 disorder 10 years ago.

He covered a bit about dealing with meds that worked or didn’t work and how he still couldn’t manage the illness very well.

Oto decided just to trust Salas, and when Oto was asked why he was locked up in this hospital, he had to think a bit before replying.

“Well, I haven’t been told, to be honest. It is a long story, but I was brought in by ambulance from a different smaller hospital not long ago actually.”

“Yes,” Salas said, “that is pretty much how we all end up in here. Did you try to kill yourself, or something.”

Oto told him all about the glass and blood incident and then waking up in the emergency of the other hospital.

“Well,” Salas said, “They obviously think you tried suicide, or you wouldn’t be here.”

With that, the two men quickly fell asleep.

Oto would later find out that it was 5:30 the next morning when a nurse who was doing blood draws on all of the patients yelled out and woke him out of a deep sleep.

As he woke up, he saw one nurse with a needle in her hand and another nurse, the same big guy that had probed him the night before, pulling on his other arm.

“Stay still, god damn it.”

Before he knew what was happening, he was being pinned down to his bed and the needle was plunged into his arm and blood pulled into the glass tube.

They apparently got what they needed so they left the room.

Oto was shaking from the whole event, but when he looked over at Salas, his roommate was laughing so hard he was crying.

“What the hell is so funny, Salas? Does this type of thing happen every morning?”

Salas stopped laughing and was soon able to respond.

“Well, yes, they do come around at some time around 5:30 am and a nurse has to get blood draws for med checks at the lab.”

“Why does that happen when you are asleep?” Oto asked.

“Well, basically, they can get in and out real fast and so it is more efficient. They always do it when you are fast asleep, and by the time you wake up it is done.”

Oto then asked Salas what was so funny and why was he pinned down by two nurses like that. His arm was sore and so were his legs from being forced to not move on the bed.

“Sorry, it was just not something I have ever seen before,” Salas said.

“They had just finished with me when I woke up and they walked over to you still sleeping.”

Salas went on to say how Oto was curled up in a fetal-like position facing toward the window and up against the wall.

His arms were locked in as if he was protecting himself from a beating or something.

The first nurse tried to get to Oto’s arm for the blood draw, but couldn’t even really move Oto at all.

“She yelled out and said, Fuck!” Salas explained.

“She then had the other nurse open you up, in a way like a clam shell, prying open your arms and pinning you down to get your blood. They both had to get involved to do this.”

Oto just listened to the story and was surprised by it all.

“That is why I was laughing my ass off. The nurses in here are usually pretty calm, and I have never heard on of them yell out the word fuck before.”

They both then got ready and stood at the doorway before they were ushered out with the other patients to get in line for breakfast.

Chapter 23: The Cafeteria

Later that same morning Oto lined up behind Salas at the door, if there was a door, which there wasn’t.

All of these lines and rules reminded him of kindergarten, and that is what it actually felt like.

Salas and Oto just stood there until a nurse walked by.

“Let’s go everyone. You can come out of your rooms now and line up by the nurse’s station and then we will head on out to the cafeteria to eat breakfast.”

Oto followed Salas’ lead and took his place beside his new roommate near the front of the doorless opening to the hallway.

Oto poked his head out looking up and down the hallway to see others, like him, waiting and chatting excitedly with anyone around them.

Oto followed Salas to the “cafeteria,” which was really just a few tables with chairs around them, and the food was served on trays with their names on them.

Oto noticed that his name wasn’t typed in, but was written with what looked like a black sharpie.

He grabbed his tray and sat down next to Salas, looking at the food in front of him.

It looked like something he would have refused to eat in his high school cafeteria, but he was starving and tried not to smell the limp, pasty food in front of him.

Across the table from him was a woman that would later tell him that she was Cantonese.

Oto felt a little uncomfortable because she had her gaze fixed on him and wasn’t even blinking.

“Hello,” she said in a nice and gentle tone.

“Hello,” he said.

“So, this is your first meal here in paradise?” she said flashing him a big smile. “You seem to have quite an impressive aura going on, and I can’t help but smile when I look at you.”

Oto wasn’t sure what to say next, so he just looked at her and tried to eat the food in front of him.

“My name is Aziza,” what is yours?

“Oto, my name is, Oto. It is nice to meet you.”

Oto was surprised by what happened next. Without hesitating Azize pushed her tray forward a little and got up from her chair.

She started limping across the cafeteria, that later Oto would laugh about because there was no reason that she needed to limp, she just did it for the theatrics of what was about to happen.

Aziza “limped” up to the counter where the empty trays are supposed to go.

She used her thickest accent and then asked, “I know we can only have one packet, but I am having a real hard time eating the turkey, or whatever it is you are serving us.” She just stared at the nurse.

“If I can please just grab a couple of other packets, I would really appreciate it.”

Before he knew it, Aziza was back sitting across from Oto, and she flashed him a big smile and winked at him.

She looked around and then quickly slid two packets over to Oto.

He quickly grabbed them, he wasn't sure why, and hid them in his left hand.

"You see, I am a mixologist, and I can give you some tips, if you just follow my lead."

She pointed to his closed hand before saying, "With two packets, you can make any type of sauce that you want. For instance I just gave you mayonnaise and soy sauce. Open them both and squirt them onto that turkey in front of you. Then just mix them all up and you will then have a soy glaze and you will think you are eating in one of my Chinese restaurants."

Oto did as she instructed him, and sure enough, he was able to eat the turkey that earlier he couldn't even imagine eating.

Oto wasn't sure how, but he now instantly had a connection with Aziza and thanked her.

He told her a couple of things about himself, but everyone other than Aziza were now looking at him.

"Oto, listen to me, you need to slow down. Your brain is racing way too fast."

Oto had no idea what she was talking about, but she then started to speaking to him saying one word and then skipping the next two and started telling him about how she owned a chain of Chinese food restaurants, but was locked up by her daughter to try and get her medication sorted out.

Oto had the greatest conversation with her, and he ignored everyone else at the table and focused on Aziza like a flashlight in the dark of night.

Two days later his medication would start to kick in and he would laugh to think about sitting there with the woman who helped him communicate and begin to slow down.

Before he followed Salas back to their room, he heard Aziza whisper to him as he walked by, "Oto, the hardest thing you will find in life is learning to slow down. Don't worry you will learn how to do that, trust me."

Three days later Oto was sitting in the rec room and he found a wall full of all types of books.

“Oto, take a look at the ‘Old Yeller’ book up on the second shelf over there,” Salas said.

Oto went and pulled the book off the shelf and quickly looked through it. He stopped at a page that caught his eye and noticed that someone had written the number 23 in the upper right corner of the page he stopped at.

He looked over at Salas, who flashed him a quick smile and winked at Oto.

He followed the growing list of numbers and was soon jumping all over the book until he saw a line that said simply, go to page 44 in the Hitch Hiker’s Guide to the galaxy. He put back the Old Yeller book and pulled out the giant Douglas Adams book.

He played the same game and before he knew it, he had a small book called “Ariel” written by Sylvia Plath.

He looked up at Salas who told him to come over and hang out with him.

“Oto,” his roommate said. “Read over the poems that are marked in that book for the next twenty minutes and we will talk later at night in between rounds like we do.

Oto did as he was asked, and was excited, but pretended to be bored as they finished out the rest of the afternoon in group therapy and making “flowers” out of tissue paper in art class.

Art class always made Oto a little uneasy, because even when using a crayon you have to first ask for a color and wait for the therapist in charge at the table to approve it, mark it down on a tablet of paper, and then hand it to him.

Of course the same thing would happen in reverse when he wanted a different color.

That night after the nurse left the room, Salas whispered over to Oto.

“Dude, tell me what the third line is in the Daddy poem written by Sylvia Plath.”

Oto did his best to recall what it was and gave his roommate his best guess.

“Perfect, my friend,” he said, “you are now in the club with Aziza and me.”

“What are you talking about, Salas?”

They both paused and pretended to be asleep and listened to the nurse enter the room, click a few boxes on the tablet in hand, and then leave the room.

Oto looked over at Salas who was resting on the small limp pillows that made it almost impossible to sleep on, flashing Oto a big smile.

“Don’t worry, we will fill you in on everything tomorrow at lunch when the three of us can talk without worrying about being overheard.”

Unfortunately for Oto, that meeting never happened and he had no idea why.

The next morning after breakfast they were told that they had a guest, a dog whisperer that would be joining them in the group therapy room.

Oto just loved dogs, and when he heard this news, he got so excited.

For some reason he seemed to have some type of bond with any dog that he came across, and he had no idea what it meant, but after petting or hanging out with them, he would instantly bond with any dog.

The dog would usually lay down and expose their belly to him, and of course Oto would give them a good scratch.

The dog whisperer showed up with a dog, a white lab, named Cesar.

Just like what always happened, Oto was soon scratching the dog’s belly. He looked up and locked eyes with the dog whisperer who introduced himself as Utu.

Oto couldn’t help but notice that the name was very similar to his own.

Utu watched as Oto and Salas got down close to the dog Cesar, and spent some time petting her.

Oto was watching Utu out of the corner of his eye, but still noticed that he was talking to the head nurse and the therapist that was supervising them.

Oto and Salas, and every other patient for that matter had Vitamin D added to their medication regime, since they were rarely if ever allowed to go outside, even though the “yard,” so to speak, had walls boxing them in that were over 20 feet high.

Oto didn’t complain, however, when Utu stepped out into the yard with a Bose speaker “connected” to his phone using Bluetooth.

They both eagerly followed Utu outside and just sat down and looked up at the sun that was in the cloudless sky.

It was the happiest Oto had been in many months, and he didn’t want it to end.

He loved the song that was planning, and in no time at all he had his eyes closed and danced around the “yard.”

Utu tapped Oto on the shoulder and explained how if you can do twenty push-ups then you can walk on your hands.

He showed Oto how by using the wall to “walk” up it backwards and then sure enough he was walking on his hands.

Before Oto could try it, they had to get back inside. He would try it months later, though, and he managed to do it.

Sometimes at night Oto would stay up late and when Salas was asleep, he would pull out the paper he had stashed inside the booklet that had all of the rules and regulations on it.

The pen he also smuggled was able to twist and bend.

This was in case they tried to commit suicide by swallowing the super thin pen.

Oto just laughed to himself by how ridiculous the rules were once you were trapped on the inside.

He knew he would never be able to tell anyone after he was released, because they wouldn’t want to hear anything about the hell he was going through.

The next day Oto was walking on his way back to his room when he noticed an empty room with a piano in it.

He quickly walked in and sat down at the piano.

He had never had lessons, but he just played a tune in his head without music and his fingers and feet just knew what to do somehow.

He played for a few minutes until a nurse came in and yanked him out of the seat Oto was sitting in.

After that a sign was put on the closed door to the piano room that said out of order.

In the morning the nurse would wake up Oto and Salas to take showers.

Just like the bathroom there were no doors.

Once you are locked up in the mental hospital you aren't allowed to have any privacy or alone time ever, no matter how well you followed the rules.

Salas and Oto, however, would leave to give them each some time alone in the shower to enjoy the water, even though it was ice cold, and they were only given a very small amount of liquid soap to use as shampoo and soap.

Needless to say, the showers only lasted a few short minutes, but it is amazing how Oto would still welcome those few minutes, even though the cold water was painful at best.

After drying off, Oto would put on a new pair of paper underwear, and quickly get on what he called his prison garb.

The first few days they only had medium size pants, which would fall down unless Oto was holding them up.

He didn't have to be told that if that happened in front of anyone he would be severely punished.

So, he used water from the sink and soaked part of the pants and then twisted them into a knot, which was awkward at best, but at least it kept his pants up.

When Salas was asleep at night, and he had somehow filled up all of the empty space on the paper that he had snuck out, he would look up at the ceiling and cry by himself.

Sometimes when you lose your freedom and are messed with all of the time to get a reaction that would then be punishable, it was just too much, even for Oto.

For some reason on this particular night he couldn't control the tears that just kept flowing down his face, so he thought up something that would stop them.

It must have been a month or so ago when Oto was alone in his apartment, which was a lot better than where he now found himself.

He had his weber grill, which he had forgotten to clean, at just the right temperature, or so he thought.

He had been distracted watching a close WNBA game, and had forgotten that he had a pork roast out cooking on the grill.

When a commercial started, he saw flames out of the corner of his eyes.

He just reacted and ran to the fridge and yanked out a box of baking soda and ran out on the balcony and dumped the entire box on the fire, shutting the hood of the grill.

The fire went quickly out, but so too did the charred piece of meat that he had to throw away and go order a pepperoni pizza, his favorite.

Chapter 24: A Razor

Oto hadn't shaved in several days so he had a rash break out all over his face. He needed to shave every day to avoid that.

He had participated in all of the group therapy sessions, and the psychologist even told him he needed to talk less and let others speak their minds.

He was trusted now by the staff, so a nurse told him that he could shave, as long as it was in front of him.

So, it wasn't long before Oto was standing in front of a mirror with a razor in one hand and the other rubbing shaving cream all over his face.

He was told he only had three minutes so he shaved as quickly as possible, handed the razor back to the nurse and then washing off the rest of the shaving cream.

He immediately felt better, and went back to his room to get ready for game night.

This was Oto's second game night, and he was excited.

He had so much energy, and no way to really channel it.

They had to go through a maze of elevators and down hallways until they arrived at a single door that somehow reminded him of Willy Wonka's chocolate factory.

Oto waited for his turn at the air hockey station.

His turn finally arrived and he faced off against an 18-year-old girl with short hair who was holding the paddle in one hand and was protecting the open slot.

Oto served up the "puck" and she slammed it back at Oto so hard that the puck flew off the table and hit a nurse in the back of the head.

She turned around and saw Oto just looking at her.

"Oto, go sit down on the bench against the wall."

He put the paddle down and did as he was told.

It wasn't long before the music started up.

Oto began tapping along and dancing a little bit as he watched the rest of the patients enjoy the games.

Oto eventually joined Salas and Aziza at the ping pong table after his “time out” was over.

They were slamming the ping pong ball back and forth until Aziza laughed.

“Oto, it is your turn to lose to me. Let’s go.”

He took the paddle from Salas and stepped up to the table.

Aziza served it so hard that the small plastic ball went flying across the room.

Oto laughed and served it himself, and then they had a good round.

He started hitting the ping pong ball faster and faster.

“Oto, you need to slow down. Try just hitting the ball without rushing.”

Before Oto could serve, the music was turned off and they all had to walk back to their wards.

Oto was sweaty after leaving the game room, but he felt much better and was able to relax.

It was time to return to their rooms and get into bed.

Salas usually quickly went to sleep, but tonight he sat up in bed after the first round of bed checks was over.

“Oto, did I ever tell you how I ended up in here?”

Oto shrugged and said he hadn’t.

“I just couldn’t take the ups and downs anymore, so one night I filled the bathtub with hot water and climbed in with my clothes on.”

Oto was focused now on his roommate.

I took the razor blade out of the shaver and held it next to my groin and just started stabbing myself in the leg until I passed out.

When I woke up, I was in a bed in the hospital.

I was hoping to end the pain, but now I was feeling groggy from the meds they put me on.

Before Salas could tell him anymore the nurse returned and gave them a warning, so they both rolled over and went to sleep.

Oto was told in the on-on-ones with a psychiatrist that he had Bipolar 1 disorder.

He of course already knew that at this point, but he listened to what she had to say.

He was told that he was manic, which is why he was in the hospital.

“This whole thing started when I dropped a Coke out of my fridge and ended up in the hospital.”

“Why am I here?”

The psychiatrist looked back at a file that she had in her hands, and explained that she didn’t know why he was there, but she just wanted to help him.

She gave Oto an IQ test, but he had so many before that he didn’t think it would change much.

That night Oto was alone again in the dark, so he got out his flexy-pen and took out a couple of sheets of paper that had Disney characters on one side.

He used the blank side to write some poems that he had been thinking about related to crows, and after that he felt a lot better.

In the morning, after eating breakfast, the same psychiatrist met with Oto and told him his time was up and that he would be free to go after lunch.

Oto was so excited that he barely ate his lunch, but Silas showed up at the table.

“Silas, I am getting sprung from this place in about an hour.”

“Good for you,” Silas said.

They both said at the same time, “I am going to miss you.”

Before leaving, and after they cleared their trays, Oto brought over two pieces of paper and showed Oto how to create an origami box.

Once it was finished Silas helped Oto with his, and then gave his to him as well.

Oto thought back to long ago when he was 17 and had to leave Ebbe behind, like he was now doing with Silas.

Of course, this time there was no GI Joe playing on the TV, nor was there one in this hospital.

They both just looked at each other and fist-bumped, before Oto left the room.

Oto was given his street clothes and told to change into them and leave the hospital garb on the ground.

He was so happy to put his clothes back on and couldn't wait to leave the hospital.

The same head nurse that had brought him into the place so many days ago, walked him through the maze of locked doors, and finally out into the sunshine.

Oto had a hard time adjusting to the light, but he didn't care, he was now free.

"Okay, sign this paper and you are free to go."

The nurse handed Oto his phone, and then he stepped off the curb and called himself an Uber to just drive anywhere but there.

Chapter 25: Freedom

Oto just sat down on the curb waiting for the Uber to show up.

He had everything he owned in a paper bag.

The sun was burning his skin, but he didn't mind.

After about twenty minutes his ride showed up.

He had one credit card that had a little room left on it before he maxed it out.

When he called the Uber, he didn't list anywhere he was headed to, because he had no idea himself.

The Uber showed up, a black Kia, and Oto hopped into the passenger seat.

"Where to?"

"Do me a favor and take me to the San Francisco airport."

Although Oto was in no hurry, you couldn't say the same thing about the Uber driver.

He was driving his Kia over 70 mph through an underground tunnel on his way to the airport.

Traffic starting slowing down so the driver swerved over into the other lane with traffic coming at them head-on.

He punched it, taking the Kia up to 90 mph, and then switched back into the right lane at the last minute.

Oto couldn't ever remember having an experience like this, but strangely enough he was totally calm and loved every minute of it.

The Uber driver pulled up to the departing gate.

Oto thanked him and gave him a \$50 tip, telling him to take it easy.

Oto decided he would just go into the airport and hang out for a bit to figure out his next move.

He had no clothes, other than the ones he was wearing, but that didn't worry him much.

Oto called up his sister Eve.

He told her he was about to buy a one-way ticket up to Washington state where she lived, and if it was okay if he could stay with her for a while.

She was surprised by the call, but more surprised that he was out of the hospital.

She told him of course he was welcome and that she would pick him up at the Seattle airport.

The one-way flight to Seattle was uneventful and Oto managed to sleep for about an hour of the flight.

He couldn't believe he was up above the clouds in a jet airplane when earlier that morning he was locked up against his will.

He actually hadn't even been sure when he would be leaving there, but he did miss his roommate Silas.

They had bonded in a way that most people can't realize.

Once the plane landed Oto just did what Eve told him to do.

"Just follow everyone else that is walking from the plane toward the departure gates and I will find you," he remembered her saying.

Sure enough, after following a few people he recognized from the plane, there she was waiting for him.

Although Oto had only given Eve about five hours from the time he called her, to when she had to drive to the airport to pick him up, she had quickly cleaned up the trailer sitting in her front yard.

There was no running water or a bathroom that Oto would be able to use, but he could use the bathroom inside the house when necessary.

“Hello, bro. You didn’t really give me enough time to prepare a place for you,” she said as they began walking out of the airport toward her parked car.

“Are you sure you are okay, Oto? I didn’t think you would be released today. I am worried about you.”

Oto climbed into the passenger side of her car and didn’t say anything.

He just looked over at his younger sister and thought about what might be the best thing to say to her so she wouldn’t worry so much.

“It’s okay, Eve, I am feeling really good. I plan to just take things day-by-day, but don’t worry I don’t plan to stay too long. I just have to figure out a good plan to move forward.”

Eve ordered a pepperoni pizza, her brother’s favorite, and had it delivered along with a Mexican Coke.

She knew her brother pretty well, but she was more worried about him than ever before.

They sat down on the couch, eating pizza, as Oto told her some of the more sanitized stories from the hospital he had been confined in.

She of course was now really worried and asked him about his medication.

He had plenty of pills left and explained to her what he was taking.

That night a powerful storm hit, and Oto was out in the trailer on his own watching a free episode of *Something Wicked This Way Comes*, written by Ray Bradbury.

He was really tired and was a bit worried, because as he watched the movie in the trailer it started rocking a bit from the wind and rain and it felt like the roof would blow off.

The Lamictal he was taking was making him piss every half hour and he had to step out into the storm to pee.

He managed to do it, but it was harder than the times when he had been watched in the hospital.

Still, he managed to get it done and then crawled back into bed and fell asleep right away.

The next day Oto woke up and walked out of the trailer to go relieve himself in his sister's bathroom. She lived in a small house by herself and she wanted Oto to have a space of his own.

"I don't know how long you plan on staying, and sorry about the bathroom situation," she said.

"It is okay, sister, I know I sprung all of this on you at the last minute. Don't you need to work today?"

She looked at her brother for a long time before replying, "I took the next few days off work so we can spend some time together."

"Are you sure? I can just hang out around here and do some writing or something while you are working."

"No, when you were asleep, I actually looked up some places where we can walk out on the coast."

She just watched him pace back and forth a little before he agreed.

"Okay, let's pack up some snacks and a small lunch and we'll head out," she said.

Oto was a little embarrassed, but he had to tell his sister before they headed out.

"I have to tell you that because of my new meds I have to pee like once an hour or even more often."

Eve, went back online and found a place where they could walk on the beach and still have a bathroom along the way.

After quickly packing up their lunch, Eve loaded up the car and they headed out.

The ride to the beach was only an hour, but Oto barely made it in time and had to run straight to the bathroom.

After returning to the car, Oto found his sister looking at a big picture of a map that showed various trails from the beach up into the woods that they could hike on.

"I thought we could hike a bit, instead of spending the day on the beach," she said.

Oto was always up for an adventure, so he quickly agreed, and off they went.

Oto had been “caged up” for those days at the hospital, but he had so much energy he had to just keep telling himself to slow down as he hiked a steep trail up a small mountain.

Oto told his sister some more stories that weren’t so carefully sanitized and the more they hiked the more he told her.

With each step up the mountain Eve got more and more worried about her brother.

She knew he had been manic and was taking his medication. She knew that because he showed her as he took them.

But after hearing more stories she began to get really worried. What would she do if he spiraled out, and what would that really mean?

She had read about Bipolar 1 and being manic, and she wasn’t sure how much of it was real, and if it even pertained to her brother.

That night Oto helped his sister barbecue some chicken breasts on the grill, and they talked about the great day they had hiking and he was happier than he could ever remember being.

“Oto, I want to take you on a longer trip tomorrow. Have you ever heard of the town of Forks up here in Washington?”

“No, I have never heard of that, but why do you ask?”

“It is where the Twilight series that was written by Stephenie Meyer was once filmed long ago. I think you will love it there,” she said.

Oto looked out the kitchen window and the clear blue sky.

“It sounds great to me. When do you want to leave?”

Oto helped his sister pack up a big lunch and snacks and plenty of water.

It wasn’t long before Oto and Eve were on their way, as she drove them toward Forks.

It took about two hours before they arrived.

On the way in to town they stopped at a beautiful waterfall, and they both just stood there taking in the beautiful nature in front of them.

“Oto, can I ask you something?”

“Sure, you know you can ask me anything.”

“Are you manic right now, and how did you end up in the last hospital?”

Oto tried to fight the tears back, but as he watched the water gurgling around him, all he could say as the tears flowed down his cheeks was, “I am really not sure, to be honest.”

They soon arrived in Forks and pulled up outside the tourist “shack,” but first he looked at the red truck that was parked nearby.

“Wow this is the actual truck used in the movies?” he said.

“Yes, isn’t it cool?”

They both looked around a bit more outside and then entered the small building.

Everywhere he looked, Oto could see everything Twilight-related.

He had actually watched all of the movies, and would freely admit that they were brilliantly made.

“Eve, let me get a photo of you here in this store.”

With that she posed for the camera and he took a few pictures on his phone.

They ate at the one main restaurant in town, which was an authentic Mexican food place.

Oto ordered two cheese enchiladas and a side of beans and rice. And he also ordered a Mexican Coke, his favorite drink besides water.

“Oto, I have a surprise for you. You of course have heard of Sasquatch, right?”

“Of course, who hasn’t?”

“Well, here in Forks is where that all started. They did it as a joke.”

“Did what as a joke?” he said.

The food arrived and Oto was starving so he dove right in, doing his best not to eat too quickly.

“Someone dressed up in a Sasquatch outfit that they made and walked through the woods as video was recorded.”

“Are you serious? Why have I never heard of this?”

After eating lunch, they walked over to another building and entered in.

Oto was spell-bound as he looked around the place.

The actual original “costume” was featured in the middle of the store, and it was huge. It must have been like eight or nine feet tall.

“This is what they originally made and filmed in?” he said.

“Yes, we have to get some photos together.”

There was a guy behind the cash register and counter that came over and took a few photos of them.

Oto had to piss really bad, so he asked if they had a bathroom.

“Sure, we have a bathroom but you have to buy something before you can use it,” the guy said.

Oto picked out a few magnets and a few other interesting trinkets and paid cash for them.

“Okay, here is the key,” the man said after Oto paid for them.

Oto thanked him and quickly went into the bathroom.

As he was peeing, he looked around the walls of the clean bathroom and saw all sorts of other trinkets, but one in particular caught his attention.

There was a pair of pink Sasquatch slippers with a \$500 price tag on them.

Oto laughed as he finished up and walked back out into the shop.

He had fifty cents left and in the back of the small building he found an old pin-ball machine.

Oto looked at the old pin-ball machine and couldn’t believe it, but it was the same type of one that he used to play so many years ago when he was in high school.

He laughed thinking back about how he must have put hundreds of dollars in quarters into it.

He went over to the man behind the counter and asked if it was okay if he played it.

“Well, as you can see, it is very old. You can play it but most of the bulbs are out, and even the high score doesn’t show all of the numbers.”

Oto put in the fifty cents and waited for the ball to pop up into play.

“Before you play, though, I have to tell you, this machine is old and so sometimes the ball gets stuck in a couple of places. When that happens just push the pin-ball machine a bit and the ball will fall back into play.”

It wasn't long before Oto was, almost like muscle memory, playing the game he loved back in high school. It was like a dream come true.

Sure, enough the ball got stuck so Oto picked up a corner and dropped hit, but he ended up tilting the machine.

The man working there ran over.

"What the hell are you doing? You are going to break it!"

Oto was surprised by the man's response.

"Well, it is the same pin-ball machine I played back in high school and the same thing would happen and you just have to lift up a corner of it and drop it. I guess I lifted it up a little too much."

The man asked him and Eve to leave the store and to not return.

After hanging out the rest of the afternoon and walking everywhere in the quaint old town of Forks, they drove back to Eve's place.

For the entire drive back they just laughed and talked about so many funny things they had experienced as they grew up together. They especially loved the stories about Ana, their mom.

"Oto, remember the time when mom left for the day and left Hanah in charge?"

How could they forget.

Their older sister Hanah went on a little power trip and started ordering them around, saying how they could clean this and that. She would then go to her room and listen to music.

Oto and Eve then did their own thing, not cleaning any of the house.

They got a call from mom, who said that she would be back in one hour.

"You guys need to quickly clean the house," Hanah said.

They both just laughed at her, telling her that she could clean it by herself.

Hanah had picked up the small plastic trash can from one of the bathrooms, throwing it with all of her might straight at Oto.

He quickly dodged it and laughed as it hit the dining room table and broke into several pieces.

Oto and Eve just laughed until they cried.

It must have been two nights later that the incident occurred that would change Oto and Eve's lives forever.

Oto was out in the trailer reading a book when the power went out and the heater shut off. It must have been 40 degrees, and Oto got nervous because he was already cold.

Even years later he tried to explain what happened next, but not even Eve could understand what happened.

For some reason the power going out triggered a response inside of him.

He ran out of the trailer and started running around trying to find out why the power had gone out and what he could do to get it back on.

It was dark, so he accidentally ran into a corner of the trailer, leaving a large gash in his arm.

Blood started flowing out from the wound, and he got really scared.

He just reacted and ran over and jumped a fence that divided Eve's property from her neighbor's house.

The light went on at the neighbor's house, and Oto got even more agitated.

The neighbor walked out his back door and yelled at Oto.

"I am sorry, I didn't mean to wake you up."

"Get the hell off my property before I shoot you. Who the hell are you?" the man said.

Oto jumped the fence to get back to his trailer.

The blood from the gash in his arm was now dripping off his elbow, and he started to feel dizzy.

He ran into Eve's house and sat down on her couch, dripping blood.

"Eve, I need help!!"

Oto laid down on the brown couch and then he blacked out.

Eve ran out of her bedroom, groggy from being yanked out of a deep sleep.

She ran out into the living room and saw her brother passed out on her couch, with blood slowly pooling up on her leather couch.

She ran and pulled her emergency kit out from underneath the sink in the bathroom and quickly took out gauze and tape.

She got back to her brother and started wrapping it around the gash in his arm.

She didn't really know what she was doing, but the blood stopped flowing and she shook Oto until he woke up.

“Oto, what the hell happened. Why are you bleeding all over my couch?”

Before Oto could respond there was a knock at the door.

Eve went over and answered it.

There was a sheriff standing on her front porch. He looked at Eve and asked about her brother.

“Is your brother here? Your neighbor almost shot him for being on his property and talking so fast that your neighbor couldn’t even understand him.”

Oto pulled himself off the couch and nearly collapsed on the floor.

He started pacing back and forth and was feeling the anxiety bubbling up in him and he wanted to just flee, to get out of there, but the sheriff was blocking the exit to the front door.

He then sat back down on the couch, trying his best to describe what had happened.

“Oto,” his sister said, “what is wrong with you?”

The sheriff had seen this type of thing before, and was positive that Eve’s brother was high on something.

He looked down at Oto before asking, “Son, do you know the difference between what is real and what isn’t?”

With that the sheriff touched the couch and asked Oto to do the same.

He did what he was asked to do.

“Son, do you feel the couch?”

Oto wanted to punch the large man in the face, but he instead just looked at him before saying, “Yes, of course I do.”

Oto stayed sitting on the couch and his sister went out the front door followed by the sheriff.

He couldn’t hear what they were saying, but from the sounds of it, he thought he heard the sheriff’s car driving away.

“Eve, I need help.”

She sprang into action, helping Oto to her car, grabbing her purse and keys and quickly locked the front door after helping him into her car.

“Oto, I have to get you to the nearby hospital and the sheriff is going to follow us to make sure we get you there quickly.”

He wasn’t sure how long the drive was, but he was blacking out and then coming back to.

The next thing he could remember was arriving at an emergency room and being pushed in a wheel chair to the inside of the hospital.

When Oto woke up, he found himself in a white room all alone.

He looked at his arm and he thought he saw stitches poking out from a bandage.

He slowly got down off the “bed,” screaming as loud as he could.

Eve rushed into the room. “What are you screaming about.”

“I won’t get locked up again, I just can’t. You don’t understand, they do horrible things to you and I will not go back.”

Eve calmed him down as a nurse came in the room.

She had some pills in her hand and asked Oto to take them.

“No, I refuse to take them.”

“Oto,” his sister said, “they will help stop the pain.”

The room was spinning around fast again and then it was just darkness.

Oto slipped in and out of consciousness throughout the day and night.

He was not allowed to leave the room he was in and he peed so much when he woke up now and then.

He filled the big read jug and the nurse had to empty it at least five times until the next morning arrived.

Eve was gone, and the nurse said she had to go back home, and that she wasn’t allowed to see him anyway.

Oto started yelling again, and it wasn’t long before several large male nurses entered the room.

They tried to be careful with him, given his wound, and they eventually all got him onto a gurney waiting out in the hall.

They strapped Oto down to it with the straps really tight.

This time there was no getting an arm out of the restraints, and he passed out again from the pain that seared through him.

When he woke up again, he found himself in the back of an ambulance and it was driving fast down a road to somewhere, he just didn't know where.

He decided to just relax, and do his best not to piss himself.

Looking out the back of the window in the ambulance, Oto could see that they were going at least 100 mph, based on the cars they were racing around.

Chapter 26: Strapped Down

The ambulance that was driving Oto to another hospital pulled up outside the back of the mental hospital.

He found himself strapped down, once again, on a gurney in the back of an ambulance.

The driver soon opened the back and lowered Oto to the ground, before pushing the gurney into some glass doors that were opened from inside the hospital.

He had to pee so bad, he thought he was going to just let loose on the gurney, but thought better of it.

He was locked into a small room that he found out later was called the intake room.

Oto was unstrapped and he sat up with pain searing in his arm.

He was escorted to a bathroom and he pissed for what seemed like two minutes.

After that he was walked into what Oto recognized as a ward in the hospital.

He was escorted into a room that had a long table in it with many chairs.

Up on the walls were all types of drawings, some in paint and others in crayon.

After what seemed like an hour or two a nurse walked in and told Oto to follow him.

They walked by a small room and Oto looked in, instantly recognizing a 4-point chair.

Just seeing it brought him back to when he was 17, and was locked up against his will and his good friend at the time, Ebb, was restrained in a 4-point bed many times.

The nurse who was checking Oto in looked up at him.

“So, why do you think you are here tonight with us, Oto?”

Oto just looked at the woman who was typing details about him into a computer.

“Well, I don’t really know. Did I do something wrong?”

“Hmm,” sighed the nurse. “If you had done something wrong you wouldn’t be here.”

It was late at night, that much Oto knew for sure.

He had seen stars when he was out on the gurney earlier.

Everyone on the ward seemed to be sleeping, and it was very quiet, almost comforting, except Oto knew what would be coming next.

The nurse had Oto follow her down the hall and asked him to follow her into a room.

The room wasn’t that dark since there are usually some lights that are never turned off.

“Oto, your roommate is named Kerek and he is fast asleep. Try to be quiet so you don’t wake him up,” she whispered.

She told him to quietly use the bathroom and then go to sleep in his bed that had a sheet and blanket on it.

Oto was exhausted so he did what she told him and quickly fell fast asleep.

Oto was ripped from a deep sleep at what turned out to be around 7 a.m. the next morning by a different nurse than the one that he saw the night before.

At first, he was confused about where he was at, and then he felt the pain in his arm and he looked over to see his new roommate still sound asleep.

It wasn’t long before he was also sitting up in his bed.

“Hello, I think your name is Kerek, at least that is what the nurse told me last night?”

“Yes, my last roommate was released yesterday. What is your name?”

Oto and Kerek talked for a bit before the nurse poked his head in from the open doorway.

“You both need to get showered and ready for breakfast,” he said.

Of course there was no door to the bathroom, and Oto let his roommate go first as he saw a paper bag with his name on it, along with a note.

The note said that he needed to place his clothes that he was wearing into the bag and put on his pants, shirt, paper-like underwear, and socks that he was all too familiar with.

It wasn't long before Kerek came out of the wet bathroom.

“Your turn,” he said.

Oto gathered up his new clothes and went to the bathroom.

He always thought it strange having to take a piss and a dump in front of others, but he was also used to that as well.

Luckily Kerek left everything clean for him. That of course wasn't always the case.

Oto knew he needed to hurry so he turned on the shower, only to find out that it was -warm water at best, and the stream of water was low-flow.

He just jumped in and quickly lathered up using his hands, using the paper cup that had some gel that he knew as both soap and shampoo.

He dried off and picked up his now wet clothes that he had been wearing and put on his new ones.

Unfortunately, as he would later find out, they only had medium-sized pants that he pulled over the paper-like underwear that he was now wearing.

Given how the pants would just fall down, he came up with what he thought was a great idea.

He put some water on the waist-band and then twisted the fabric into a make-shift knot and then he was good to go.

After breakfast and hanging out with Kerek, Oto had plenty of time before it was time for group therapy.

Kerek was working on a puzzle at a table and Oto decided to join him.

“Hey there, Oto. Want to help me out with this puzzle?”

“Sure thing, it looks like you have made a lot of progress on it. only It looks like a couple dozen more pieces and it will be wrapped up.”

Oto found one or two pieces, but Kerek finished the rest, except at the very end there was one puzzle piece missing.

“Damn,” Kerek said. “This always happens, you put together a puzzle in this place and then at the end there are one or two pieces missing.”

They both searched everywhere, but couldn’t find it, so they just got up and returned to their room to kill some more time.

Oto sat down on his bed and Kerek sat on his.

“So,” Oto said, “What did you do to land yourself in this place?”

Kerek showed him the loose bandage that covered his forearm.

“It is a long story.”

Oto just waited for Kerek to go on.

“Well, believe it or not I was discharged from the Navy a couple of years ago.”

Oto was intrigued by this and asked him a few questions about the Navy and if he had been deployed or not.

“Well, I was on a big carrier over in the Gulf during the war in Iraq.”

“Wow, no shit?” Oto said.

“Yeah, I was actually there for the initial blitz when we bombed the hell out of them.”

Oto watched Kerek move around the bandage on his forearm and noticed for the first time that there seemed to be dried blood on it.

Kerek continued. “I was dealing with top secret messages and coordinating the strikes in the middle of the night.”

Kerek stood up for a minute, stretched, and then sat back down on his bed.

“I was discharged and have been at home with my parents for the last year or so.”

Kerek explained that he was having a tough time at home, not because his parents were mean or anything, he was just haunted by things he had done on that carrier.

“It was late one night and I was alone in my room. I just wanted to make the nightmares to stop.”

Oto was afraid he knew what was coming next.

“I used an X-acto knife, and just closed my eyes and plunged it into my forearm and was cutting back and forth before I passed out.”

Kerek stood up and paced around the room for a while, as Oto just looked down at the ground.

“I woke up in an emergency room hospital with staples, glue and stitches in my forearm.”

Kerek explained how it was his dad that had found him in his room.

Before they had time to talk any further a nurse walked in and said it was time for group therapy.

After an hour-long session of group therapy, where Oto didn't say anything the whole time, he returned to the “puzzle” table that they had been at before.

Kerek dumped out the pieces to a new 500-piece puzzle and started sorting them.

In the background was a TV blaring.

Oto couldn't help but watch it as he helped Kerek search for the straight pieces of the puzzle.

Oto did both this for a couple of hours, and the shows he later watched were disturbing.

One of them was all about border crossings and the countless ways that those who wanted to come into the US smuggled drugs in every which way possible.

That show wasn't too bad, but the other one he couldn't watch. It was about a phantom spirit that was raping women.

Chapter 27: Level Up

Oto later found out that there were four different floors in the mental hospital he found himself confined in.

He was on level four, but he eventually talked to someone on level one and they said on that floor they have the most space and fewer restrictions.

Of course, he wanted to get to level one and he was told that the way to do that was to participate in group therapy sessions, and all other classes.

He was really bored so he was doing that anyway.

The main problem, besides the loud TV, was that all four floors in the hospital were served the same food.

But by the time it got down to level four, it was cold, and almost inedible.

Oto found the TV blaring at a high volume most of the day, which was distracting, to say the least.

It reminded him of one of the hospitals he had been confined in before.

There it was a reward to watch television. But when he watched the Super Bowl weeks ago on their TV, there was no volume.

He preferred that to the current situation.

Oto was pretty sure it was the morning of the third day when a nurse said to follow her because he was moving to level one, but that meant he had to leave his roommate Kerek behind.

He really didn't have a choice, so he took the elevator with the nurse and found himself on the top floor.

It was amazing, and was at least ten times the size as the main room in level four.

He had the freedom to walk around and drink red, or blue punch, and have snacks whenever he wanted them.

The snacks were mostly salty chips, which would make him drink even more red and blue punch.

Oto, who was outgoing, quickly made friends with people on level one.

He was the only patient who had Bipolar 1 disorder, and the rest of the patients had Bipolar 2 disorder.

Still, he quickly bonded with one man named Pip.

Due to him having Bipolar 2, he would stay up late at night.

The rules were that you had to be in your room by 10 o'clock at night.

Oto felt that his medication was starting to help him, but Pip couldn't work with his psychiatrist to get the right combination of the right meds.

Oto's new roommate slept for twenty-three hours straight because he was detoxing from some heavy-duty drugs.

This wasn't a problem, but when Oto tried to go to sleep, his roommate seemed to be having night terrors and would scream out and thrash around on his bed.

Since there was no way he could sleep, Oto stayed out past ten o'clock with Pip, and they talked about religion and any other subject that came up.

He was very religious and read the Bible every afternoon right after lunch.

Because they both refused to go back to their rooms at ten o'clock, a head nurse from level three was called up.

The nurse was visibly upset when he showed up.

He ended up, however, on letting them stay up in the main, shared room, as long as they were quiet.

Oto stayed awake without sleep that night, and in the morning other patients came out and joined him, at a big table.

The chairs were so heavy that they were very hard to move, and Oto was so focused on a puzzle he was putting together that he kept banging his shins on the chair.

He first noticed that his shins were bleeding a little bit, but not enough to have to deal with that.

As he moved more and more puzzle pieces around and found the right place for them, the more he hurt his shins.

They seemed to be not only a little bloody, but actually bruised.

Many months later the bruises were still there, and it seemed like the bones were bruised, at least the bruising didn't go away.

The following night, Oto finally got some sleep, because he shared a room with a new roommate who was also detoxing.

The new roommate in the new room slept almost all of the time, but he had no night terrors, so it was fine.

During the day he would look out the window and watch a couple of crows fly and land in the nearby tall trees.

He thought back to when he was on suicide watch months ago and just like this time, he couldn't hear the crows, but he could of course see them flying around.

For some reason they comforted him.

Pip was reading his Bible, so he went over and sat across from him.

He eventually stopped reading and told Oto about how he had friends on the "outside," and they had money and were interested in trying to reform the mental health system.

Oto didn't know anything about that, but he did know that he had never truly received any help in the six hospitals, even if you counted this one.

Pip went back to reading, and Oto walked back over to the table, and began working on his puzzle again.

A patient with schizophrenia began hitting himself in the face and screaming out loud.

Oto looked over at him, and felt sorry for him.

A nurse behind the front desk, must have felt differently, though because he went to the med station and pulled out a needle with a syringe.

Oto saw him insert the needle into a small bottle with a clear liquid in it, pulling it into the syringe.

He then quickly walked over to the man who was yelling and hitting himself.

Without hesitating, the nurse plunged the needle into the patient's neck and emptied the liquid into him.

After a few minutes he stopped yelling, and then eventually, after that he calmed down.

Chapter 28: Hitchhiker

Oto woke up and he could tell by looking out his window that it was still sometime in the middle of the night.

He looked over at his new roommate who had been asleep for most of the day and now night.

Oto didn't mind, though, because he could at least sleep.

He still of course had to share a toilet, and from outside in the hallway when waiting in line to go to the cafeteria, anyone in the hallway could look in and see him relieving himself.

For some reason this toilet had no seat on it, and his new roommate would leave piss and shit on the non-lid toilet that he had to first clean up with toilet paper before using it.

On level one, that he somehow managed to get to, he thought back to his days playing The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy.

That's what it felt like going from level four now to level one.

But here at least they get to go to the cafeteria and eat the starchy and pasty food warm, which is of course way better than eating it cold down on level four.

In order to go to the cafeteria, escorted by two to three nurses, you must have a laminated piece of paper with your name and other information on it.

One essential element on this paper is a photo.

For some reason Oto's photo never showed up on his paper, and for dietary restrictions it just said allergic to sesame seeds.

Oto wished that those seeds were the only thing he couldn't eat.

Even on level one, there were always new puzzles being worked on.

He was more careful about not banging up his shins when helping put them together.

Another thing they could do was to play cards to help pass the time.

They actually had Uno, the card game, and he had fun playing that with the other patients on the ward.

They also had a pack of playing cards, and they would also play rummy.

Oto never knew there were so many different types of rules for different rummy games, but it certainly helped the time go by.

While playing card games, Oto thought back to when he was eleven-years-old and he was working for his grandpa over the summer.

That is when he learned how to play his grandma and grandpa's version of rummy, and at the time he had no idea there were other types.

These were the same grandparents that got him to take the Zyprexa when he was seventeen and his sister Hanah had "tricked" him.

That was how he ended up being locked up in the second mental hospital that he was later released from since he turned eighteen, and by law they had no choice.

Later that afternoon Oto, Pip, and others were told by the head nurse that they could go outside for one hour.

Oto was so happy that he could barely contain himself.

Like everything, they had to line up like in kindergarten, escorted by several nurses, until they made it through the maze of doors and found themselves suddenly outside in the bright sunlight.

There was black chalk boards on the twenty-foot walls.

Oto picked up a big pink piece of chalk and wrote in large words: "Oto was here."

Pip found two pickle ball paddles and he walked over to Oto.

"Hey, are you brave enough to play a little pickle ball with me?"

Oto leapt at the chance to play some pickle ball, but the problem was that there was no net, and he had no idea how to play pickle ball.

"Pip, how can we possibly play without a net?"

Pip just pointed to his head, "Come on, just pretend you see a net in your mind."

Oto laughed out loud, and nodded in agreement.

Oto and Pip begin playing with no net, without keeping score.

They were both just loving the feeling of the hot sun burning into their skin.

“Slowing down is the hardest thing in the world for me to do,” Oto thought to himself.

He later couldn’t believe he did it, but he hit the pickle ball so hard with his paddle that the ball hit Pip right in the face.

“Oh, my God, Pip. I am so sorry, can you forgive me?”

Without hesitating he served the ball right at Oto, but he dodged the ball at the last minute and then turned and hit the ball so hard that it went flying over the 20-foot wall that enclosed them.

Later in his room, Oto just looked at his sleeping roommate who was snoring.

He walked over to the large window and looked outside.

He saw an ambulance without the sirens on pull up outside.

From up on level one, the ambulance driver who hopped out of the “truck” looked so small.

“Hmm,” he thought, more fresh meat I suppose.

Oto thought back too many years before, when his biological father was still alive and before he drank himself to death.

It was one of those “magical” memories that he had. It now seemed more like a dream.

His dad had showed him a “dune-buggy” that he had built, especially the engine, which was his specialty.

“Come on, son. I want to see if you have race car driving reflexes.”

It wasn’t often that he spent any time with his dad, and he could only recall a few times that his dad had ever even called him son.

His dad let Oto drive the dune-buggy out into the Arizona summer heat.

“Go for it, but just watch for cops, because we aren’t supposed to be out here like this,” he said.

Oto had punched it and was soon sliding around in the desert sand going roughly fifty-five mph.

He saw a cop car out of the corner of his left eye, so he downshifted and circled back to where his dad was standing.

The only problem was that he had “blown” the transmission up when downshifting.

“That is okay, son, I had a feeling all along that you had them. You certainly have race car driving reflexes.

Oto had felt so proud at that very moment.

There were so many art classes that Oto couldn’t even count how many he had participated in during the days that he was locked up in on level one.

He thought it was so ridiculous that next to his name, after he was given a red crayon, that on a piece of paper in front of the nurse it would say, “Oto, one red crayon.”

He was able to “check out” some glue and some tissue paper, since they were being shown how to make “artificial” roses.

Still, it was better than out in the main ward, where they played cards, and where they only had sheets of paper with Disney characters on them.

And out there they could only use one crayon at a time as well.

Oto looked forward to walking up and down the hallway with Pip.

It was like the bigger, more impressive, version of being locked up in a cell in prison and pacing the floor.

Still, it allowed them both to get a little exercise.

Of course they weren’t supposed to really be talking when taking these “walks.”

Still, it lessened the boredom and anxiety that Oto felt.

And it beat spending all of his time with cards, puzzles, and Disney characters on paper.

That afternoon after their “walk,” Pip wasn’t paying attention and hit his foot on one of the heavy chairs in the main ward that seemed like they were glued to the ground.

Pip, this time, though really hit his ankle hard and yelled out.

He collapsed to the floor, and the nurses came running and asked for everyone to give them space.

Oto saw how his ankle was already the size of a baseball and looked bright red.

The nurses lifted him up, taking him to the same room where they were forced, standing in line, to take their meds and lift their tongue to show they had not pretended to swallow them.

He wasn’t told how Pip was doing, but he was confined to his room and was told later by his roommate that he was in bed sleeping with his foot raised up on a few flat pillows with ice packs on his swollen ankle.

Oto was worried about Pip, and he decided to go back to his room to look out the big window again.

Seeing the crows flying around for some reason helped him recall another memory of his biological father.

He was still living in his apartment for at least a year before being locked up in this hospital.

His dad’s sister had called him, telling Oto that his dad maybe had a week left to live, if that.

He immediately hopped on a plane and flew out to the Arizona desert.

He had taken a taxi to the giant hospital where his dad was at.

He walked up to the room he was in and saw a nurse outside his room watching all of his vitals on a computer screen.

She glanced over at Oto, telling him he could go in and see his dad.

She had to monitor two patients at once, with two different monitors, because they were so close to dying.

Oto slowly walked in, finding that his dad was sitting up in bed.

“Son, shit, if you are here that means I only have a couple of days left alive.”

Oto went over and took his dad’s hand in his and just stared into his eyes.

“Son,” he said, “if I knew you were coming, I would have done something with my hair.”

His dad moved a blanket near his hand and Oto stayed with him for two hours.

They talked about the few times when they had spent a week here and there, hanging out together.

It was eventually time to leave and Oto reassured his dad that he would be back to see him soon.

But some last-minute work emergencies came up, so Oto had to fly back to his apartment in California.

He knew that would be the last time he would see his dad, because he wouldn't be attending his funeral.

Oto had to walk away from the 500-piece puzzle that he had been working on for hours, feeling the anxiety bubble up inside of him.

He was so thirsty with the new “cocktail” of Lamictal and Zyprexa that he was on.

No matter how much red or blue punch that he drank he was still always thirsty.

He was bored out of his mind and felt like running down the hall to try and escape.

He of course knew that long before he made it to the first of like five locked doors he would be caught by nurses and most likely confined back in level four.

He went to the nurse's station and asked for blue punch this time.

“Sorry, Oto, you have to save some for the other patients, so I can't let you have any more punch for at least two hours from now.

Chapter 29: Medication

Oto was forced to take Lamictal, Zyprexa, Vitamin D and some other drug that he had no idea what it was called.

He had a psychiatrist who was monitoring these drugs and the dosages, but nothing seemed to really be working for him.

He was told he was manic, but in his experience, he really had no idea what that meant, because he just felt the high.

This is what they call a manic episode, his psychiatrist would say.

The only thing he really knew for sure was that when the Lamictal and the Zyprexa, which he was forced to take before bed time, would make him really sleepy.

He was told that this combination is what allowed him to stop his thoughts from racing.

The next morning he was told by the head nurse that he needed to go into what she said was the intake room.

What Oto now realized that this meant that a “bed” was open, because a patient had moved on, and now the ambulance could bring in what he called fresh meat.

Oto was waiting in the intake room waiting for a psychologist to join him.

She finally did and explained to Oto that she wanted to have him take an IQ test.

She gave Oto a blank piece of paper and was told to fold it anyway he felt like doing.

He folded it perfectly in half and then folded that in half, so the result, once he unfolded it was to have four equal “squares.”

He was then given a pen and told to draw a square.

Oto folded the paper in half and then used the middle, where the other mark was, to draw two different squares.

He then handed the paper back to the psychologist and she folded the paper in a different way and held it up to the light, and she could see no difference.

This is a standard way of testing a person’s IQ.

She didn’t say anything, but Oto knew that he tested off the charts, meaning that his IQ was so high, that they felt they had to assign the top number to it.

Oto just smiled, because the first time he was given this test he was 17, and once you do the test once, the gig is up.

Later that same day Oto had to go back into the empty intake room, but this time a dietician met him at the same table.

She had a booklet filled with all sorts of information about what he should and shouldn’t eat.

She explained that if Oto made a fist, that was the maximum amount of a protein that he could eat each day.

He was told that things like chicken, pork, and turkey, which he could eat, were good sources of protein.

He just laughed to himself, because if the cafeteria was giving him that option then they were failing miserably.

Oto was so “good” that he earned the privilege of being able to use a phone that was out in the open so everyone could hear every word.

But he didn’t mind because that meant that he could call his brother Kanak, who lived in Texas.

Although his sister lived in Washington, she couldn’t really have him stay with her anymore.

Oto didn’t understand that, but since Kanak was on the list of people he could call, the head nurse would first make the call and then signal Oto to an empty phone.

There were actually two phones, but again they were out in the open.

Oto was so glad that he could talk on the phone with his brother.

“Kanak, I think I may be let out of here soon.”

“Are you sure, Kanak, I was not told this.”

Oto listened to his brother trying to decide whether or not to tell him what his good friend Pip had told him on one of their walks together.

“Kanak, the way you get out of here is to convince your psychiatrist to have you meet with a lawyer who represents you, another lawyer who doesn’t, and a judge to make a ruling whether or not you can leave or not.”

Oto could tell that Kanak didn’t really believe him, but Kanak asked if he wanted to come and stay with him in Texas for a while.

Oto wasn’t sure what other options he had, so he agreed to that plan.

The next day Oto was set to have his virtual “trial,” where he would be having a Zoom call with the two lawyers and the judge.

He was told that it would happen sometime between two p.m. and four p.m.

Oto watched the clock above the nurse's station closely, because he couldn't wait to get out of this hospital where he was locked up like a convict.

In a way, though, Oto felt like it was worse than a convict, because even though he was wearing what was standard issue garb as what he would wear if he was in prison, in here they messed with your mind.

He thought about this as he played cards with Pip, but at the same time was watching the clock out of the corner of his eye.

Oto began to think about another time with his dad, and he was out hunting with him in the woods that was hours away from the desert where he lived.

His dad had two compound bows and they were out hunting for deer.

They had a permit that legally allowed this, but it still seemed strange to Oto.

After about an hour of walking around the woods, his dad told him to be quiet.

Oto looked ahead around a tree and saw the rack of what turned out to be a five-point buck.

His dad had not spotted the deer, but Oto took the arrow and pulled back with all his might like his dad had showed him.

At first nothing happened but then it went past the "breaking" point and was easy to adjust.

Oto took aim at the neck of the buck, and let the arrow fly.

It went straight into the neck of the deer, and he fell to the ground, and was still breathing.

Oto didn't know what to do and neither did his dad, because he had never even hit a deer with an arrow.

Oto now turned to look at the clock and it was only 3:30, so he knew he would most likely be called in like 15 minutes, so since nobody was around, he played solitaire with the cards to pass the time.

His grandma and grandpa had shown him all those summers ago how to play the game.

He loved it, and it always relaxed him.

They taught him the Vegas style of solitaire, a betting version of the game.

You still laid out the cards in seven spots, adding a card each time so that the last card had more cards underneath the face card.

Each card that you scored and placed above the row of the main cards was worth \$5.00 dollars.

Since there are of course 52 cards in a full deck you have to first pay \$1.00 for each card.

So, if you do the math, in order to not lose money on each game you have to get at least eleven cards up as points.

Oto looked one more time and saw that it was 3:45 and he began to get nervous.

It was late one night about six months before his Mexican Coke helped land him in the last hospital that he had been confined again against his will.

He was driving his blue Jetta at about 45 mph, but it was really dark and as he rounded the sharp turn that he had taken so many times before, he saw two deer running straight at him.

Oto just reacted, and in a split second he swerved around the first deer, but the second one slammed into the left front side of his car.

He pulled off the road and got out of his car, seeing the smashed side of his car.

He was able to still drive home, but before doing that he looked around for both deer, but he couldn't see either of them.

He thought bad about hitting the one deer, but there was nothing he could do.

The next morning he called his insurance company who came out and took a photo and told him the auto body shop that he could call up and get his car fixed at.

Chapter 30: Rubiks Cube

Oto put the cards down and noticed that it was 3:55 p.m. and now he was panicking, because he knew that he would have to spend at least another week locked away.

He had to think fast, so he went over to the head nurse and said if he didn't get his "trial" that he would stop eating, and he said it wouldn't be hard to get the rest of the patients on the ward to do the same thing.

Before he knew it, he was being escorted into one of the group therapy rooms.

A nurse was sitting at a table looking at a laptop and she instructed him to sit down across from him.

Sure enough, she explained how there was a judge and the two lawyers and it was on Zoom, but it was really a court and the two lawyers would state their arguments before the judge made a ruling.

“Oto, you have to stay in the frame of the screen. If you move outside of the monitor then this trial will end and you will have no recourse.

“Sure, I understand,” he said.

The trial seemed to be going well, but then the low battery light started flashing on the screen.

The nurse was shocked and she turned the laptop away from him to quickly plug the laptop in.

It was only a few seconds, and she had to explain what happened so the trial was able to continue.

The trial then continued and although it was only 4:10 p.m. the judge said the magical words.

“Oto, you are free to go.”

Oto went into his room with the sleeping roommate.

He undressed, leaving all of his clothes, including the paper-like underwear on the floor and looked inside the bag that had his street clothes.

Again, he was surprised that his wallet, belt, and cell phone were all in the bag.

He quickly pulled on his street clothes and felt whole again.

Even though the clothes had been washed in the hospital, and smelled strange, he welcomed them as if they were old friends.

Once dressed Oto was escorted out of his room.

He was able to wait at the main table that had both hurt him and helped him.

Pip was sitting there working on another puzzle.

“Well, he said, you are obviously leaving, but I have another week in here.”

Oto felt his anxiety bubbling up again.

“I am sorry Pip. I know I will never see you again, but I want to thank you for everything. Good luck, I am sure you will figure it out.”

Pip just stared at Oto with what looked like sadness mixed with envy.

At least that is what came to Oto looking at him, giving him a fist bump.

He then left the table, never looking back, and followed the nurse through the long maze of locked and unlocked doors.

Of course it was the nurse with a key that was making this all happen.

Oto felt guilty, but at the same time he was relieved and so excited to leave the hospital that had confined him for a week of his life.

As soon as he is let out into the bright sunlight of the Washington state afternoon, he had trouble seeing anything at first.

But he did see his sister Eve.

She was standing there with a big smile on her face.

“Well, brother, you did it. I knew you would.”

“How did you get here so fast, sister?”

“They called me of course.”

Although Eve picked him up, she explained to Oto how she was driving him straight to the airport so he could fly out and get picked up in Texas.

She had packed his bags in advance and had them in her car.

Oto was actually really excited to stay with his brother Kanak.

The last time they had lived together was decades before when they both worked at Greyhound together.

Eve and Oto talked a lot on the long drive to the airport.

They talked mostly about the walks and hikes that they took.

“Eve, don’t worry, I know it doesn’t make sense for me to go back to your place.”

Eve kept her eyes on the road in front of her, without looking over at her brother.

They were both crying at this point.

“Brother, I am sorry, I just can’t have you stay with me.”

“It is okay, you have helped me so much, and I don’t want you to be upset.”

Eve just wiped away her tears at the same time that Oto did with his own tears.

“Sister, I am being totally serious. You spent all of that time with me and we had grand adventures.”

“Eve, don’t you know that by telling me all of the stories the last 23 years of my life, you helped fill in the gaps of my missing memories.”

Oto looked over at Eve, and this time she did quickly look over at her brother before looking back at the road in front of her.

“Oto, I hope that is true. I feel, to be honest, that I have failed you.”

Oto reached over and put his hand on her shoulder.

“Sister, without you I maybe never would have recovered the memories that I lost.”

It wasn’t long before they were parked at the departure gate.

They both just looked at each other before Eve gave him his two bags that were so small that they were carry-ons.

What he was carrying were the only possessions he had now in life.

“Haha,” he said, “at least I can travel light.”

They both laughed and hugged for a long time.

“Okay, don’t worry, my sister, we will see each other again someday.”

“Brother, I know.”

Oto left her on the curb and watched as she climbed back into her car and pulled away.

“Well,” he said to himself, “I am on my own again, at least for now.”

Oto walked into the busy airport, walking toward the security line.

It wasn’t long before he got through the line and the X-Ray and search.

He always seemed to be singled out for the pat-down.

Just like the mental hospital that he had left, he was used to it.

After being strip-searched, a pat-down seemed normal to him.

Pissing and shitting in front of all of the patients and nurses on the ward he had just “escaped” from, was also something he had gotten used to.

He walked slowly to his gate, because he had at least two hours to kill.

He sat down on an empty row of plastic chairs that reminded him of the Greyhound depot so long ago.

He knew he would have great talks with his brother in Texas, and he was looking forward to it.

But his thoughts didn’t return to the Greyhound memories, but instead he thought of the trip from Georgia to California when he was eleven-years-old, and his stepdad had slammed his plane into the ground.

Oto thought often about how he still believed it was suicide but Eve tried to convince him on one of their walks that he was just exhausted.

Oto had plenty of time to kill, so he opened his main bag and found the Rubik’s cube that he had purchased long ago when he was at his apartment.

He picked it up out of his bag and spun the squares around, but try as best he could, he had never been able to solve it like he had when he was 11 in that car his mom Ana was driving him in so many decades before.

Before discarding it and putting it back into his bag he laughed as a random thought came to him.

“Hmm,” he thought, “I have an idea of how to solve it.”

He grabbed a jacket from inside his bag and put it on his lap.

He then took the Rubik’s cube and pulled with all of his might on one of the corners.

Sue enough the piece popped out.

He did the same thing with all of the other squares that would come lose.

He then sorted them all out on the jacket, which wasn’t easy.

He laughed to himself and pictured himself spinning a bunch of plates, doing his best to not drop any of them.

He then managed to put all of the 3-D squares back together in perfect order arranged by color.

He looked at the Rubik's cube that he had now solved.

He put it back into his bag, because it was now time to board the plane.

Without looking back he boarded the plane, eager to head out to Texas to hang out with his brother.

He had no idea how long he would be there, but right now he had to just go and find his seat on the plane.